UMEÅ SCHOOL OF BUSINESS,
ECONOMICS AND STATISTICS
UMEÅ UNIVERSITY



Achieving continuous growth through entrepreneurial ecosystem interplay

Perspectives of Entrepreneurs, Investors & Innovation Support System

Fanny Bölja & Agnes Öhrn

Department of Business Administration
International Business Program & Civilekonomprogrammet
Degree Project, 30 credits, 2026
Supervisor: Vladimir Vanyushyn

[This page was intentionally left blank]

Acknowledgements

The authors would like to express their gratitude to everyone who has contributed to the completion of this thesis.

First, we would like to thank our supervisor Vladimir Vanyushyn for valuable guidance and support through the whole research process. Your constructive feedback and insights have shaped the direction and quality of this study.

Gratitude goes out to all respondents who generously shared their time, experience and perspectives. Your openness and willingness to participate made this research possible. We hope to be able to contribute to your future work through the findings and conclusions of this thesis.

We further thank our classmates for insightful discussions and encouragement throughout the writing process. And a special thank you to our respective families and friends for showing patience and support through this journey.

Finally, we would like to acknowledge each other for strong collaboration, support and commitment in completing this thesis.



Fanny Bölja

2026-05-25



Agnes Öhrn

2026-05-25

[This page was intentionally left blank]

Abstract

The entrepreneurial ecosystem is a complex web of actors, all working alongside each other in encouraging entrepreneurship and innovation. This thesis explores how the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and actors within the innovation support system enables continuous growth in new ventures in Sweden. While existing research on entrepreneurial growth mainly focuses on individual actors, this study adopts an ecosystem perspective to better understand how growth is shaped through the interactions between the three stakeholder groups - entrepreneurs, support systems, and investors.

A qualitative research design was adopted through twelve semi-structured interviews with entrepreneurs, investors and innovation support actors, encompassing close to thirteen hours of interview data, across three different regions in Sweden. Using triangulation, guided by the Triple Helix model, the study applies the Gioia methodology to analyze how the relationships and interactions among the representative of the three groups influence the process of achieving long-term growth.

The findings of the study demonstrate that continuous growth is not an outcome of isolated actors' actions but instead is based a relational and dynamic process emerging through the interplay between stakeholders. Growth is enabled when financial resources, social capabilities, and knowledge sharing are effectively allocated and mobilized through strong relationships. Stakeholders must align their expectations and time horizons to make growth possible. Misalignments and conflicting priorities create tensions that constrain growth. The study further shows that continuous growth is more non-linear than previously described.

The Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem provides enabling conditions for achieving growth by facilitating access to funding, support infrastructures and collaborative networks. However, complexity, fragmentation and widespread competition within the system also creates challenges in navigating and aligning stakeholders effectively.

Continuous growth is not achieved by eliminating tensions, but by managing and navigating them over time. By integrating multiple stakeholder perspectives, this study contributes to a more holistic understanding of continuous growth as a relational and ecosystem embedded process.

Keywords: Continuous growth, Entrepreneurial Ecosystem, Triple Helix, Entrepreneurs, Investors, Innovation Support System, Triangulation, Swedish Innovation Ecosystem

[This page was intentionally left blank]

Table of Contents

1. INTRODUCTION 1
   1.1 Problem Background 1
   1.2 The Current Startup Environment in Sweden More connections to Sweden 1
   1.3 Research Gap 3
   1.4 Research Question 4
      1.4.1 Thesis Purpose 4
   1.5 Delimitations 4
2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK 6
   2.1 Entrepreneurial Growth 6
      2.1.1 Current Research on Entrepreneurial Growth 6
      2.1.2 Drivers behind Growth 7
      2.1.3 Measurements of Growth 8
      2.1.4 Models to Visualize Growth 9
   2.2 Entrepreneurial Ecosystems 13
   2.3 Triple Helix Model 13
      2.3.1 The Triple Helix within Entrepreneurial Ecosystems 14
   2.4 The Entrepreneur 15
      2.4.1 Entrepreneurs in Sweden 16
   2.5 The Investor 17
      2.5.1 The Investor Ecosystem in Sweden 18
   2.6 Innovation Support System 19
      2.6.1 The Swedish Innovation Support System 20
3. SCIENTIFIC METHODOLOGY 21
   3.1 Preunderstanding, Prior Experience and Choice of Topic 21
   3.2 Research Philosophy 22
      3.2.1 Ontological Considerations 23
      3.2.2 Epistemological Considerations 23
      3.2.3 Axiology 24
   3.3 Research Approach 24
      3.3.1 Choice of Research Approach 25
   3.4 Literature Search 25

4. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY 27
4.1 Research Design 27
4.1.1 Research Strategy 27
4.1.2 Research Method 27
4.1.3 Triangulation 28
4.1.4 Semi-structured Interviews 29
4.2 Data Collection 29
4.2.1 Data Selection and Sampling 30
4.2.2 Interview Guide Include English interview guide and refer to appendix for the Swedish 31
4.2.3 Interview Process 33
4.3 Data Analysis 33
4.3.1 Gioia Methodology Explain why this method was used and the benefits of this method for this thesis 33
4.3.2 Concepts, Themes and Aggregated Dimensions 34
4.4 Research Quality 35
4.5 Ethical Considerations 36
4.6 Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) 37
5. EMPIRICAL FINDINGS AND ANALYSIS 38
5.1 Identified Concepts, Themes and Aggregated Dimensions 38
5.2 Data Presentation 43
5.2.1 What is Growth? 43
5.2.2 Differences in Short-term and Long-term Growth 44
5.2.3 Challenges of Growth 45
5.2.4 Importance of Network and Relations 46
5.2.5 The Role of the Entrepreneur 47
5.2.6 The Role of the Investor 49
5.2.7 The Role of the Innovation Support System 50
5.2.8 Changes to the Ecosystem to Enable and Support Growth 53
5.3 Regional Differences 54
5.3.1 East 54
5.3.2 South/West 55
5.3.3 North 55

6. DISCUSSION 57
6.1 Thematic Interpretation of Growth Dynamics 57
6.1.1 Evolution of Conceptualization of Continuous Growth 57
6.1.2 Relationships and Networks for Enabling Growth 58
6.1.3 Constraints and Tensions to Shaping Continuous Growth 58
6.1.4 Capabilities and System Conditions for Growth 59
6.1.5 Ecosystem Improvements 60
6.2 Regional Differences and Similarities 61
6.3 Conceptual Framework of Continuous Growth 62
7. CONCLUSION 64
7.1 Revisit Research Question and Purpose, and Key Findings 64
7.1.1 Summary of Key Findings 64
7.1.2 Answering the Research Question 65
7.2 Contributions to Theory 65
7.3 Contributions to Practice What could each stakeholder group do? 65
7.4 Societal and Ethical Implications 66
7.5 Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research Look for limitations? 67
References: 69
Appendix 74
Appendix 1: Interview Guide Swedish 74
Appendix 2: Data Analysis of Entrepreneurs 75
Appendix 3: Data Analysis of Investors 79
Appendix 4: Data Analysis of Innovation Support System Actors 83

List of Figures

Figure 1. The Five Phases of Growth 11
Figure 2. Growth Stages 12
Figure 3. A differentiated Triple Helix with dynamic overlay 14
Figure 4. The Entrepreneurial Perspective - Data Structure 39
Figure 5. The Investor Perspective - Data Structure 40
Figure 6. The Innovation Support System Perspective – Data Structure 41
Figure 7. Summarized Aggregated Dimensions – Data Structure 42
Figure 8. Conceptual Framework of growth in the Swedish Entrepreneurial Ecosystem 63

List of Tables

Table 1. Data Collection Summary 30
Table 2. Interview Guide in English 31

1. INTRODUCTION

The introductory chapter outlines the problem background and further introduces the research gap, the purpose of the study, and the research question. It begins by providing an insight into the current state of the research topic, followed by deeper insights into more specific areas.

1.1 Problem Background

In the contemporary global economy, innovation and entrepreneurship are recognized as the primary engines of socioeconomic development, competitive advantage, and job creation. Governments and private investors worldwide have poured huge resources into the "zero to one" phase of business creation, leading to a surge in new ventures formations. While many ventures pursue growth, only a small percentage undergo substantial transitions associated with scaling, and some may never reach the stage of continuous growth (Genedy et al,. 2024). This aligns with research suggesting that while many firms experience periods of growth, only a very small proportion can manage growth over time and keep it continuous (Freel & Gordon, 2022, p. 684). This phenomenon, frequently referred to as the "scale-up gap", suggests that the competencies required to launch a startup are fundamentally different from those required to sustain and grow over time. According to the European Investment Bank (2024), while financial market constraints and a lack of late-stage venture capital often hold back innovative firms. The struggle for continuous growth is as much an internal organizational challenge as it is an external economic one.

The transition from a nascent, founder-led startup to scalable enterprise is fraught with structural and leadership obstacles. McKinsey & Company (2025) identifies this as the "scale-up conundrum" where firms must undergo a painful evolution from the informal and charismatic leadership of a founder to a more industrialized, process-driven management style. When this evolution fails to occur, the venture often hits an "organizational ceiling" where complexity outpaces the founder's ability to micromanage. This is further increased by a "core competency deficit" where the initial team may possess technical brilliance but lacks the essential behavioral traits. More specifically, systematic information-seeking and a sophisticated customer service orientation that are vital for navigating the maturity phase of a business (Szathmári et al., 2024).

The primary driver of this failure is the paradox of "premature scaling". Research indicates that approximately 70% of startups fail because they attempt to grow their customer base or team before they have solidified their underlying business model or unit economics (Startup Genome Report, 2025). This misalignment between organizational maturity and market expansion creates a "leaky bucket" effect, where capital is consumed at a rate that the firm´s internal infrastructure cannot support. Despite the wealth of research on individual barriers, current academic perspectives remain somewhat fragmented. Existing literature often focuses narrowly on either financial constraint, leadership psychology, or market dynamics. Such narrow foci often fail to provide a holistic understanding of how these barriers interact to stifle continuous growth.

1.2 The Current Startup Environment in Sweden

In 2025, the European Innovation Scoreboard (European Commission, 2026) awarded Sweden the title of the most innovative EU member country, and the Global Innovation Index of 2025 (World Intellectual Property Organization, 2025) ranked Sweden second place worldwide. This

top ranking is built on decades of experience and a legacy of building and enabling “unicorns”, startups with a valuation over $1 billion (Doyle, 2024; Stam & van de Ven, 2021, p. 817) through rigid innovation infrastructure. Sweden has to date created more than 40 unicorns, including global superstars like Spotify and Klarna (Vinnova, 2024; Business Sweden, 2020). This puts Sweden at the top of “unicorn” companies per capita in Europe and among the top ten globally (Dealroom, 2025). It requires rapid growth to become a unicorn, and a lot of these companies start off as “gazelles”, companies that sustain a growth rate of 20% in annual sales yearly over a period of a couple of years (Frid et al., 2025, p. 1). The challenge is no longer starting a company but creating continuous growth, especially in an environment of high innovation and intense competition. While Sweden shows high level of entrepreneurial activity and strong support for innovation, only a limited share of new ventures creates continuous growth.

There are different ways that a company can choose to scale, and there are three main ways that a startup can finance growth. These include staying private and refinancing with internal funds, going public and attracting external investors or to be fully or partially acquired (European Commission, 2021, p. 5). The external investors have a few characteristics that have been linked to increased growth in companies. Apart from the actual investment, there are social factors like the investors' expertise and experience that turn an investment into “smart money”. The investors network is another aspect of an investment that has the chance to increase the success of the scaling (European Commission, 2021, p. 5).

Sweden’s entrepreneurial ecosystem is characterized not only by high levels of innovation but also by the interaction between multiple stakeholder groups creating and shaping the foundations for continuous growth together. Entrepreneurs act as the central drivers of innovation by identifying opportunities, mobilizing resources and starting new companies. Their ability to achieve continuous growth is highly dependent on access to external support and partnerships withing the ecosystem.

Investors are another important stakeholder group within the Swedish innovation ecosystem. Through angel investors, venture capital, family offices and public funding, investors not only contribute financial capital but also industry expertise, knowledge and strategic guidance. The Swedish investment environment is known to be built on collaboration between public and private actors, creating strong access to early-stage funding (Tillväxtverket, 2026).

The third stakeholder group in this thesis are the actors within the innovation support system. These include incubators, accelerators, science parks, universities and public support organizations (Vinnova, 2026). Their ambition is to strengthen entrepreneurial capabilities by providing mentorships, business development support and access to professional networks. In Sweden, many of these organizations are publicly funded (Regeringskansliet, 2024) and connected to universities and regional innovation strategies.

Together, these stakeholder groups form an interconnected ecosystem where growth is created and shaped. Understanding how these groups interact within the Swedish ecosystem becomes central for explaining why some companies manages to achieve continuous growth and others struggle to scale over time.

1.3 Research Gap

Prior research suggests that continuous growth is not determined by a single factor but instead shaped by a dynamic relationship between multiple different players and their actions. Existing research often examines these dimensions in isolation, resulting in a fragmented understanding of the concept of growth (Audretsch, et al,. 2025). This study aims to address this gap by exploring this topic from different perspectives. The use of a triangulation perspective of entrepreneurs, investors, and actors from the innovation support system will enable comparative analysis of findings. By focusing on multiple actors, the study will move beyond linear explanations of growth and instead create a more integrated understanding of the continuous growth in new ventures.

The necessity of an integrated approach is further underscored by the prevailing methodological limitations in the field. While quantitative datasets have provided broad overviews of failure rates, there remains a notable lack of qualitative studies capable of capturing the nuanced, process-oriented challenges of scaling. As highlighted by Azeem & Khanna (2024) in the *Journal of Research in Marketing,* qualitative insights are essential for understanding the "how" and "why" behind organizational transitions, yet such depth is frequently overlooked in favor of large-scale statistical modeling. Achtenhagen et al. (2010) acknowledge this further by arguing that qualitative studies allow deriving results that are of more relevance for practitioners in the field. Qualitative research provides the researcher with the tools to dive deeper into a topic during the data collection, in comparison to a questionnaire in a quantitative study that is fixed. By employing a qualitative lens, this study can move beyond surface-level correlations to uncover the underlying mechanisms that either facilitate or hinder continuous growth.

Furthermore, the current body of literature remains largely siloed with researchers typically focusing on a single stakeholder in isolation. For instance, studies on market and economic barriers often prioritize the investor's perspective (European Investment Bank, 2024). While research into competency deficits focuses almost exclusively on the internal team (Szathmári et al., 2024). This fragmented approach misses critical synergies and misalignments that occur across the entrepreneurial ecosystem. By triangulating the perspectives of entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors, this study addresses the missing links between these groups. Identifying where conflicting expectations such as the pressure for rapid scaling versus the need for operational stability create barriers to sustainable expansion.

In addition, published research papers on business growth often create a fragmented perspective on what the concept is about, as argued by Achtenhagen et al. (2010). The included measurement for how growth is achieved in research is often far from what entrepreneur's value and sees as important for the longevity of their company. And what business growth means for entrepreneurs is also often very different from what researchers define in their papers. Achtenhagen et al. (2010) call for more research on business growth to have a stronger focus on what is happening in practices. By applying a triangulation approach and aiming at looking at the concept of growth from three different perspectives, the authors hope to add to this gap in the research.

Väisänen (2020), while attempting to explain the Swedish innovation support system, voiced that there needs to be a shift in the mindset of these actors to ensure growth over time. Making sure that the support that the organizations provide aims to be long term and encourage entrepreneurs to build a sustainable business from the beginning of the journey is shown to be

essential for achieving continuous growth. This input will guide the research of this thesis and more specifically data collection.

Finally, there is a distinct demand for research that accounts for specific geographical and regional contexts. General theories of entrepreneurship are often built on data from major global hubs, yet as suggested by recent studies in the *Journal of Entrepreneurship* and *Innovation in Emerging Economies* (Opute et al., 2021). The environmental and institutional factors governing growth vary significantly across different regions. A lack of localized research means that many startups are forced to apply growth strategies that may not be compatible with their specific economic landscape. Consequently, this study fills a critical void by examining these dynamics within a specific geographical context, thereby offering more relevant and actionable insights for both local practitioners and policymakers.

1.4 Research Question

In light of the identified gaps, calls for further research and the explicitly stated need for further qualitative insights in the domain of growth entrepreneurship, we formulate the following research question

How does the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and actors from the innovation support system enable continuous growth in new ventures in Sweden?

1.4.1 Thesis Purpose

The purpose of this thesis is to research the drivers and influences that create and contribute to continuous growth in new ventures. Even though the topic of growth within businesses has been well studied, this thesis aims to contribute to this phenomenon using multiple perspectives in the research design. Conducting a study that investigates the interplay between three main stakeholder groups will move this study beyond the linear relationship of entrepreneurial growth. The use of the *Triple Helix model* as well as *Triangulation* will ensure that the focus of the study is on the relationship between the entrepreneurs, the investors and the actors from the innovation support system, rather than on each group in isolation.

The study also acknowledges the regional dimensions of the Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem since access to investors, innovation support actors and professional networks might vary across the country. This thesis includes respondents across Swedens's major NUTS1 regions: Eastern Sweden, Southern Sweden and Northen Sweden (SCB, 2008). These regional innovation ecosystems have differences in terms of industrial infrastructure and resource concentration, which might influence how continuous growth is enabled and sustained in new ventures (Backteman & Åberg, 2026).

1.5 Delimitations

The scope of the study has been limited in various ways to ensure that the research is manageable within the timeframe and the available resources.

The qualitative nature of the study, based on limited numbers of interviews, limits the ability to draw generalized conclusions from the small sample size. The interviewees were also divided into three different groups, from three different regions in Sweden, further limiting the generalizability of the findings. However, it enables cross regional comparisons that would not be possible with a larger sample constricted to one geographical region. Due to the time limit of the thesis, a minimum of one person from each group was interviewed in each region to

ensure that the triangulation would be complete within each region, allowing for patterns within each region to be compared to the equivalent in other regions. Other stakeholder groups like employees and customers may also influence the growth of a company, however, they are not included in this study. The limitation was made to maintain focus on the interplay of the three chosen groups that are believed to be crucial in supporting and shaping the transition between early stage to continuous growth.

The research is geographically limited to the Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem. Sweden is known to have an innovative environment and strong support from multiple institutional actors. Other characteristics for Sweden are the mix of public funding and angel investor networks, as well as high levels of collaboration between all stakeholders. This context provides a complex environment when studying continuous growth, however it might differ from ecosystems in other countries, the findings will therefore be most relevant for Swedish actors even if they might be applicable elsewhere.

The study adopts a qualitative approach based on semi-structured interviews and structured analysis. It does not aim to test casual relationships or deliver statistically significant findings. The objective is to generate insights into how growth is created, shaped, and experienced by different actors. The study is also designed as a cross-sectional study, where data was collected at one point in time. Growth is, however, a dynamic process, and the research does not capture the relationship between actors to evolve over time. This delimitation allows for a detailed exploration of current perspectives but limits the ability to analyze potential changes over time.

2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

The theoretical framework provides the conceptual foundation for the study and situates the research withing relevant literature. It introduces and explains key theories and models that guide the study and act as a base for the analysis. The theoretical chapter will introduce topics such as Entrepreneurial Growth, Entrepreneurial Ecosystems, Triple Helix model, as well as the three different stakeholder groups.

2.1 Entrepreneurial Growth

Growth is a central concept in business and entrepreneurship and can be explained in several different ways. ” Grow” is also a verb which indicates that growth is an ongoing process rather than a static or fixed event. Having this in mind when trying to understand what drives and enables growth is important since it can change and shift over time. This section aims to introduce and explain several ways in which growth can be viewed and explained.

2.1.1 Current Research on Entrepreneurial Growth

Shah et al. (2013) argue that choosing the appropriate growth strategy allows the entrepreneur to overcome challenges and move towards continuity. These initial challenges of starting and growing a business include, but are not limited to background, education, entrepreneurial aspirations, business skills, external environment and mindset. In a literature review, the authors highlight several different growth models and strategies. The models act as blueprints and the base for motivating growth, while the strategy provides a roadmap of how to achieve the goals set by the growth model (Shah et al, 2013, p. 2190). Their review of growth models included both Greiner (1998) and Churchill & Lewis (1978), which are both explained in depth further down in the theoretical chapter.

Further, they mention Garnsey (1998) and the resource-based view on business growth. Explaining that the resources that a company either possesses or acquires are essential for successful growth. Resources can be intangible or tangible and sources through networking, alliances or partnerships (Shah et al, 2013, p. 2191). Difficulties to facilitate or match necessary resources potentially lead to growth reversal.

When it comes to growth strategy, it can be viewed in many different ways. Essentially, the strategy acts as an agenda of how to achieve desired growth. What level of growth is desired is mainly based on the entrepreneur's ambition (Shah et al,. 2013, p. 2191). Important is also that the chosen strategy is in harmony with the external environment and the internal capabilities. To move past short term and often rapid growth to something closer to continuous growth, long term strategies are necessary to adopt (Shah et al,. 2013, p. 2193). The main challenge to finding the appropriate strategy is to have poor access to required information. This refers to knowledge about different markets when attempting to explore and penetrate new opportunities. It can also be internal like not understanding what structure works will for the company that is planning to expand.

Achtenhagen et al,. (2010) present a literature review of articles published between 1981 and 1992, arguing that most publications on business growth have focused on changes in output such as sales, revenue, turnover, or employment. Restricting a definition of a process like growth to static numerical values has been questioned since these metrics often can be altered with purposely to present a picture of higher growth when desirable. Several studies that have included these metrics have also been of the self-reporting type in the past, which present the

risk of bias and the difficulty of replication. Due to this fragmented view on growth, Achtenhagen et al., (2010) chose to conduct an updated literature review including seven dimensions, including the definition of growth in 56 articles, published between 1997 and 2008, all having the primary word in the title. Out of these, almost 65% of the articles failed to conceptualize growth. Achtenhagen et al,. (2010, 298) concludes from the articles that "firm growth is a complex phenomenon. It is not uni-dimensional. It is hard to predict and assess.".

Audretsch et al,. (2023) argues that there are two distinct phases to growth in new ventures. The first being tied to knowledge transfer and explorations of new markets (Audretsch et al,. 2023, p. 1538). The second stage evolve into market exploitation and growth, this is reached through the adaptation of new technologies and combining existing resources (Audretsch et al,. 2023, p. 1539). Whetten (1987) explains that while an increase in size, of resources, of employees or other factors is an absolute measure, growth should be referred to as an increase in size over time.

2.1.2 Drivers behind Growth

The phenomenon of venture growth within the Swedish innovation ecosystem is not driven by a singular catalyst but rather emerges from an interflow of internal strategic intent, external mandates, and systemic support structures. At the primary level, the internal driver of growth is rooted in the "entrepreneurial vision" which functions as the initial engine of firm development. As Penrose (1959, p. 31) argued in her foundational work on firm growth, the limit to a firm's expansion is often determined by the internal managerial resources and the strategic ambition of its leadership. This drive often transcends mere financial gain, frequently manifesting as a mission-oriented ambition to disrupt established markets or address systemic societal challenges, a trait particularly prevalent in the Swedish "impact" sector. This internal strategic intent is critical, as it dictates the firm's willingness to absorb the risks associated with rapid scaling and high-uncertainty environments.

However, internal ambition alone is insufficient without the external catalysts provided by the broader ecosystem, most notable through the role of venture capital and professionalized investment. Within this context, investors act as "extrinsic drivers" by imposing growth mandates that necessitate a shift in organizational speed. This pressure is often a byproduct of the "innovative competitiveness" inherent in the Swedish economy where firms are pushed to scale rapidly to maintain a global edge (Rastvortseva et al., 2025, p. 18). The infusion of capital is rarely a passive event instead it acts as a structural requirement for growth where the firm must meet specific scaling milestones to maintain investor confidence. As Davidsson et al. (2010, p. 75) note, small firm growth is often a result of the external environment providing opportunities that the firm's internal resources are then "pulled" to exploit.

Furthermore, the drivers behind growth are deeply embedded in the "synergistic infrastructure" provided by innovation support actors, such as incubators, accelerators, and university-linked hubs. These actors do not merely facilitate growth, the drive it by reducing the "transaction costs" of innovation. This relationship is best understood through the Triple Helix framework where the quality of the startup ecosystem is directly influenced by the strength of the bonds between University, Industry, and Government (Flechas-Takahashi, 2026, p. 12). In the Swedish context, these support mechanisms are often regionalized, meaning that the specific driver of growth for a firm in Umeå may differ from one in Gothenburg due to localized industrial clusters. Recent research into Swedish family firms and startups further suggests that this regional innovativeness is a primary driver of long-term sustainable growth (Bourouaha &

Maliki, 2026, p. 5). Growth is driven by the alignment of these three forces: the entrepreneur's internal strategic intent, the investor's growth mandate, and the support system's facilitating infrastructure.

Beyond the structural and financial mandates of growth, there exists a profound socio-psychological dimension where the drive to scale is fueled by the pursuit of organizational legitimacy and the "need to be heard" within a crowded global marketplace. This desire for visibility is often a primary driver for entrepreneurs who view growth not merely as metric of success, but as a mechanism for establishing a "voice" and gaining recognition within their respective industrial clusters. As Suchman (1995, p. 574) notes in his seminal work legitimacy, organizations often seek growth to align themselves with socially constructed systems of norms and beliefs. Thereby ensuring their "right to exist" and operate within the ecosystem. In the Swedish context this often manifests as a drive to be recognized as a "hub" of innovation where being seen and heard by national support actors and international investors becomes a strategic objective.

This "want to be seen" is closely linked to the acquisition of social capital. Growth then serves as a signal of quality to external stakeholders. For many new ventures, the driver behind rapid expansion is the desire to move from the periphery of the innovation ecosystem to its core (Zimmerman & Zeitz, 2002, p. 414). That translates visibility into increased access to elite networks and high-value partnerships. This pursuit of reputation and brand fame acts as a non-monetary driver of growth where the entrepreneurs' personal identity is often intertwined with the firm's public profile. As recent research into the Swedish startup landscape suggests, the social prestige associated with high-growth "gazelle" status can be as much of a motivator as traditional profit-seeking. It provides the founders with the cultural capital necessary to influence future industry standards (Rastvortseva et al., 2025, p. 21). Therefore, growth must be understood as a communicative act and a way for the firm to project its values, secure its status, and ensure it is not silenced by the competitive noise of the international innovation arena.

2.1.3 Measurements of Growth

In the study of new ventures, measuring growth is a complex task that requires a shift from traditional accounting metrics to a more holistic set of indicators that capture the firm's evolving capabilities. While financial measurements such as revenue increase and profitability remain the most common indicators of commercial success, they often fail to reflect the underlying development progress of and early-stage firm. As Davidsson et al. (2010, p. 72) argue, growth is often a non-linear and multidimensional process where different metrics, such as turnover and employment, may not always correlate in the short term. For many Swedish startups, particularly those in high-tech or capital-intensive sectors, growth is initially measured by the acquisition of risk capital. That serves as a proxy for market validation and future scaling potential rather than immediate profit (Rastvortseva et al., 2025, p. 22).

Except from financial statistics, employment growth is frequently utilized as a key indicator of organizational expansion and social impact. Increasing the number of employees signifies an expansion of the firm's internal managerial capacity and a reduction in the "liability of smallness". However, employment as a metric must be approached with caution. As Penrose (1959, p. 45) suggests in her foundational theory, the real measurement of growth lies not merely in the headcount, but in the firm's ability to integrate these new human resources effectively to create "productive services". This perspective shifts the focus toward knowledge-

based measurements where growth is viewed as the accumulation of intellectual capital and specialized expertise. In the context of Triple Helix model (Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, 1995), this is often quantified through the firm's increased research output, patent filings, or the depth of its collaboration with university-linked innovation hubs which represent a growth in "innovation capacity" (Flechas-Takahashi, 2026, p. 15).

The measurements of growth must account for qualitative and symbolic shifts in the firm's market position and social standing. As Zimmerman and Zeitz (2002, p. 416) emphasize, the transition from a surviving startup to a legitimate market player is a critical growth milestone that is often better captured through reputation and network density than through balance sheets alone. This suggests that growth is also a communicative achievement, where the firm's ability to be seen and heard within the ecosystem serves as a vital measurement of its competitive standing. That gives a robust analysis of the Swedish innovation ecosystem that requires a triangulated approach to measurement. It is combining hard financial statistics with soft indicators of organizational learning, ecosystem influence, and strategic legitimacy. By viewing growth through these diverse and often conflicting lenses researchers can better understand the holistic scaling path of new ventures within their regional and national contexts and moving beyond a reductive focus on mere financial output (Davidsson et al., 2010, p. 72; Rastvortseva et al., 2025, p. 24).

2.1.4 Models to Visualize Growth

Growth can also be described through the five-phase model by Larry. E Greiner (1979; 1998), including the challenges and organizational practices of each stage in the growth process. The articles also map how companies tend to grow based on the organizations' size, age, and whether it is experiencing evolution or revolution (see Figure 1). The age of an organization has been showing impact on what practices an organization takes part in, and these evolve as the company ages over time (Greiner, 1998, p. 4). These practices include challenges in management and increased decentralization as the organization grows. The size of the company is another aspect of how it grows over time. More employees mean more people to manage and have a higher risk of conflict. Coordination and communication are key areas where problems can erupt quickly and impact an organization's ability to scale. Whether a company is experiencing evolution or revolution is described as if the organization is growing continuous, without major setbacks or large challenges or if it is experiencing a more turbulent phase on their journey to growth. Companies that fall short during periods of revolution are often ones that fail to put the past behind and keep practices that have been challenging or had a negative impact on the organization's growth in the past (Greiner, 1998, p. 4-5).

Larry. E Greiner (1998) five phases of growth are illustrated in *Figure 1* below and described as a pattern that is seen in companies that operate in industries with moderate growth over time, or as in this thesis referred to as continuous growth. However, Greiner (1998, p. 6) argues that firms in faster growing industries still tend to follow the same trajectory but at a faster pace and companies showing slower scaling might only experience a couple of these phases.

1. *Creativity* is the birth of an organization, the focus is on creating the value proposition and finding the initial market. The evolution of this phase involves the founders working operationally and in the middle of the company, managing all types of activities. This early in the growth the company acts very responsive to the voices coming from customers. However, as the company succeeds and creates a position on the market, the need for further knowledge regarding efficiency starts to impact

leadership. That leads to the first revolution phase of the growth path. The need for a great manager is something that can hinder the company from growing. The founders still want control, however they might not be the best suited for leading the development ahead. Unless the entrepreneurs either step aside or acknowledge the challenges in the leadership, companies can get stuck this early on and not grow past this phase.

2. The second phase is referred to as *Direction*, and these firms start to develop more complex organizational structures, separating functions to enable better management and efficiency. Through this change in structure comes levels of hierarchy, influencing norms in communications and overall management. With fixed levels within the organization comes the challenge of autonomy, where employees feel stuck between following orders and taking initiative. The balance between enforcing hierarchy and centralized report systems and allowing individuals to be decision makers is what allows companies to move beyond this second phase.
3. From here, the company moves towards *Delegation*, where decentralization is central to how well the company grows. Giving more control to managers in a decentralized organization leads to wider market exploration and penetration. However, as top-level management starts sensing a loss of control, the revolution of control sets into action. Lower-level managers prefer to have decision making power while the top management seeks to regain control over the organization as a whole. Attempting to reintegrate central management once the decentralization has begun is difficult and often why companies don't get past this phase. Those who allow decentralization and instead focus on coordination move on to the next phase.
4. *Coordination* is the fourth phase, and companies now focus on centralizing come core business units while keeping other decentralized, closer to the market and closer to customers. To be successful, implementation of systems facilitating this type of structure is essential to this growth phase. Overload of systems and programs leads to this phase revolution called the *red-tape crisis*. This is when the people within the organization criticize how it is run, employees feel like the organization has grown to large and there is too much trust in the formal programs that have been integrated to allow further growth.
5. The last of the five phases is *Collaboration*. The name of this phase emphasizes interpersonal collaboration to overcome the crisis in the previous phase. Social interactions and self-discipline are key aspects of overcoming the impact of formal systems. Problem solving is a big part of trying to regain trust in the workforce and build an organizational culture. Companies that reach this far in their growth have been seen adopting a matrix structure in attempts to assign collaborative teams to work on specific challenges. There is also an increase in internal education programs to train managers and employees and encourage them to stay in the company. This growth phase does not have a clear revolution part at the time of publication, and it might still be of interest for future research since only a few companies have moved past phase five on their growth journey.

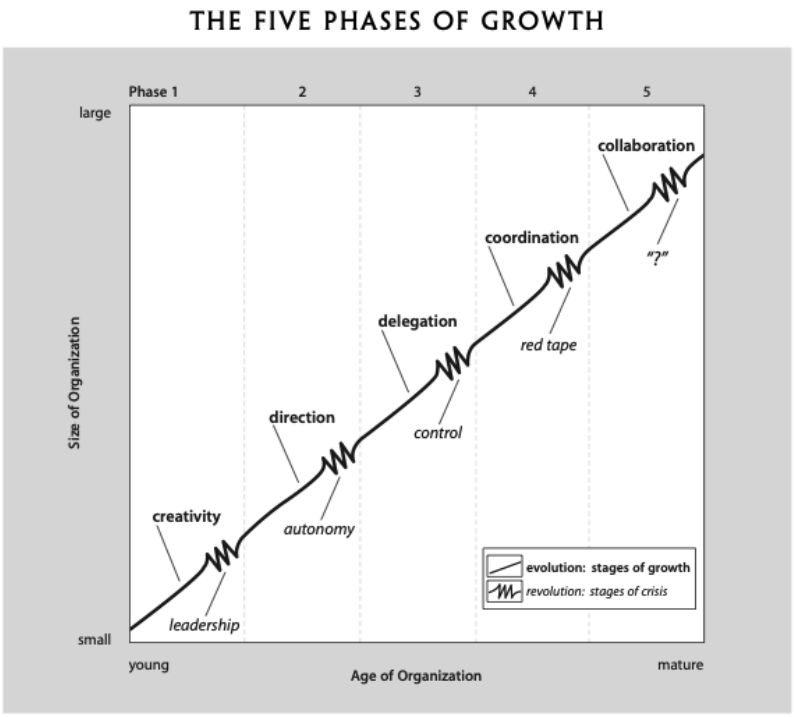


Figure 1. The Five Phases of Growth

Source: Larry. E Greiner (1998, p. 5)

Building on the work of Greiner (1972) Churchill & Lewis (1978) created the five growth stages, as another way to explain entrepreneurial growth. When reviewing their model Shah et al,. (2013, p. 2190) stated that growth motivation by the entrepreneur was to be considered an important factor in creating and shaping growth over time. Below is an explanation to the growth process shown in Figure 2.

1. The first stage is referred to as *Existence*, which is when a company is born essentially (Churchill & Lewis, 1987, p. 3). The business is trying to attract customers and deliver value. The companies that can achieve these two objectives move on to the second stage of the growth trajectory.
2. The second stage is the *Survival* stage (Churchill & Lewis, 1987, p. 4). The organizations at this stage are still simple in terms of structure, it moves from just existing to aiming to generate revenue. Companies can stay at this stage for a while before they move to the third out of five stages, or they are not able to create continuous growth, and they instead go out of business.
3. The third stage is the *Success* stage, and business owners often find themselves in a dilemma once they have come this far. The company can either continue to grow and through that explore and exploit new market opportunities or stay stable and profitable but without the desire to expand (Churchill & Lewis, 1987, p. 5). If the business owner decides on the continued growth path.
4. It then moves to stage four, called *Take-off* by Churchill & Lewis (1987, p. 6). This stage, as the name recalls, is all about rapid expansion. Most companies adapt to a decentralized organizational structure at this stage, and it often entails going globally to reach larger markets. This is a pivotal moment is the lifecycle of a company, often

still controlled by the owners, the determination of success if crucial for the survival of the business. Any mistake and the journey can be over. The biggest challenge in this stage is trying to move too fast and run out of capital or other resources or not moving fast enough and losing momentum and motivation.

5. The last stage is the *Resource Maturity* and here companies must recover from successful rapid growth from the previous stage. This includes building internal management structures and adapting to using tools that of a larger company, like financial and strategic planning. Churchill & Lewis (1987, p. 6) also mentions a last step, *Ossification*, that they choose to not include in the graphical representation of the growth stages, this one referrer to when a larger company loses momentum and the entrepreneurial spirit, meaning that the business becomes less flexible.

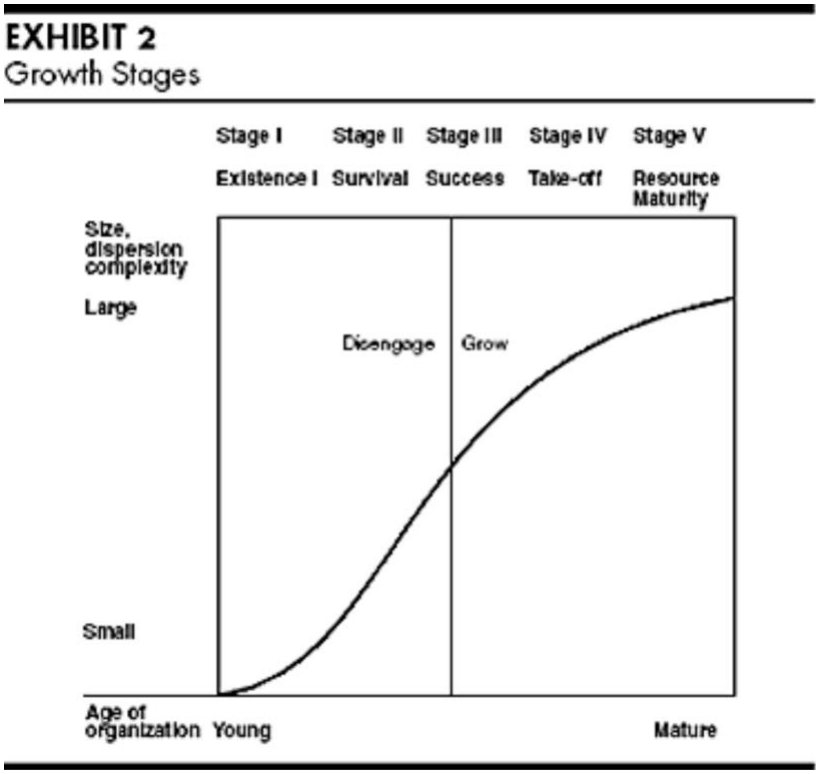


Figure 2. Growth Stages

Source: Churchill & Lewis (1978, p. 3)

The models presented in this section are important for the study as they illustrate that business growth should not be understood as a linear or isolated process, rather as a dynamic development shaped by access to strategic resources and external conditions over time. By visualizing how firms transition through different phases or stages of development, the models contribute to a deeper understanding of the challenges associated with achieving continuous growth. The models also highlight that different stages of growth often require different forms of support, financing and strategic guidance. This creates as theoretical foundation for examining how the three different stakeholder groups in this thesis interact to influence long-term growth.

2.2 Entrepreneurial Ecosystems

Entrepreneurial ecosystems as described by Stam & van de Ven (2021, p. 826) should be viewed as a web where all actors work together as one. Looking at the independent elements might provide an incorrect view on the potential outcomes of the ecosystem. However, it is important to understand what the different actors are within the ecosystem and what purpose they serve to the environment.

Stam (2015, p. 2) breaks down the meaning of the entrepreneurial ecosystem to evolving around high growth startups acting in an entrepreneurial community of independent actors. The term entrepreneurial ecosystems are often used to describe innovation systems, clusters of new ventures within an innovative field or industry, or as a space where all of these come together. Differentiating this from other ecosystems is that the entrepreneur is in the center, rather than the company or venture, allowing the focus to be maintained around innovation and entrepreneurship.

The independent actors within the ecosystem can be categorized in many ways. The World Economic Forum (2013, p. 7) describes eight pillars as building blocks of an entrepreneurial ecosystem. These include accessible markets, funding and finance, regulatory framework and infrastructure, major universities as catalysts, human capital, support system, education and training, and cultural support. These eight can be divided into three perspectives, allowing for further discussion through frameworks like the Triple Helix and Triangulation. The entrepreneur requires a market to enable their vision (accessible markets), they also need a team to build the venture together with (human capital) and a culture that supports and celebrates innovation and tolerates a certain level of risk taking (cultural support). The investor's perspective is responsible for funding and finance as well as a regulatory framework in a way of protecting their investments. Lastly, the innovation support perspective, seen as the enablers, provides knowledge through their connections with universities, education and training through various incubators or accelerators and acts as an overall support system to the entrepreneur.

2.3 Triple Helix Model

The Triple Helix model, pioneered by Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff in the mid 1990s, provides a non-linear framework for understanding the synergies between academia, industry and government (Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, 1995, p. 2). Traditional models viewed these three groups as operating separately, universities as knowledge producers, the industry as the engine for commercialization and wealth creation, and lastly the government as regulators. The triple helix model suggests that these three actors collaborate and overlap in their roles, forming a structure that has been shown to be beneficial for economic development.

The Triple Helix allows collaboration to move from bilateral to trilateral using spheres (Leydesdorff, 2012, p. 3), rather than a linear relationship in a triangular format. Apart from the spheres' format, a critical feature of the development of the model is the concept of role substitution. This is explained by Etzkowitz (2003, p. 295-296) as institutions to “take the role of the other”, suggesting that universities adopt entrepreneurial functions such as incubators or accelerators, and the industry and privately owned companies including a higher level of research to backup business development decisions.

Leydesdorff (2012, p. 4) further complicates the model by introducing a “differentiated Triple Helix with dynamic overlay” that suggests that the model can be three-dimensional with layers

of communication interfering and enabling one another. This multi-layered architecture of the model allows for different dimensions within each sphere to be considered in relation to each other. The use of the Triple Helix model in research can enable insights into the interactions between the three clusters, creating depth to the research.

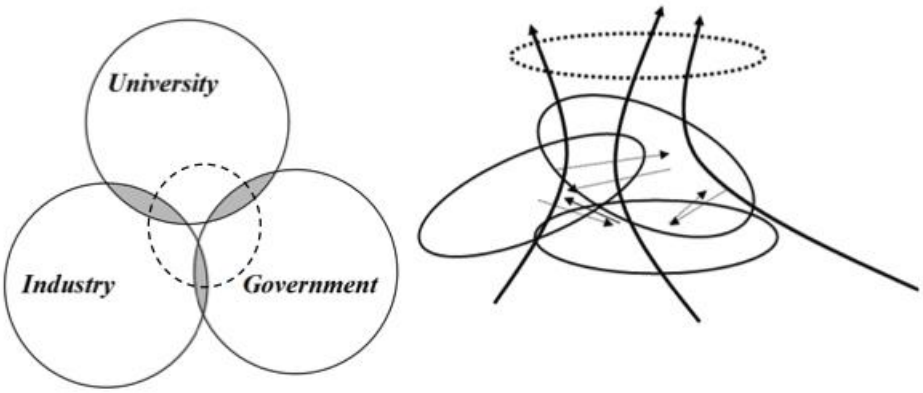


Figure 3. A differentiated Triple Helix with dynamic overlay

Source: Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, (1995, p. 4)

The Triple Helix model is included in this study to visualize the interplay that is imagined to be present between the three stakeholder groups. Understanding that they operate independently and interconnected simultaneously will act as a fundamental base for the interviews.

2.3.1 The Triple Helix within Entrepreneurial Ecosystems

The triple Helix model and the concept of entrepreneurial ecosystems emerge from different branches of research, they are closely interconnected and act as complements to each other in understanding how innovation and growth develop. The entrepreneurial ecosystem perspective explains a broader configuration of actors and resources that enable entrepreneurship. The Triple Helix has a more focused lens on the interactions and interplay between three key stakeholders. The Triple Helix model can be viewed as a foundational structure within the entrepreneurial ecosystem, highlighting the importance of collaboration, knowledge sharing, and cooperation between the actors. The model provides a visual representation of how innovation and growth are not achieved in isolation, but through overlapping interactions.

The entrepreneurial ecosystem instead extends the Triple Helix perspective by including more actors, including entrepreneurs, investors and support organizations (Stam & van de Ven, 2021). It also emphasizes the informal networks and the market dynamics that are present within an ecosystem. The ecosystem perspective provides a holistic view of, incorporating the dynamic environment that creates, shapes, and drives growth.

In the context of this study, the Triple Helix acts as a theoretical foundation for understanding the logic of the ecosystem and the interplay between the different actors. The entrepreneurial ecosystem allows for the inclusion of additional actors and relational dynamics. The combination of the two enables a more comprehensive analysis of the collected data from three different stakeholder groups.

While the original Triple Helix model conceptualizes innovation systems through the interactions between university, industry and government (Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, 1995), this thesis adapts the framework to fit the entrepreneurial ecosystem context. Instead of examining the institutional spheres in isolation, the study focuses on three stakeholder groups that operate within the spheres of entrepreneurs, investors and actors within the innovation support system.

The entrepreneur represents the industrial and commercial dimension of the ecosystem through venture creation and market development. Investors contribute financial resources and strategic guidance primarily. The innovation support system often operates at the intersection between academia, industry and government. These three stakeholder groups therefore reflect the overlapping and collaborative structures introduced by the Triple Helix model.

This adaptation if further supported by the concepts of role substitution within the Triple Helix framework (Etzkowitz, 2003), where institutional actors take on functions traditionally linked to other spheres. Universities engage in entrepreneurial activities through incubators and holding companies. Investors act as mentors and support in sharing knowledge and strategic support beyond financial investment. Innovations support actors act as intermediaries that connect entrepreneurs with both public and private investors. The boundaries between the stakeholder groups are therefore blurred, making the Triple Helix model relevant to understanding the relational and interconnected dynamics of the Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem.

2.4 The Entrepreneur

The concept of entrepreneurship has been widely discussed in economic management literature, and different scholars emphasize different aspects of entrepreneurial activity. In general terms, an entrepreneur can be understood as an individual who identifies opportunities, mobilizes resources, and creates value through new business activities or innovations (Shane & Venkataraman, 2000, p. 218).

One of the most influential definitions originates from Schumpeter, who described the entrepreneur as the individual responsible for introducing innovations in the economy. According to Schumpeter (1934), entrepreneurs are those who carry out “new combinations” of resources. Such as introducing new products, new production methods, new markets, new sources of supply, or new forms or organization (Schumpeter, 1934, p. 66). In this perspective, entrepreneurs are closely linked to innovation and economic development, as entrepreneurs disrupt existing market structures through what Schumpeter described as processes of creative destruction (Schumpeter, 1934, p. 74).

Other scholars emphasize opportunity recognition as the central feature of entrepreneurship. For example, Shane and Venkataraman (2000, p. 218) argue that entrepreneurship concerns the discovery, evaluation, and exploration of opportunities to introduce new goods and services. This perspective highlights how entrepreneurs identify unmet needs or inefficiencies in the market and act upon them by creating new ventures. Similar to this, Kirzner (1973, p. 35) views the entrepreneur primarily as an individual who is alert to previously unnoticed opportunities in the market. In his theory, entrepreneurs play a key role in market processes by identifying and exploring profit opportunities and thereby moving markets toward equilibrium.

Gartner (1988) suggests that entrepreneurship should not only be understood through the traits of individuals but also through the process of venture creation itself. According to him, entrepreneurship can be defined as the creation of new organizations emphasizing the activities involved in establishing and developing a business (Gartner, 1988, p. 11). From an entrepreneurial perspective, growth is closely linked to innovation and the exploitation of new opportunities. Entrepreneurs contribute to economic and organizational growth by introducing new products, entering new markets, and developing new business models that create value (Schumpeter, 1934, p. 74; Shane & Venkataraman, 2000, p. 218). In this sense, growth is not only a matter of increasing firm size but also of generating change and development within industries and economies.

These perspectives illustrate that entrepreneurs can be understood from several perspectives. That includes innovation, opportunity recognition, and venture creation. Despite these different emphases, most definitions share the idea that entrepreneurs play a crucial role in initiating economic change by identifying opportunities and organizing resources to create new value. Achtenhagen, Naldi, and Melin (2010, p. 305) provide a specific perspective on entrepreneurs and emphasizes the importance of sustained business development. They are discussing continuous growth and are defining entrepreneurs as individuals who own or drive companies that have experienced continuous growth over a period of at least one decade. This definition shifts the focus from venture creation to the ability to sustain and manage long-term growth.

2.4.1 Entrepreneurs in Sweden

Sweden's entrepreneurial landscape is characterized by a high volume of market entries and a sophisticated industrial structure dominated by small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). According to official data from the Swedish Agency for Economic and Regional Growth, the registration of new ventures remains a primary driver of economic renewal with approximately 70 000 to 75 000 new businesses established annually (Tillväxtverket, 2024). This statistical trend underscores a persistent entrepreneurial drive within the Swedish population where propensity to start is supported by a stable institutional environment. These new starts are not evenly distributed but are heavily concentrated in the service sector and knowledge-intensive industries. That is reflecting Sweden's transition toward a post-industrial innovation economy.

A critical metric in assessing the health of this ecosystem is the prevalence of "young" ventures, firms that have been active for less than five years. Statistics from the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) Sweden report and Statistiska Centralbyrån (SCB) indicate that these nascent organizations are vital for national employment dynamics. While micro-firms (0-9 employees) constitute over 90% of all registered businesses in Sweden, it is the best subset of young, scaling ventures that generates a disproportionate share of new net jobs (SCB, 2024; Tillväxtverket, 2024). Currently, early staged entrepreneurial activity (TEA) rates suggest that approximately 9% of the Swedish working-age population is involved in the startup or early management phase of a business, placing Sweden among the more active entrepreneurial nations in the European context (GEM, Sweden, 2024).

The growth trajectory of small companies in Sweden reveals a significant structural pattern often termed the "scaling threshold". While the survival rate for Swedish startups is relatively high compared to international averages, with over 65% of firms remaining active after three years, the transition to high-growth status remains an elite phenomenon (Tillväxtverket, 2024). National statistics highlight that "gazelle" companies, which sustain a minimum annual growth

of 20% in turnover over a three-year period, represent less than 1% of the total business population. This suggests that while the Swedish 2environment is exceptionally efficient at fostering new starts, the barriers to rapid scaling remain central challenge for national innovation policy (Tillväxtverket, 2024). Because of this, contemporary growth trends increasingly focused on internationalization and digital transformation. As firms leverage Sweden's advanced digital infrastructure to access global markets early in their lifecycle to overcome the limitations of the domestic consumer base (Tillväxtverket, 2024; SCB, 2024).

The statistical landscape provided by Tillväxtverket and SCB establishes that while Sweden is a fertile ground for venture creation, the transition to sustained high growth "gazelle status remains a significant hurdle. This scaling gap suggests that numerical survival does not inherently translate into ecosystemic influence or strategic legitimacy. To understand the underlying mechanisms that allow certain Swedish ventures to overcome these regional and national barriers. It is necessary to move beyond aggregate statistics and examine the qualitative interplay between key actors.

2.5 The Investor

The word investor can entail numerous different meanings and be defined in several different ways. In general terms, an investor is someone who puts money or equivalent capital into a business for potential financial return (Corporate Finance Institute, 2019). The main focus is to maximize return for the most minimal possible risk. There are several different types of investors, from individual angel investors to institutional actors investing government funds.

An angel investor is an individual that invests with their own personal capital (Verksamt, 2025), often in early startups since the ticket size and evaluation of the company is often lower. In addition to providing capital, angel investors are known for what can be referred to as "smart money", meaning that the investor also invests their time by providing guidance, sharing competency, or accepting a seat on the board (Dealroom, 2026). Angel investors can, by sharing expertise and knowledge, often get additional shares in a startup, as a complement to capital investment, instead of a salary. These angel investors can also join angel investor networks to collaborate in investing and combine capital to be able to cover larger investment rounds. A few examples of angel investor networks in Sweden are Connect Sverige, VILDA, Stockholm Business Angels, Saminvest and SweBAN. These are often run by an organization whose purpose is to connect individual investors with potential investment objects like new ventures. There are also industry-specific networks that connect angel investors with specific expertise, useful or necessary to have when investing in industries like life science or tech. Another end of the spectrum of private investors is the family offices. These are often smaller offices that manage a wealthy family's fortune by investing the money (Dealroom, 2026). Since they often have more capital than a single individual, they can often invest in very early startups until the company goes public. Just like angel investors, the family offices can offer guidance and mentorship since they focus on long-term value creation and want to ensure continuous growth to gain higher returns.

The second type of investors are corporate investors or often called venture capital. These types of firms often manage and invest a pool of money that they have acquired from investors that want someone else to calculate the risk and do not strive to become operationally involved in the startups themselves. The people working for the venture capital firm can however offer to provide strategic support and take on the role as board member, as a way of ensuring insight and control in the company (Dealroom, 2026). There are also private equity firms, much similar

to venture capital, but they often invest in more mature companies, even publicly traded companies on the stock market (Schroders, 2026).

Last is a group of investors that are funded by the government. These include non-profit organizations, accelerators, and incubators. An example of a government funded investor in Sweden is Almi Invest, they act as venture capitalist, however they invest with government funds. Almi Invest have currently invested in over 900 startups, reaching a total of around 3.5 billion SEK (Almi, 2026). Incubators and accelerators tied to universities in Sweden are also government funded. These are organizations that work with helping entrepreneurs to start their companies and later on grow them. A crucial step in creating growth is financing the company, and a lot of the incubators or accelerators therefore have an investment company tied to their organization. Allowing the university to invest in new ventures that are born and developed at their site enables this type of business development work to continue since they also aim at making a financial return.

2.5.1 The Investor Ecosystem in Sweden

The investor ecosystem plays a crucial role in enabling the creation and growth of new ventures. Access to capital is recognized as a key factor influencing whether a company is successful in sustaining growth over time. In Sweden, this ecosystem is characterized by the mix of investors often supporting new ventures at different stages of development, however there is also good collaboration between the private and public investors.

Early-stage financing is often provided by individual angel investors or by networks who invest their own capital in exchange for equity. As explained before, this type of investor is often generous with sharing experience and industry knowledge, as well as opening their professional network as a way of helping the startup develop further. In Sweden it is common for angel investors to find potential startups to invest in by being members of investor networks. Pitch events and other meetings is how investors find companies to invest in. As the startup develops and grows, so does their demand for capital and when the investment rounds increase in size, this is often where venture capitalist and family offices enters the picture. However, angel investors that already have equity in the company are often asked to follow up on their previous investment, if possible, to not lose too much ownership.

Public actors play a significant role in in the Swedish investment ecosystems. Government funded organizations provide both fundings and crucial support for startups in the early stages of development. Almi invest is one of the most active early-stage investors in Sweden (Almi, 2026). They often co-invest alongside angel investors to reduce overall financial risk and stimulate growth and innovation. Similarly, both Industrifonden and Vinnova are other big players that provide funding either through venture capital or grants to new and innovative ventures (Indsutrifonden, 2026; Vinnova, 2024). Overall, these big government-backed actors strengthen the investment environment by facilitating access to capital and encouraging collaboration with individual investors. Have several larger players funded by the government specialized in different industries or for specific stages of growth is something unique for the Swedish context (Stockholm Insights, 2025).

Overall, the Swedish investor ecosystem is unique by the strong collaboration between private and public actors. Strong early-stage funding and innovation driven investments enable global growth potential. The combination of angel investors, venture capital firms and public funding organizations creates a supportive environment for entrepreneurs to start and grow their

companies. All of which contributes to Sweden's position as one of the leading startup ecosystems in Europe and in the world (Dealroom, 2025, p. 29). This is important to have in mind when examining the investors' role in shaping continuous growth in new ventures.

2.6 Innovation Support System

The innovation support system refers to a network of organizations that provide resources, knowledge, and support to entrepreneurs through the initial phases of starting and growing a business (Bager-Sjögren & Rosenberg, 2004, p. 14). Unlike investors who focus on gaining a financial return, actors within the support system aim to promote innovation, economic growth, and other aspects of entrepreneurship on a broader level (Väisänen, 2020). The organizations provide different types of support or guidance that aim to better enable startups to develop necessary capabilities and increase their chances of achieving growth.

The innovation support system consists of a wide range of actors, including incubators, accelerators, science parks, universities, public agencies, and non-profit organizations. Some have strong local ties, while others have a nationwide reach. However, the mix of organizations can be seen in most regions in Sweden (Väisänen, 2020). While the actors might be similar across regions, the local environment poses unique opportunities and challenges, potentially affecting what type of support is offered. The same goes for the actors themselves, depending on the environment they operate in and the market they aim to approach, they all have strengths and weaknesses (Hjalmarsson, 2022, p. 107). They support entrepreneurs through providing mentors, business development guidance, and access to networks. A key aspect of these support actors is that the majority are government funded and therefore provides the support to the entrepreneur at a very low or no cost.

Incubators are often focused on the initial phases of starting a business. They aim to help entrepreneurs realize their ideas and turn them into a viable business. This type of actor can be separated or connected to universities. The academic incubators only approach students and researchers while the independent incubators welcome anybody. Their support evolves around coaching, workshops, and overall ideation creation (Cote, 2023). Accelerators are responsible for the next stage of the growth journey, when the company is ready to expand and accelerate. This phase is equal to finding a direction in *The Five Phases of Growth* model by Larry. E Greiner (1998). The accelerators work with slightly more developed startups and focus on scaling the business (Cote, 2023). Their support can include mentorships and investor matchmaking, apart coaching and workshops. Both the incubators and accelerators often have structured programs that entrepreneurs can apply to as a way in and once in the system, they can be assigned a business coach and work with more specific challenges.

Science parks or other types of innovation hubs provide a physical environment focused on fostering innovation. It acts as a place where startups can meet each other and access support from researchers and support organizations (Swedish Incubators & Science Parks, 2026). This type of knowledge exchange and collaboration have been seen to have a positive impact on growth. The same type of support as in the incubators or accelerators is often offered within the science park or innovation hub, however the companies present here are often tied to science in some way and often a mix of just getting started and more mature.

Universities also play a central role in the innovation support system by connecting research, talent, and infrastructure. Many larger universities have their own innovation offices, incubators and holding companies, supporting students and alumni to commercialize their ideas

or research (Brunnström, 2020, p. 22). In addition to academic support, there are public agencies and non-profit organizations providing support for entrepreneurs through grants, advisory, and programs aimed at enabling and fostering entrepreneurship and innovation.

The innovation support system can be understood as an enabling actor that complements the investors by focusing on building capabilities, knowledge, and networks to create growth, rather than maximizing financial return.

2.6.1 The Swedish Innovation Support System

The Swedish innovation support system is characterized by a mix of publicly funded and privately owned organizations. Bager-Sjögren & Rosenberg (2004) aimed to map out all actors, describe their purpose and how they interact with each other. They identified over 400 actors that all work towards supporting innovations and startups in the early phases of growth (Bager-Sjögren & Rosenberg, 2004, p. 32). The network of organizations strives to support entrepreneurs, specifically in the initial stages of venture creation and helping to navigate phases of uncertainty, connected to commercialization and generating growth. Many of these actors are government funded, allowing them to offer their support at a low or no cost, which shifts their focus from short-term financial return to a more long-term societal impact.

In Sweden, incubators, accelerators and science parks are many times connected to universities or regional centers of research. These often provide structured support through standardized programs as a gateway into the other types of guidance and support they can offer. Their main purpose is to help entrepreneurs develop their business model, validate their ideas, and prepare to scale and grow (Hjalmarsson, 2022, p. 98-99). Having innovation support actors tied to larger universities enables research to be commercialized that otherwise would only stay within labs or take a lot longer to reach the market. This type of collaboration can also allow researchers to have a dual agenda and keep their job at the university while they pursue building a company.

Another aspect of the innovation system in Sweden is the emphasize and importance of networking and collaboration. Entrepreneurs are often assigned or connected with a business developer or mentor. This creates opportunities for knowledge exchange and enables startups to gain access to resources beyond financial capital. However, since there are so many different actors present in the same environment, it can lead to difficulties for entrepreneurs to navigate different structures.

From a growth perspective, the system of support actors can therefore be viewed as both an enabling and constraining infrastructure within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. This duality becomes relevant when examining a dynamic and process-based concept like growth.

3. SCIENTIFIC METHODOLOGY

The scientific methodology establishes the frameworks guiding the research. It introduces and defines the study´s research philosophy, including its ontological perspectives, epistemological standpoint and considerations regarding axiological. It also explains the reasoning behind the choice of research approach and concludes by presenting the conducted literature search.

3.1 Preunderstanding, Prior Experience and Choice of Topic

Preunderstanding refers to the author's prior experiences and knowledge about the field of interest. Disclosing this type of information is useful in understanding the choice of topic and research area. The previous experiences of the authors have potential to affect decisions made during the research period, and it might also influence who is asked to participate in the study based on the personal networks of the authors. Therefore, the authors have chosen to disclose information relevant to the topic of this thesis.

The two authors are currently both studying the 8th and final semester of a four-year business economics program at Umeå University. Both authors chose the business development and entrepreneurship field for the advanced courses this past fall. This choice gave the authors the ability to learn more about business growth and strategizing through periods of organizational change. Through courses in entrepreneurship, innovation and management, there has been multiple opportunities to create and develop a structural and systematic view on business growth, emphasizing scalability, strategic alignment and collaboration within ecosystems. It also provided a chance to work on a case for an external organization, aiming at providing evidence and suggestions for future development. All together and this past fall especially has resulted in shaping the author's perspective on continuous growth for new ventures or entrepreneurial businesses, as a multidimensional phenomenon. Existing familiarity with frameworks such as the Triple Helix model and ecosystem models may influence the authors to view and discuss growth as a collaborative network process rather than isolated on individual firm level. Furthermore, being present in a Nordic context influences a preunderstanding that innovation systems often are coordinated and institutionally supported, which may affect how the findings from the qualitative study is interpreted and related to sustained growth.

The process of choosing the topic for the research project, it was influenced by what the authors thought was interesting and manageable within the provided timeframe. Conducting a qualitative study with multiple respondents and from various groups and allowing for a comparative analysis can be challenging given the timeframe. Therefore, the personal and professional networks of the authors influence who is asked to participate.

One of the authors has several years of prior working experience from Connect Sverige region Uppsala, an organization operating within the innovation support system, specifically with supporting and coaching entrepreneurs in the process of raising capital from private investors. In the role as coordinator, she has participated in coaching meetings with entrepreneurs, pitching events for investors, as well as at meetups for innovations system actors. This experience has presented good insight into how different stakeholders perceive and support growth processes. Furthermore, it allowed for creating a building a professional network and existing relationships with potential respondents could influence both access and interpretation of findings, requiring conscious reflection throughout the research process.

3.2 Research Philosophy

Research philosophy is a term used to describe a system of beliefs and assumptions connected to the development of knowledge when conducting research (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 131). It establishes through what perspective the research should be conducted and later analyzed. Clearly stating and developing and understanding from which perspective the research will be conducted based on are crucial steps in generating trustworthy and useful research findings (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 132).

There are many different parts to research philosophy, and it is important to establish these beforehand to relate back to them in the analysis part of the research. There are five main philosophies that are often seen in business and management research; positivism, critical realism, interpretivism, postmodernism, and pragmatism (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 146). Positivism describes a strictly science-based reality, and everything exists independently of the researcher. Critical realism focuses on explaining what a person is experiencing through underlying structures of reality (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 149). There are layers to observable reality through the perspective of critical realism and there are two main steps to understanding the world, first it is experienced and later it is processed and reflected upon. The third philosophy referred to as interpretivism was originally developed as a critique to positivism (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 150). This philosophy empathizes that reality can be perceived in different ways depending on the observer. The purpose of the interpretivism philosophy is to create new and deeper understating of the social world as it is constantly changing. Postmodernism philosophy evolves around the importance of language in the ongoing change of the world and therefore how reality is observed. Using language, reality is believed to be created and changed through processes like organizing and managing. Lastly, pragmatism is a research philosophy that views theories and concepts not in an abstract way, but instead what role they play as instruments to understand reality and most importantly research findings (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 153). Pragmatism explains that there are many possible ways to interpret the world, and there is no single point of view that can create a whole picture of reality. Pragmatism also allows for multiple realities to exist simultaneously.

Since this study will involve three different perspectives and the use of models like Triple Helix and triangulation, this study will adopt an interpretivism philosophy. Understanding the social world through experiences will be crucial when conducting a qualitative study with multiple stakeholders who are all in relation to each other. Growth is also a process which should not be perceived as static, but instead shaped by decisions, perceptions, and social interactions. The findings of this study will emerge from the dialogue between the researchers and participants, allowing for a deeper understanding of the reasons behind the concept of continuous growth.

The research philosophy further affects the choices made within ontology, epistemology, and axiology, which all three will be presented further and in relation to the specific research question. In addition to these three, it is also important to be aware of reflexivity, described by Saunder et al ., (2023, p. 132) as one's ability to question their own thinking and actions and how personal beliefs and assumptions might impact the process or analysis of the findings. Keeping this in mind throughout the whole process will be important and something to reflect on when discussing the findings.

Since this study aims to understand how continuous growth is enabled and experiences through interactions between multiple stakeholders within the entrepreneurial ecosystem, the interpretivist philosophy becomes suitable. The study focuses on relationships, expectations

and interpretations, which are all social processes. Therefore, it becomes important to capture the subjective meanings attached to how growth develops by the three stakeholder groups. The entrepreneurial ecosystem is also characterized by overlapping institutional roles and informal networks, making continuous growth a socially constructed and relational phenomenon rather than an objective outcome. An interpretivist perspective therefore enables the researchers to explore the complexity and multidimensional nature of growth by recognizing that different stakeholders might hold different values and views on the topic.

3.2.1 Ontological Considerations

Ontology involves assumptions about the world around us and more specifically how the researchers view reality (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 134). Adopting an interpretivism philosophy refers to viewing the reality as subjective and with everyone constructing their own perceptions (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 43). Continuous growth in businesses is therefore not viewed as a phenomenon existing independently of surrounding actors, but instead as something shaped through the interpretations and interactions between entrepreneurs, investors and actors within the innovation support system.

What constitutes successful continuous growth may differ depending on the stakeholder's experiences and personal assumptions. This study assumes that multiple realities coexist, and that understanding continuous growth requires exploring how these realities are constructed and developed within networks and through the relationship between different stakeholders. Rather than seeking an objective explanation for sustained growth, this research aims to explore and interpret the diverse understanding that shapes how growth processes are perceived and acted upon in practice.

A subjectivist ontological position is relevant for this thesis because the concept of continuous growth is not assumed to have one universal meaning shared across different actors within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. The study therefore assumes that reality is socially constructed through interactions between the actors. This ontological standpoint becomes important when examining the Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem, where collaboration and networks shape how growth is enabled. By adopting this subjectivist perspective, the research allows themselves to capture the multiple realities and interpretations that influence the relational dynamics of continuous growth.

3.2.2 Epistemological Considerations

Aligned with the study's interpretivist ontology, this research adopts a subjectivist epistemology position. Epistemology refers to the assumption of knowledge and includes what is considered acceptable and valid (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 43; Saunder et al., 2023, p. 134). Subjectivism specifically refers to understanding different narratives and allows the researcher to interpret findings while keeping their own values. In contrast to objectivism, where the researcher is believed to detach themselves completely from and interpret findings objectively (Saunder et al., 2023, p. 138). A subtheme of subjectivism is referred to as social constructivism and is explained to be present when knowledge is constructed through social interaction and realities are created intersubjectively. Understanding what shapes continuous growth will therefore be generated through engaging with the lived experiences and assumptions of entrepreneurs, investors and actors within the innovation support system. The researcher is not seen as a detached observer, but instead an active participant, co-constructing the meaning while interpreting the findings.

This contrasts with a positivist epistemology which assumes that knowledge can be obtained and developed through objective measurements like hypothesis testing, independent of the researchers' influence. If adopting a positivist approach, continuous growth would instead have to be interpreted as a measurable outcome, probably connected to revenue or market reach. Rather than seeking universal findings that can be generalized, this study aims to develop a deeper knowledge of how growth is enabled and sustained over time through the interplay between stakeholders.

3.2.3 Axiology

Axiology is a fundamental branch of research philosophy that explores the role of values and ethics throughout the entire research process (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 136). In the field of business administration, it addresses critical questions regarding what is deemed desirable or "good" for both individuals and society (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 136). This philosophical dimension is essential because researchers are inherently guided by their own belief systems, which inevitably influence how a study is conducted and which findings are prioritized (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 137). Essentially, the researcher is an integral part of the inquiry and cannot be fully separated from the work, resulting in a degree of subjectivity that shapes the choice of the research question, scientific approach, and methodology (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 137). Furthermore, an axiological lens provides a necessary framework for understanding ethics. A researcher's values can internationally or unintentionally steer data collection toward a path that confirms their own preconceived views (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 138).

Within the context of this study, the formulation of the research question and the specific nature of the theories applied necessitate high involvement in every stage of the research. The choice of data collection reflects a specific value placed on interacting respondents to gain their unique perspectives on the theoretical frameworks being utilized. However, in accordance with established academic standards, the authors plan to implement rigorous precautions to ensure that personal biases do not misdirect interviews or lead to the misinterpretation of respondent data (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 138).

3.3 Research Approach

The research approach refers to how the research will be conducted. There are three main types called deduction, induction and adduction.

A study following a deductive approach is based on a "top-down" method, where researchers base their work on existing theories and collect specific data to test if the theory holds up. Deduction requires the researchers to develop hypotheses that will be tested by collecting data (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 156). It is therefore more common in natural sciences when there is often a strong relationship between variables. Basing the research on testing rather than observing often involves quantitative methods, ensuring possible replication is another important aspect of the deductive research approach. Since this approach is based on existing theory, there is a need for generalization to allow for connecting the new data with what already exists. This means that the sample needs to be of sufficient size and reduce any bias or other factors that might affect the level of possible replication. A deductive approach is often tied to quantitative studies and follows a positivist philosophy.

The second type of research approach is induction, and it can be viewed as the opposite to deduction. Induction follows a "bottom-up" approach and is when research instead collects data in a more explorative way, aiming at creating new theories rather than testing existing

ones. An inductive research approach is also more connected to an interpretivist philosophy (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 157) and therefore often entails a qualitative study based on a smaller sample.

The third and last type of research approach is abduction and different to the two other types. This one allows the researcher to move back and forth between data and theory. Instead of basing the research in moving from theory to data as in deduction or the opposite pattern in induction, abduction can be described as a combination of the two previous types (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 158). Adapting this type of approach involves collecting data alongside using pre-existing theory to enable interpretations of new data in line with existing patterns through theory.

3.3.1 Choice of Research Approach

While this study will include inductive elements, it is mostly characterized as abductive. Existing frameworks are included in this research, including different models of growth and ecosystems like the Five Stages of Growth (Churchill & Lewis, 1978) and the Triple Helix (Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, 1995). These frameworks will allow for the research to have a starting point and for categorizing the stakeholders into three groups. The theories used, however, will not act as hypotheses to be tested, as would be the case for a deductive approach. Instead, they will shape the analytical sensitivity of the researchers and give the findings something to build upon. Moving between empirical findings and existing theory reflects an abductive research approach. This study aims to be theoretically informed, rather than freed from theory as if it followed an indistinctive research approach. Therefore, the concept of continuous growth will be explored through the participants in the qualitative study, without pre-determined hypotheses. However, the findings will be thematically analyzed based on established frameworks, concluding in an overall explorative workflow.

An abductive approach was considered most suitable for this study since the research process involved a continuous movement between empirical findings and the theoretical development. The study initially departed from existing theories related to entrepreneurial growth, ecosystems and the Triple Helix model, the theoretical framework was not fully finalized prior to the data collection process began. Instead, the findings from the semi-structured interviews contributed with new perspectives and patterns that influenced which theoretical concepts were further explored and later included in chapter 2. The iterative movement between empirical data and theory allowed the researchers to be open to unexpected findings while still grounding the analysis in existing literature.

3.4 Literature Search

The purpose of the literature search is to gain a deeper understanding of the existing literature connected to the topic of this research (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 67). It is important to identify and synthesize existing research related to the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and actors within the innovation support system. How the relationships shape continuous growth and what enables and restricts that process. Conducting a structured search contributes to clarifying the concept of long-term growth. It is also an important step in finding the research gap.

To begin the literature and gain a better understanding of the topic of growth in general, literature reviews like Shah et al,. (2013), Achtenhagen et al,. (2010) and Audretsch et al,.

(2023), were found and read. These reviews provided general insights as well as mentions of useful models to explain the concept of growth. From the reviews, models that were thought to be relevant for this study were further examined and found from their original source. The reference lists of the literature reviews were also examined to find additional sources, to gain deeper insight into the chosen subject.

Umeå University library database was used as the primary source for finding articles. Google Scholar was another way of finding articles that provided useful information. Other ways to find digital articles was through searching industry specific databases, like the *Journal of Small Business and Entrepreneurship*, *Journal of Business and Economics Research, Small Business Economics, Journal of Small Business Strategy, International Small Business Journal and Harvard Business Review*. These databases were selected due to their broad coverage of peer-reviewed articles within entrepreneurship and innovation studies. Additionally, physical books were borrowed from the university library, some being course literature from previous courses the authors had attended.

The search process was guided by combinations of keywords related to the core concept of the study. These included "entrepreneur", "investor", "innovation support system", "entrepreneurial ecosystem", "Swedish innovation ecosystem", "short-term growth", "long-term growth", "drivers of growth", "measurements of growth", "models to show business growth", "growth vs scaling", "scale-up gap", "Triple Helix", "triangulation". Boolean operators "AND" and "OR" were used to refine the searches for relevant literature.

To ensure relevance and quality, the publication date and the number of citations on a paper were considered when choosing to include the source. Additionally, methodological rigor and relevance of the research question were key factors in the evaluation process. Other ways were to cross-check the references against similar articles. Having a mix of recent and older studies ensures that the information is historically grounded, while still being updated to contemporary standards. Finding original sources for models of growth was important to be able to understand the more recent adaptations. Including multiple sources supporting the same concepts strengthens the reliability of the information. A mix of Swedish and English sources were included, due to the explanation of the Swedish innovation ecosystem being a kay part of the study. Generic models of growth were searched for in English, while the description of certain actors of the ecosystem was mainly found in Swedish and from nonacademic sources, such as company websites or government department reports.

Despite efforts to aim for a comprehensive review, there were some limitations to this process. The main limitation is the time constraint of conducting this research and writing thesis. At a certain point, the data collection had to be prioritized over continuing the literature search further with the same intensity. The process did however continue throughout the whole research, and the same process was applied. Another limitation is that the only articles that could be included had to be in either Swedish or English since those are the two languages that the authors are sufficient in. Additionally, database selection and choice of keywords also have the potential to influence the scope of the literature that becomes available. Lastly, the literature search revealed a gap in understanding how the dynamic interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors shapes continuous growth, rather than being studied in isolation.

4. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter introduces the choices made regarding research design. It will also explain how the research will be conducted in terms of sampling methods, data collection, and the structure behind the interview guide. It will further display how the collected data will be analyzed through the application of thematic analysis and coding. In addition, this chapter will address how the quality of the research was ensured and what ethical considerations guided the research process.

4.1 Research Design

The research design serves as the fundamental strategy for organizing the various elements of a study into a cohesive and sensible framework. Its primary purpose is to ensure the research problem is tackled effectively by providing a clear roadmap for collecting and analyzing data. It acts as a structure that allows researchers to use the evidence, they collect to answer their research question with as little ambiguity as possible. While there are three standard paths, quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods, the choice depends heavily on the specific nature of the research questions (Williams, 2007, p. 65; Yilmaz, 2013).

For this study, qualitative research design was selected as the most appropriate path to explore the intricate, non-linear dynamics of the Swedish innovation ecosystem. Unlike quantitative designs that prioritize numerical generalizability, a qualitative approach allows for an in-depth examination of the "how" and "why" behind venture growth. This choice is justified by the need to capture the subjective experiences of diverse stakeholders, which cannot be reduced to isolated variables without losing the contextual richness of the Triple Helix environment. By prioritizing the depth of data over breadth, this design aligns with the study's goal of uncovering underlying relational tensions and synergies that characterize the scaling of new ventures in Sweden.

4.1.1 Research Strategy

The research strategy of this thesis is exploratory, since the purpose is to gain deeper understanding of how continuous growth is shaped through interactions and interplay between stakeholder groups. Since the relational dynamics between these groups are context-dependent and not sufficiently explored in previous literature, an exploratory strategy (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 5) allows the researchers to investigate experiences and perceptions without limiting the analysis to predefined concepts and frameworks.

The abductive approach is further reflected in the application of the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013) where movement between empirical data and theoretical concepts enables the development of themes and dimensions. This process allows the findings to be grounded in participants' experiences, while still contributing to theoretical development.

Abductive and explorative strategies encourage alignment between the study's research question, theoretical framework and methodological choices, enabling a comprehensive analysis of continuous growth as a complex concept.

4.1.2 Research Method

The primary research method employed in this study is semi-structured qualitative interviewing, supported by rigorous framework of triangulation. This choice is fundamentally driven by the need to explore complex social processes within the Swedish innovation ecosystem that are not

easily quantifiable. According to Williams (2007, p. 65), qualitative methods are superior when the researcher seeks to function as an active interpretive agent, capturing the "how" and "why" of a phenomenon from the perspective of those experiencing it. By utilizing semi-structured interviews rather than a questionnaire, the researchers can maintain a thematic focus while simultaneously leaving sufficient "conversational space" to pursue unexpected but relevant insights that emerge during the dialogue.

4.1.3 Triangulation

Since the environment explained by the Triple Helix model is non-linear, and involve multiple actors, triangulation will be used to capture these different perspectives and allow for a deeper understanding of the interrelationships between the three main pillars. Triangulation is described by Fusch et al,. (2018, p. 26) to be a "way in which one explores different levels and perspectives of the same phenomenon". Collis & Hussey (2021, p. 63) describes the concept to be a powerful tool in research since it can reduce overall bias.

Triangulation is a methodological model used to capture and interpret multiple sources of data. This can enhance the reliability of the overall study and the results (Fusch et al,. 2018, p. 20). When multiple different actors are included in a qualitative study, triangulation aims to facilitate a better understanding of interplay between these actors, a perspective that might get lost in standard qualitative analysis. Triangulation is often used in explorative studies that allow for multiple realities to be present parallel to each other. The method can also counteract the potential bias that might be present in qualitative research due to inconsistent sampling. Looking at the proposed research question through multiple lenses minimizes the risk of the researcher applying a personal lens and therefore enforcing bias into the study (Fusch et al., 2018, p. 21).

Triangulation and the use of multiple sources of data can also enable higher levels of transferability of the findings in a study since it uses different starting points to create a path ahead (Fusch et al,. 2018, p. 22). There are four main types of triangulations, first mentioned by Denzin in the 1970s and described now by Fusch et al,. (2018, p. 22). The first type being *Data Triangulation*, which refers to different data points, however, regarding the same event in time. The second type is referred to as *Investigator Triangulation*, this type instead focuses on the researchers and that more people interacting with the data will lead to less bias since the research will then be interpreted through multiple lenses. The third variation of triangulation is called *Theory Triangulation*, and it is when multiple different theories are applied to the same data set. Applying contradictory theories to a single data set tests the data further than through linear analysis. The last type is the *Methodological Triangulation*, and it is when multiple methods of data collection are present simultaneously. This can be within the qualitative research design through interviews, observations and focus groups, or a mix of qualitative and quantitative methods (Fusch et al,. 2018, p. 23).

This method can be seen in this study through data triangulation, achieved by collecting and analyzing the perspectives of three different stakeholder groups. Researching the concept of growth from these different viewpoints allows the study to have a multi-dimensional nature. This approach enables finding both converging and diverging perspectives, which becomes important in understanding differences in expectations and role descriptions between the participants. Triangulation supports the study's aim to understand the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and support actors rather than relying on individual perspectives. Additionally, investigator triangulation is present since both researchers have been present

during the data collection process as well as analyzing and interpreting the data. Applying a collaborative process like triangulation increases the analytical rigor and reduces the influence of individual bias. Overall, triangulation strengthens the credibility and depth of the empirical findings.

4.1.4 Semi-structured Interviews

To bridge the gap between theoretical frameworks and the practical realities of the Swedish startup ecosystems, this study employs semi-structured interviews as its primary empirical instrument. This methodological choice is driven by the ambition to explore the intricate interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors. This type of relationship dynamic is inherently subjective and context dependent. Williams (2007, p. 65) argues that qualitative methods are essential when the research seeks to understand the "how" and "why" of a phenomenon. That positions the researchers as the active agent who must interpret the descriptive meanings provided by participants. By utilizing a semi-structured format rather than a rigid questionnaire, the researchers can maintain the thematic focus on the drivers of continuous growth while leaving sufficient "conversational space" to pursue unexpected but relevant insights that emerged during the dialogue.

The strategic importance of this design lies in its ability to facilitate a deep dive into the lived experiences across different stakeholder groups. According to Yilmaz (2013, p. 312), the strength of qualitative inquiry is found in its capacity to reveal the complex social processes and interrelated variables that characterize human systems. In this study, the "system" is the Swedish innovation ecosystem, and the relational bonds and support mechanisms that foster long-term venture growth. To ensure the findings are representative of the national context, a geographical sampling strategy was implemented which involve respondents from the northern, middle, and southern regions of Sweden. This regional spread is vital, as it accounts for the potential impact of localized innovation clusters, varying access to venture capital, and the specific mandates of regional support actors, on a firm's growth trajectory.

Semi-structured interviews were particularly valuable for this study since it allowed the researchers to explore complex relationship dependent dynamics and subjective interpretations connected to how continuous growth is achieved. The interview guide ensured that all three stakeholder groups were asked to reflect on similar themes, at the same time, the flexible structure enabled the interviewers to ask follow-up questions to clarify meanings and explore unexpected insights that emerged during the interviews. In addition, the conversational nature of the interviews allowed the respondents to elaborate on their own experiences and relational processes that might not have emerged through a more standardized or strict form of data collection.

4.2 Data Collection

The following section details the methodology employed to identify specific data sources and determine the appropriate sample size for this case study. It further clarifies the strategic logic behind the selection process and provides a transparent account of how the final group of respondents were both identified and contacted, as summarized in Table 1.

The regions refer to geographical locations in Sweden. North was centered around Umeå, the East region can be found around Uppsala, and the mix of South and West refers to Malmö and Gothenburg. The participants have been assigned codes as a way of keeping their identity anonymous. The codes are made up of traditional Swedish names, women and men have been

assigned code names accordingly and each stakeholder type has been given names starting with the same letters, **E** for entrepreneurs, **I** for investors and lastly **S** for support actors.

Table 1. Data Collection Summary

Region	Stakeholder type	Interview length	Code
North	Entrepreneur	55 minutes	Elliot
North	Investor – business angel	42 minutes	Ida
North	Support actor – Public agency	30 minutes	Sigge
North	Support actor – non-profit accelerator	40 minutes	Signe
North	Support actor – non-profit accelerator	68 minutes	Sture
North	Support actor – university incubator	51 minutes	Sigurd
East	Entrepreneur	35 minutes	Eivor
East	Investor – business angel	42 minutes	Igor
East	Support actor – university incubator	55 minutes	Stellan
South/West	Entrepreneur	40 minutes	Elmer
South/West	Investor – risk capital / public holding	55 minutes	Ines
South/West	Support actor – non-profit accelerator	67 minutes	Selma

4.2.1 Data Selection and Sampling

The selection of interview respondents and the determination of the final sample size for this study were fundamentally guided by the necessity to obtain high-quality, specialized insights into the complex interactions that drive continuous growth in Swedish new ventures. To achieve this level of depth, a purposive, information-based selection criteria was utilized (Jacobsen, 2017, p. 120). This methodological choice is grounded in the belief that for a qualitative study to be effective, respondents must be selected based on their specific expertise and first-hand experience within the subject of interest. Rather than employing a random sampling technique, the researchers targeted three distinct stakeholder groups: entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors to allow a triangulation of the collected data. This diversity in the participants is essential for uncovering the relational interplays and potential systemic tensions that a single-actor perspective might overlook.

To ensure that the research captured a representative view of the Swedish innovation landscape, a width and variation-based selection was applied (Jacobsen, 2017, p. 121) in relation to geographical distribution. Recognizing that innovation ecosystems are often influenced by regional infrastructure and local economic climates, the sample was drawn from three different regions in Sweden. These included the North (centered around the entrepreneurial hub of Umeå), the East (focused on the innovation-heavy Uppsala region), and a combination of the South and West (represented by the industrial and tech centers of Malmö and Gothenburg). This spatial variation prevents regional bias and ensures that the findings account for different types of support and investment environments present across the country. In total, twelve in-depth interviews were conducted giving a data set result of 580 minutes. With an average session duration of 48 minutes, reaching a point of theoretical saturation, the primary themes regarding growth mechanisms and actor synergies became consistently recurring. This selection process (detailed in Table 1) ensures that the empirical foundation of the study is both robust and deeply rooted in the practical realities of the Swedish innovation ecosystem.

4.2.2 Interview Guide

To ensure a balance between structure and conversational flexibility, a comprehensive interview guide was developed prior to conducting the semi-structured interviews (see Table 2 below). This guide served as a strategic framework to keep the dialogue centered on the core research objectives, preventing the collection of peripheral data that might weaken the study's focus. By acting as a thematic script, the guide ensured that the most critical questions were addressed systematically, thereby maximizing the utility of each session while remaining respectful of the participants' professional time.

The formulation phase played an important role in framing questions that were non-intrusive and open-ended. This deliberate phrasing was intended to establish a rapport of trust, ensuring that respondents did not feel overwhelmed or defensive. By avoiding a confrontational or overly personal tone, the researchers aimed to foster an environment where entrepreneurs, investors, and support actors felt comfortable sharing authentic insights and truthful responses regarding their experiences within the innovation ecosystem.

Following this approach, the interview guide was thoroughly constructed to feature questions that were short, clear, and designed to stimulate an expansive dialogue rather than short answers. As emphasized by Bolderston (2012, p. 70), the efficacy of qualitative data collection is often contingent upon the use of accessible language, therefore, the researchers deliberately avoided overly academic and technical terminology that might be unfamiliar to the interviewees. Instead, the guide utilized simplified, relatable phrasing that allowed participants to articulate their experiences without the barrier of exclusionary language. To ensure the highest level of spontaneity and to capture unfiltered reactions, the specific questions were not provided to the participants in advance. This strategy was employed to mitigate the risk of respondents providing rehearsed or pre-formulated answers, thereby ensuring that the data reflected their genuine perspectives on the interplay within the Swedish innovation ecosystem.

While the guide differed slightly depending on stakeholder group, the overall themes are consistent to enable comparison between entrepreneurs, investors and innovations support actors. The English version of the interview guide is presented below as it formed the foundation for the interviews that were conducted during the data collection. The Swedish translation of the interview guide is presented in Appendix 1.

Table 2. Interview Guide in English

Interview Guide	English
General Questions	▫ Describe your role and what you do for work ▫ How would you define continuous business growth? ▫ What distinguishes continuous growth from short-term growth? ▫ In your experience, what characterizes companies that manage to grow over time? *Growth Process* ▫ Can you describe a company that you have seen achieve sustained growth? What enabled it? ▫ What are the biggest challenges companies face in maintaining growth over time?

	▫ How important are networks and relationships for sustaining growth?
Entrepreneur	*Internal perspective* ▫ What do you believe is your main responsibility in shaping continuous growth? ▫ What capabilities are most critical for sustaining growth over time? ▫ How does your role evolve as the company grows? *Investors* ▫ What do you expect from investors to sustain long-term growth? ▫ Beyond capital, what type of support is most valuable? ▫ What do investors sometimes misunderstand about growth? *Innovation support system* ▫ What role do support organizations play in shaping continuous growth? ▫ Where do they add the most value? ▫ What could they improve to better support sustained growth?
Investor	*Investment logic* ▫ How do you assess whether a company has potential for sustained growth? ▫ What signals indicate long-term scalability versus short-term traction? *Entrepreneurs* ▫ What do entrepreneurs need to do differently to enable continuous growth? ▫ What are common mistakes that founders make when it comes to shaping long-term growth? ▫ How should entrepreneurs evolve as their companies' scale? *Innovation support system* ▫ How important are incubators, accelerators, and public actors in shaping growth? ▫ What do they do well? ▫ Where do they fall short? ▫ What should they prioritize to better enable sustained growth?
Innovation Support System	*Organizational role* ▫ How do you see your organization´s role in shaping continuous growth? ▫ At what stage is your support most critical? *Entrepreneurs* ▫ What capabilities do entrepreneurs need to develop sustained growth? ▫ Where do entrepreneurs often struggle? ▫ What should entrepreneurs focus on beyond early-stage development? *Investors* ▫ What role do investors play in shaping long-term growth?

	▫ Where do investors contribute most effectively? ▫ Are there tensions between investment logic and long-term growth?
Closing General Questions	▫ If you could change one thing in the ecosystem to better enable continuous growth, what would it be? ▫ What is something in collaboration with either of the other two groups that can be done or implemented to better enable continuous growth? ▫ Is there anything we have not discussed that you believe is critical for understanding sustained growth in businesses?

4.2.3 Interview Process

The practical execution of these interviews followed a hybrid administrative model to accommodate the significant geographical distances between the Swedish regions. Where logistically feasible, in-person interviews were conducted at the participants' offices or local innovation hubs. These face-to-face sessions offered a setting that enhanced the interpretive quality of the data, allowing the researchers to better observe the tone and body language of the participants. For participants located in distant regions or where scheduling constraints existed, interviews were conducted via Microsoft Teams. This digital approach was treated with the same academic rigor as the in-person sessions, initiated with consent agreement, and the same interview guide was followed. The in-person interviews as well as the ones conducted online were recorded after asking the participant for consent.

By adopting this dual-modality approach, the study ensures that data collection remains both inclusive and robust, facilitating a detailed transcription process that preserves the authentic voices of the participants. Centering the methodology on these detailed dialogues allows the research to move beyond superficial growth metrics and instead uncover the underlying relational tensions and synergies that characterize the scaling and growth of new ventures in Sweden. This prioritizes the depth of the data over its breadth, a focus that is consistent with the qualitative tradition described by Yilmaz (2013, p. 315). The analysis is firmly grounded in the complex, real-world interactions within the Swedish innovation support system, providing a nuanced understanding of the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and support actors.

4.3 Data Analysis

Data analysis refers to the process of analyzing the qualitative data that was collected through the semi-structured interviews. Since there were three different stakeholder groups included in the data collection, a method allowing for analyzing the qualitative data in a structured format is needed. The following sections will explain the theoretical framework for the methodology and the practical implementation of coding and theme generation.

4.3.1 Gioia Methodology

First introduced in 1991 by Gioia & Chittipeddi, the Gioia methodology focuses on understanding someone's experiences and how they choose to construct their surroundings, rather than aiming at how frequently something occurs (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 16). This methodology was explicitly selected for this thesis because it offers a highly structured and transparent framework that effectively bridges the gap between rich, subjective qualitative

descriptions and rigorous, systemic academic analysis. By utilizing this approach, the thesis can move beyond mere storytelling. It transforms deeply personal narrative accounts into robust and scientifically grounded conceptual dimensions that remain fundamentally loyal to the participants lived realities. This sets the method apart from others in a way that allows for capturing social concepts that correspond both to the people who have experienced it, as well as for the researchers. The Gioia method treats the respondents as "knowledgeable agents", meaning that their thoughts, opinions and experiences should be considered in the form that they are delivered and the researchers act as reporters, trying to capture the responses without imposing prior constructs or theories (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 17). The primary benefit of adapting this method for this specific thesis is that it establishes a high level of qualitative validity. Furthermore, it prevents the empirical findings from becoming prematurely constrained or biased by existing literature. Thereby it is allowing new and unexpected conceptual categories and genuine practitioner nuances regarding the chosen phenomenon to emerge organically from the data. The authors thought about this when designing the interview guide and included opening questions to have the interviewees defining growth, rather than summarizing existing theory and presenting it, risking shifting their perspectives. Including open ended questions that are non-specific is a big part of laying the groundwork of adapting the Gioia method (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 19), the aim is to capture sayings or expressions that otherwise wouldn't have come up if the question was too directed.

Another key part of the method is that the voices of the respondents should be heard early in the data gathering and then stay as intact as possible throughout the analysis part of the research. Gioia et al,. (2013, p. 22) explains that the method was originally formulated for inductive research that is based on the collected data that later moves into theory. In this research, an abductive approach has been adapted, referring to having the theory as a basis for data collection. However, there is also room for moving from the data back to theory once the data collection and analysis is finalized.

4.3.2 Concepts, Themes and Aggregated Dimensions

The analysis part of the Gioia methodology is divided into three parts. The first part is categorizing the responses, essentially finding everything that has value and is relevant to the research question. As described by Gioia et al,. (2013, p. 20), this can be up to 100 categories for 10 interviews. These 1st order categories are gathered still using the language and expressions of the respondents. Having this many categories to work with can feel overwhelming, therefore the next step is to look for similarities or differences between the categories, group them together and form concepts. Once they are grouped, they are given labels and they then lay the basis for creating the 2nd order themes. It is in this step that the researchers become "knowledgeable agents" (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 17) and they form themes based on the concepts from the first step. It is also in this step of the analysis that the researchers ask themselves in what way the themes that have emerged from the respondent's answers can help answer or understand the research question (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 20). There should be a focus on finding themes that might not be found in previous literature and understanding how those findings might still be relevant for the research topic. Once the 1st order concepts and the 2nd order themes have been analyzed, the third and final step is to sort these into aggregated dimensions, clustering the findings into sections that will be used for the discussion. Using the findings from all three steps and using it against relevant literature will tell the researchers if they have been able to discover new concepts through their research (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 21). If more than one researcher is present there is an increased need for agreement in data coding

since there is a higher risk that the data will be interpreted differently based on personal beliefs and experiences (Gioia et al,. 2013, p. 22), a way to combat this is to revisit the data throughout the analysis and discuss the concepts and themes among the researchers.

Together, the concepts, themes, and aggregated dimensions illustrate how continuous growth is shaped through the interplay between the actors included in the study. It also sheds light on mechanisms enabling this process as well as underlying tensions and challenges. While this structure organizes the empirical findings, it also highlights the complexity and interconnectedness of the growth process.

4.4 Research Quality

Ensuring the quality of the data in research is of great importance and it can be done through different concepts and criteria. Traditionally, research quality was assessed through reliability and validity. However, in qualitative research, these concepts become technically inappropriate to use (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 216). This is because reality assumes to be socially constructed and based on interpretive assumptions. Therefore, this study applies the criteria of like credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability, better suited for qualitative studies (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 161).

Credibility refers to if the research was carried out in a way that correctly captures the research question (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 161; Saunders et al., 2023, p. 217). To establish credibility, the researchers must ensure that the participants' perspective and answers are correctly represented in the findings and analysis of the research. Credibility was strengthened using triangulation of data from the interviews, including three stakeholder groups, entrepreneurs, investors, and support actors. The primary data was collected alongside secondary sources, as well as a continuous discussion between the two authors. All the interviews were recorded and later transcribed, ensuring that everything that was said was being captured and later analyzed. Notes were also taken during the interviews to allow the interviewer to stay present and to follow up questions in the moment. The interviews were all conducted in Swedish, while the data was kept as close to the transcripts an AI software was used to translate it to English. Including quotes in the empirical findings chapter, it is possible that the meaning might have been slightly altered.

Transferability is concerned with how well the findings can be applied to another study (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 161). Providing in-depth descriptions of the research methodology, the research question and the findings of the study, presents the reader with the opportunity to replicate the research themselves or in another setting (Saunders et al., 2023, p. 217). Transferability was addressed in this study by providing descriptions of the Swedish innovation ecosystem and the characteristics of the interviewees, keeping them anonymous. Additionally, detailed information about the sample, including the number of interviewees, and the distribution between the stakeholder groups, was included. While this study focuses on Sweden, due to limitations, the findings might be transferable to similar small, open economies with developed innovation support systems. Including perspectives from multiple stakeholder groups further supports transferability by capturing a broader view of the ecosystem.

Dependability makes sure that the research process is logical, traceable, and well documented (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 161). This includes all practical parts of the research process, sampling, data collection, analysis, and coding. Data collection procedures, including

participant selection and interview structure, were clearly defined. A semi-structured interview guide was used in all interviews to ensure consistency, while at the same time allowing for flexibility in terms of follow-up questions and responses. In addition, the analytical process followed a systematic approach through the Gioia methodology, where empirical data was reviewed and categorized into themes, further enhancing the consistency of the analysis. A continuous discussion between the two authors also reduces inconsistencies in the analysis.

Confirmability concerns whether the findings have been interpreted by the researchers in a neutral and objective way (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 161). Confirmability was ensured by grounding the findings in empirical data. By collecting substantial data from 12 interviews and including quotes in the analysis, the credibility of the study was improved. Once again, ongoing discussions between the authors led to reduced bias in the interpretation of the data.

Certain limitations remain, particularly regarding the context-specific nature of the sample and the inherent subjectivity in qualitative analysis. This could be something to consider for future research to further improve the overall quality of the research.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

Ethical considerations are a central part to the research process since it refers to the morals and values of the researchers (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 27) and how they have taken steps towards ensuring that the participants feel safe and heard throughout the whole process. Research ethics was a present topic throughout the entire process, from planning the data collection, conducting interviews to analyzing, and presenting the findings.

This study involves three different stakeholder groups which raise specific ethical considerations related to confidentiality, potential power dynamics, and the handling of sensitive information. Participation in the study was entirely voluntary (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 29), and all interviewees were informed about the purpose of the study prior to the interviews. They were all sent a consent form, in line with the policies of the university, in advance to allow for time to review and digitally sign the form before the interview. During the interview process, all interviews, in-person or digitally, were recorded through Microsoft Teams. Before the recording was started, a verbal consent from each participant was obtained.

To ensure confidentiality and protect the identity of the participants, all data has been anonymized (Collis & Hussey, 2021, p. 29). All interviewees have been assigned code names, as a way of still including direct quotes but not refer to them by name, company or any other identifiable characteristics in the presentation of the empirical data. This approach of coding was necessary, especially due to the relatively small and interconnected nature of the Swedish innovation ecosystem. Individuals could otherwise be identifiable even through limited information. By informing the participants about the anonymous presentation of the data, the hope was to encourage honest answers.

The authors also acknowledge the potential for sensitive information to be shared during the interviews. Questions and discussions related to growth challenges, investment decisions, and organizational strategies are areas where respondents can be hesitant to share detailed information. To address this, the participants were given the option to refrain from answering or choosing to what extent they felt like answering the question. This has also been considered in the analysis of the data, as well as the presentation of the empirical findings, making sure to not reveal information that could negatively impact individuals or their organization.

In terms of data handling, all collected primary data has been stored securely and in line with the university policy. Access to the data, including recordings and transcripts, has been restricted to the researchers, as well as their supervisor. Overall, these ethical considerations have guided the research process from start to finish to ensure that the study is conducted in a responsible, transparent, and respectful way.

4.6 Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Artificial intelligence tools were used in a limited and supportive capacity during the writing of this thesis. The use has been restricted to assisting with specific aspects of the research design and literature search process, while all substantive decisions, interpretations, and final content remained the responsibility of the authors.

The authors used AI during the construction and development of the interview guide. In this context, the tools assisted in generating nuanced formulations of potential interview questions and prompts. This process helped refine the wording of the questions and develop prompts designed to encourage more comprehensive and reflective responses from the interview participants. To further facilitate the accuracy of these responses during the data collection phase, automated transcription features in Microsoft Teams were utilized. As well as forming the interview guide, AI was a part of the research planning phase to explore and compare different methodological approaches. By reviewing and comparing alternatives with the assistance of AI, it enabled the authors to better assess which research approach was most suitable for the objectives and design of this study.

In the process of literature searching, AI was a supporter in generating synonyms and related concepts associated with the key themes of the study. These additional search terms were incorporated into database searches to broaden the scope of the literature review and increase the likelihood of identifying relevant academic sources. In addition, Microsoft Word was employed to assist in the translation of data tables and empirical segments to ensure that the transition from the Swedish source material to the final English text remained consistent and professional.

In conclusion, Artificial Intelligence has functioned solely as a supportive instrument throughout the research process. All the methodologic choices and evaluations of relevance, as well as all interpretations of the findings were conducted and critically assessed by the authors.

5. EMPIRICAL FINDINGS AND ANALYSIS

The empirical findings and analysis showcase the results from the interviews. The data is presented separately based on stakeholder groups, entrepreneurs, investors, and actors from the innovation support system. The identified aggregated dimensions or themes are introduced and later discussed based on each of the stakeholder groups. Each of the group's findings are summarized in text and including direct quotes.

5.1 Identified Concepts, Themes and Aggregated Dimensions

This section presents the empirical findings in a structured process based on the Gioia method (Gioia, Corely & Hamilton, 2013). The analysis of the data is initiated by finding 1st order concepts in the participants' own expressions. These are then grouped into 2nd order themes, summarizing the many expressions into something more manageable. The themes are then grouped into aggregated dimensions that represent the overarching patterns found in the responses.

The purpose of creating this visual structure is to systematically reduce and organize the data while still maintaining a strong connection to the raw data, which can be found summarized in Appendices 2 to 4. The larger dimensions are easier to work with when attempting to relate the findings to the theoretical framework. The data had been organized based on stakeholder groups, and the aggregated dimensions of each individual group have later been compiled into one summarizing model.



Figure 4. The Entrepreneurial Perspective - Data Structure



Figure 5. The Investor Perspective - Data Structure

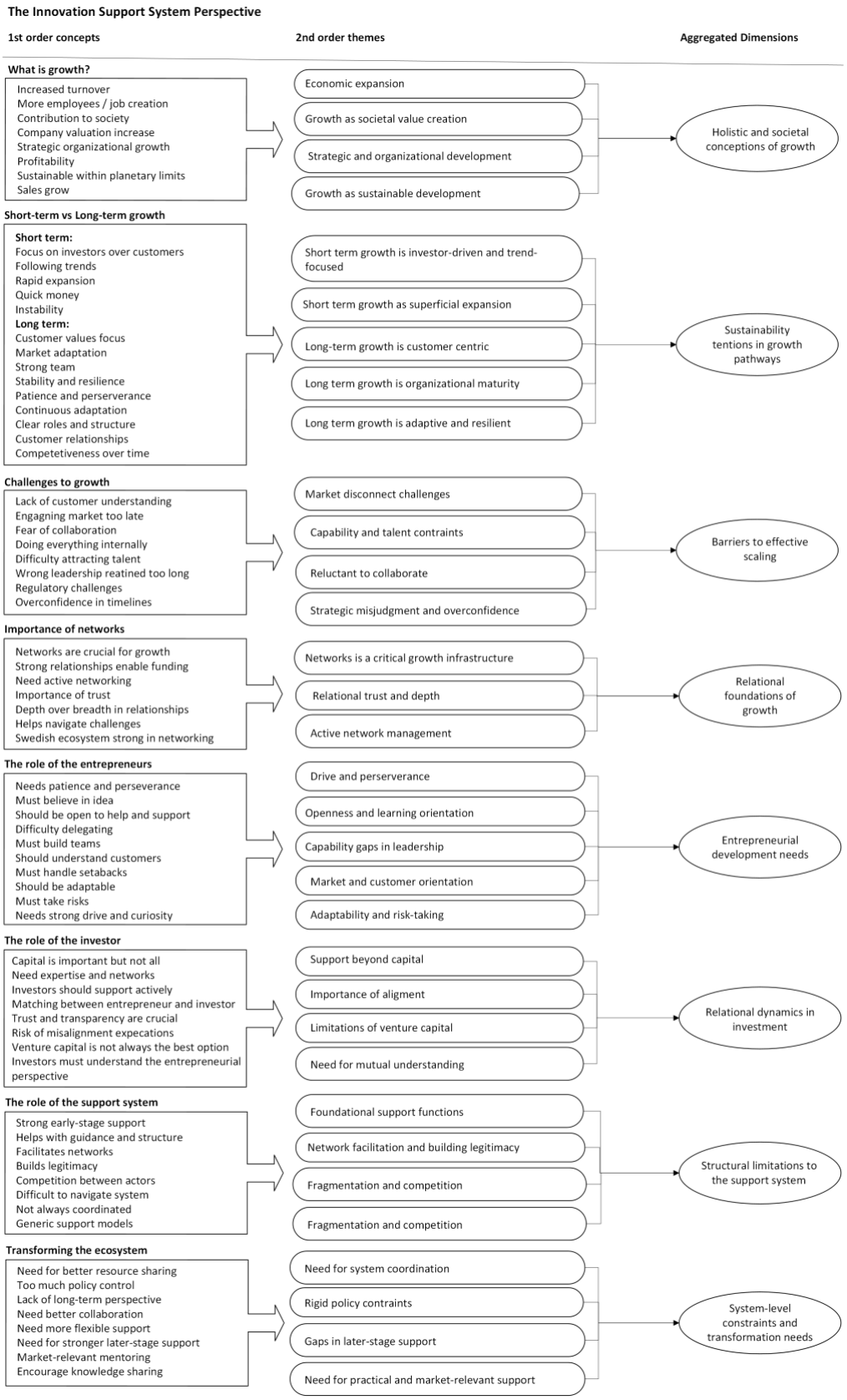


Figure 6. The Innovation Support System Perspective – Data Structure

The initial analysis across the three stakeholder groups generated multiple aggregated dimensions, reflecting the experiences of each group. Significant overlapping was identified, and similar concepts have therefore been synthesized into a smaller number of overarching categories. This merging of dimensions shifts the focus from actor specific perspectives to cross actor dynamics.

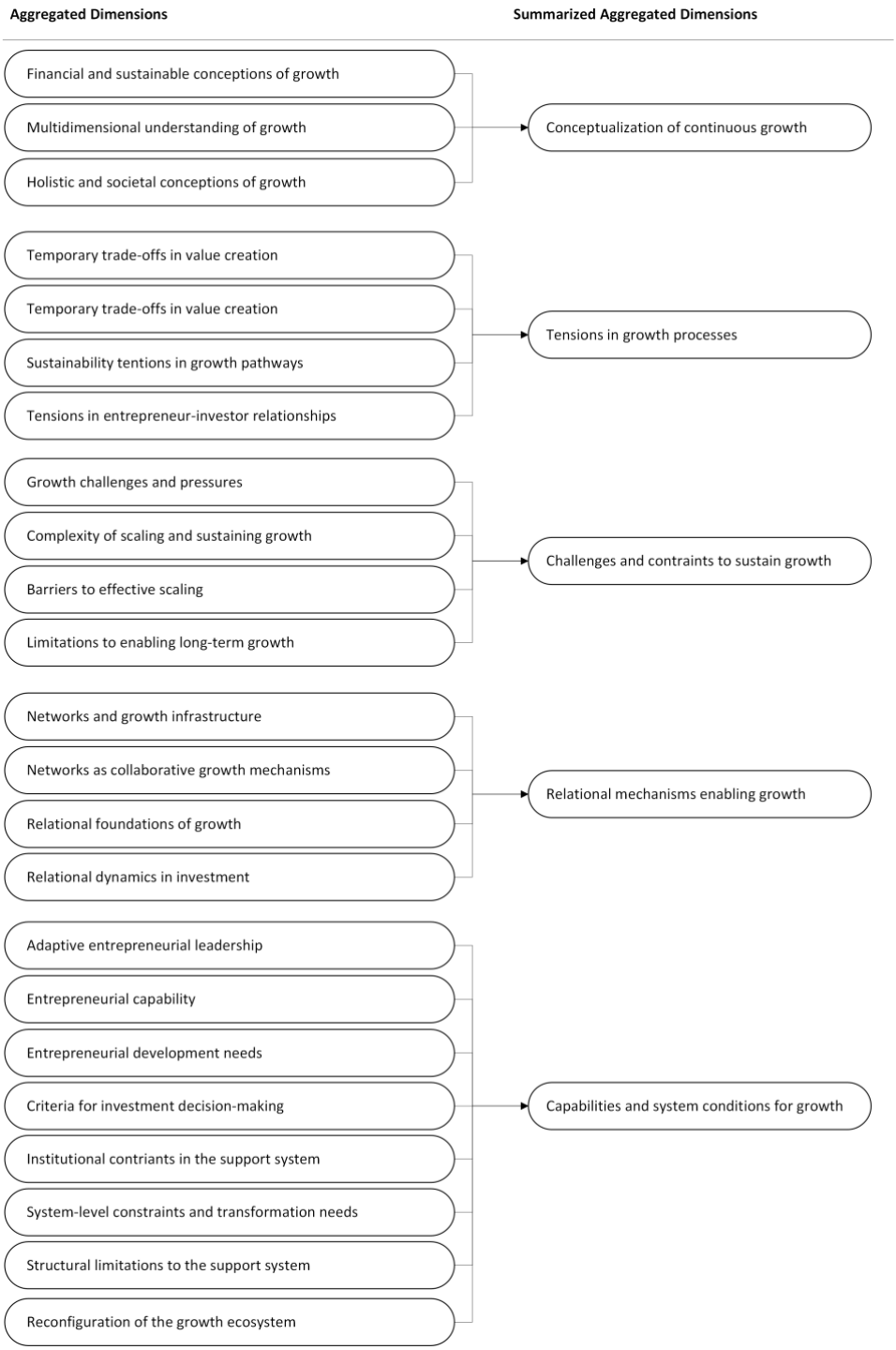


Figure 7. Summarized Aggregated Dimensions – Data Structure

5.2 Data Presentation

This chapter presents the empirical data collected through 12 semi-structured interviews with entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors across three primary Swedish regions. In accordance with the qualitative tradition, the following sections prioritize the "authentic voices" of the participants. They are being treated as knowledgeable agents whose experience construct the reality of Swedish innovation ecosystem. To ensure a logical flow, the findings are organized thematically, reflecting the interconnected drivers and measurements of growth identified during the data collection process.

The presentation of this data follows the systemic structure of the Gioia methodology and is moving from raw respondent expression to consolidated concepts. By utilizing a triangulated approach, the findings highlight the relational tensions and synergies between the three stakeholder groups and are providing a comprehensive view of the mechanisms that foster venture scaling. Each section integrates direct quotations to illustrate the depth of the participants' experiences. Ensuring that the empirical foundation remains grounded in the practical realities of the northern, eastern, and southern/western Swedish innovation hubs.

5.2.1 What is Growth?

The Entrepreneurs explained growth to be when a company moves from one phase to another. They also mentioned that the value of the company increases and with that turnover should also have a positive trend. Growth can also be measured in the number of products a company offers and if they expand their market reach. Hiring more people and more importantly being able to keep key employees are other ways of showing that the company is scaling and growing. A couple of the entrepreneurs also mentioned that attracting capital is a way of measuring growth since it shows that the company is getting attention from investors and not only customers. Overall, they mentioned a mix of tangible and intangible assets of ways to show and measure that a company is experiencing growth.

"Going from one phase to another, making sure that you don't get stuck in one spot" - Eivor

"The company expands in the number of products they offer and in terms of employees and partnerships" - Elliot

Among the investors, there were attempts to visualize an upwards slope, meaning that that shape can be a definition of growth. Reaching profitability and creating a solid foundation in the organization were other explanations of growth as a concept. When asked how growth can be measured, they all choose to mention financial well-being as the main way of determining how much a company grows. Increased turnover and profit were the two main ways, however attracting and raising external capital was also mentioned. The investors overall talked about tangible assets tied to the financials of the company.

"You have a continuous curve upwards. I think that both turnover and revenue must be considered" - Igor

"Growth is how much a company has in turnover and how much the organization increases. It is also about market reach and revenue streams" - Ines

"Creating a solid foundation in the company and a balance in the finances" - Ida

The interviewees from various innovation support organizations answered in terms of organizational expansion and societal impact when asked to define the concept of growth. Creating value for customers and ensuring a good market fit were mentioned as ways to tell that a company is thriving. Increased turnover, sales and the number of employees were said to be signs of achieved growth for a company. Many of these interviewees chose to go a bit deeper in their explanations without being prompted by the interviewers. They explained that an increased turnover could lead to the company being able to hire more people, which leads to more jobs being offered to the market and more tax revenue being generated. Being sustainable and making sure that the growth goal was within reasonable limits in terms of planetary boundaries was mentioned as important in some of the interviews with actors from the innovation support system.

"Growth is when a company develops strategically, both in turnover and revenue, as well as an organization as a whole" - Signe

"I would explain growth as an increase in revenue and when a company always strives forward and into the future." - Sture

"Hiring more people also creates more jobs in society which in turn leads to more tax revenues for the government. It is also important that the growth is within the boundaries of the planet, that the company aims to be sustainable." - Sigurd

5.2.2 Differences in Short-term and Long-term Growth

The entrepreneurs mention that not getting tied up in too many fixed costs early on is crucial to creating more long-term growth. Timing is also incredibly important and understanding that short-term growth can be due to landing a couple of larger customers and does not necessarily mean that effort was put into creating growth. One entrepreneur also voiced that she thought it is almost too easy to start a company and attract a first round of investments, and it still does not mean that the company will be successful in growing over time. Achieving continuous growth is instead described as putting in the required effort and having an ambition to create something more than the current state. Financial stamina is a key part to allowing oneself to afford to make long-term decisions and not act too radically in the moment. Working past an initial phase of survival to build up strategic roadmap ahead is what puts continuous growth apart from short-term expansion. Growing over time also surrounds creating value for the customer and making sure that the market understands your offer. It is all about being able to get through the noise and create a competitive advantage. Another aspect of long-term growth that was mentioned by this stakeholder group was scalability but also creating lasting internal processes and clear values that everyone in the company works towards. Organizational culture was mentioned by the entrepreneurs as something that should affect everything within the company as well as be known in a positive way to the outside world. To summarize the entrepreneurs' view on long-term growth, perseverance is everything.

"Quick short-term growth can be achieved if one is lucky enough to just land a couple large customers." - Elmer

"Long-term growth is about creating effective internal processes and an organizational culture where everyone wants to be and thrives in." - Elmer

“The most important thing is that you believe in what you do and want to achieve.”
“Perseverance, perseverance, perseverance.” - Elmer

"You must have a clear picture of how you want to be perceived by the outside world, and that should guide the values you create for the organization.” - Elliot

The investors said that short-term growth can be due to some luck and that it often is a result of quick decisions that might not always lay a basis for the company’s continued journey. Growing for a short period of time can have many explanations, some that were mentioned by the investors in the interviewees were aggressive temporary workload and running after money to ensure survival at any cost. To be able to create long-term growth, all aspects of the company have to be considered and optimized. Going from thought to action is a major part of ensuring continuous growth. Creating a positive culture and securing the right partnerships are other aspects to work on. Other things mentioned were penetrating new markets, expanding reach, and ensuring that key employees stay in the organization. Growing over time also requires the ability to connect with the market and pivot when needed.

“Quick growth is easily achieved through working hard for a short period of time, it can also be because of some temporary luck.” […] *“Creating a vision and sharing it with the employees.”* - Igor

“Long-term growth is all about building the foundation of the company and financial perseverance. Growing the team and expanding market reach.” - Ines

The innovation support system describes short-term growth as focusing too much on raising capital and in that process losing direction and momentum. Short-term can also indicate that the company has jumped on trends, without thinking about what might lead to long-term and whether it is right for the company. This stakeholder group also voiced that they feel like companies that grow rapidly focus more on creating value for potential investors instead of making sure they stay relevant for their customers. This must shift to achieve growth over time, in the end, it is the relationship with the customers that creates value. Other aspects of long-term growth are creating resilience and clearly dividing roles and responsibilities. One interview respondent also explained that they had seen the most stable growth in companies run by mixed teams, mixed in the sense of gender, age, previous experience, and knowledge. Having diversity in the company also ensures that they are better at questioning themselves and their decisions in a constructive way. Having the willingness to always improve is crucial to create continuous growth in the company.

“Companies that succeed in growing over time might not have growth as the end goal but instead it becomes a consequence of their work in working towards it.” - Sigge

“We also need companies that grows rapidly they can act as fuel for the companies that achieves long-term growth.” - Signe

“Companies that create continuous growth are good at shifting their focus to where it is the most important at the moment, not falling into trends.” - Selma

5.2.3 Challenges of Growth

One of the biggest challenges to growth mentioned by the entrepreneurs was not securing capital in time or trusting the process of reaching stability. Several people mentioned that another challenge is falling into a trap of adapting too much based on someone else's agenda

or goals and therefore losing track of their own vision. They also voiced that a challenge to grow the company is not treating the employees right. It is important that all people within the organization understand what they are aiming to build together and feel like they have a purpose and role in the process of reaching that goal. It can be challenging to achieve growth if either the internal or external environment takes over the focus. Allowing a dual focus is crucial in growing over time.

"Avoid measuring employees on key performance indicators and focus on making sure that they feel like they have a purpose and give them responsibilities in reaching growth" - Elliot

The main challenge of growth mentioned by multiple investors is getting the organization on board with the change that is happening when the company grows. Resistance to change can be detrimental in trying to develop and achieve something bigger. Another difficulty in the process of growth is not understanding that the same business model might not work long-term. Getting stuck and not seeing potential will hinder growth in a company. Other challenges can include changes in the external environment, such as political shifts and trends in the world economy. This can make it hard to know how to stay relevant and up to date with what the market demands. Recruitment was also mentioned by the respondents as a key part to enable growth and not being able to recruit or retain the right people can instead hinder the growth.

"One big challenge to growth is getting stuck in the hard and uncomfortable decisions and feeling like it is going to be like the current state forever." - Igor

"Getting the organization on board and motivated for the change is crucial and without that support, growth becomes very difficult." - Igor

"Changing and adapting too much based on someone else can really hurt a company's ability to grow. They should want to survive but not to any cost." - Ida

Not understanding your customers can be one of the biggest challenges to growth if you ask a representative from the innovation support system. Other challenges in achieving growth include connecting with the market too late into the development phase and not setting your priorities straight. Being too influenced by what is going on around you might make you lose focus and without a clear agenda, higher levels of growth are difficult to reach. Overconfidence, especially in how long certain things take, was another challenging aspect that was mentioned. Being afraid of someone stealing your idea and therefore not collaborating will hinder growth. Another big challenge is not changing the management of the company as the organization grows. Scaling and growing is all about improving and optimizing, and an area that is often overlooked is the management team and the CEO. If the focus of the organization shifts as the company grows, so should the people that make strategic decisions.

"Making sure to evaluate the management team as the company grows, maybe the CEO that was responsible for starting the company isn't the right person to scale the organization." - Selma

"Unrealistic timelines is one of the biggest challenges to growth." - Signe

5.2.4 Importance of Network and Relations

Networking and building good relationships are explained to be a crucial part of creating growth. The entrepreneurs explained that building lasting relationships with external partners

such as investors and customers is extremely important. Without a relationship with your customers, there is not going to be a business at all. In addition to external relationships, it is also important to create a good network within the internal organization. It was also mentioned that when you network it is beneficial to have an agenda and a goal with why you are approaching new people or trying to build something deeper. Without an agenda it is easy to fall into just mingling for fun which can be seen as a waste of time.

"Everything comes down to the relationships you make with external parties and how good you are at networking." - Eivor

The investors said that networking is crucial for growth. They emphasized that as an entrepreneur you can't do everything yourself and who you have around you is therefore of great importance for how well the company performs. It is also an essential part of supporting innovation since it involves a lot of problem solving and with more people within the network there is the potential for more solutions. Building relationships also means that you build trust, which can enable partnerships.

"Networking allows people to zoom out and get inspired by others, one of the biggest problems we have today is that enough people don't listen and learn from each other. Not enough people ask for help or support since they haven't built those crucial relationships." - Igor

"Through building relationships, you share the risks, the opportunities and you build trust." - Ines

Building a good network requires work and a clear plan on how relationships can benefit the company. Several of the respondents from the innovation support system said that networking is very important for achieving growth in a company. Having a large network and good relationships can ensure that you get answers to questions and challenges you might face. The depth of the relationship is always greater than the number of connections an entrepreneur can make. Networking is all about knowledge exchange and attracting new talent. The support system also believes that it is crucial to be good at networking in the process of raising capital, in the end the investors invest in the people more than the value proposition.

"If you have not built a good network, you will never grow." - Sture

"It is not about how many relationships you are able to make, you have to find the right people and build the right type of relationships that benefits you." - Sture

5.2.5 The Role of the Entrepreneur

The entrepreneurs themselves believe that their role in enabling growth is to bridge the gap between the organization and the board. Their main responsibility is driving the company forward, strategic planning, and overseeing the overall prioritization. Other responsibilities include making sure that the company's products or services stay close to market demand and that changes are made when needed. The entrepreneur should be able to move past mistakes fast to not lose momentum and focus. Additional skills that are beneficial to generating growth are the ability to wear different hats and take on a lot of responsibilities from different areas within the company, attracting investors and knowing when it is time to step back and let someone else run the company. All respondents mentioned that it can be easy to get lost and forget what is best for the company due to pressure from investors or other external parties.

"As the CEO you have great responsibilities and you are also expected to come up with alternatives for the journey ahead." - Eivor

"The most important thing is to develop the product based on the customers feedback and together with the customer." - Elmer

"It is on me that the company survives, however in survival mode the company won't grow." - Elliot

The investors believe that it is important that the entrepreneur understands their limits and what they are capable of. As investors, they want to invest in potential but not if it seems too unrealistic. Some personality traits that investors said are important for entrepreneurs to have to succeed are being goal-oriented, able to handle stress and being willing to adapt and pivot. Being optimistic and not afraid to ask questions or ask for support when needed are other things that were mentioned by the investors. One investor mentioned the concept of acting like a camel, making sure you have reserves and using them wisely. Showing endurance is very important for entrepreneurs if they aim to attract investors. Another aspect that might be contradictory coming from the investors is that several of them wanted more entrepreneurs to think about if risk capital and investors is really the right way to go about growing the company. They said that they believe that many entrepreneurs think about external investors too lightly, they must gain a better understanding of what it actually entails selling shares in the company. While additional capital might boost growth initially, giving up control might not be beneficial in the long run.

"The entrepreneur must be someone who always strives forward if they want their company to grow." […] "They must also dare to make changes in the team and even replace themselves as the CEO if it is the best for the company's development." - Igor

"Show endurance until the timing is right and then the revenue will come once the customers come." […] "More startups should consider acting like camels, having a reserve and spending it wisely." - Ines

Patience, drive, and perseverance are three personality traits that actors from the innovation support system lift as keys to creating growth in a company. They also mention how important it is to have expertise in the area that you operate in. The entrepreneur should also be open to taking risks and expose themselves to new uncertain situations to develop. Another key aspect of enabling growth is for the entrepreneur to be open to receive help and support and really take advantage of their network. This was something that this stakeholder group emphasized as extra important since it is their responsibility in a way. The support system actors also mentioned that they have seen a lot of entrepreneurs having a difficult time delegating, which spreads them thin in terms of time and effort that they are able to show up with. This hinders overall growth since it makes it hard to have the efforts focused if enough time can't be spent on specific tasks. Tied to delegation is the importance of building teams and attracting the right talent for the company. The interviewees also mentioned that the actual work of hiring someone doesn't start until after the person has joined the company. Making them feel valued and building mutual trust is crucial to having any chance of achieving long-term growth. Another area that was mentioned as a potential obstacle to creating growth is spending too much time chasing external capital instead of trying to grow organically or find a way of surviving until the timing is right. From experience, a couple of representatives said that they have seen entrepreneurs that spend too much time explaining their value proposition to the investors that

their product or service becomes irrelevant to the market. What is most important is that the offer must suit the market and if there is a demand, the investors will see the value and the potential. The entrepreneurs must be solution-oriented, curious, and willing to learn.

"An entrepreneur must be humble and understanding that they can't do everything themselves. To allow help and support is crucial in my opinion." - Signe

"The founder of a company is the best marketer for their product, so it is important that they spend time working the market instead of just chasing risk capital." - Selma

"It can be difficult to let go of control if there isn't enough trust." - Sigurd

5.2.6 The Role of the Investor

The entrepreneurs said that they prefer investors to have a long-term approach when investing in a company. To feel like they care about the development and growth of the company if they decide to risk their money. Apart from just investing capital, the entrepreneurs emphasized the importance of what is called "smart money", when the investor opens their network to the startup or shares their knowledge and experience. Included in the long-term approach is also the ability to follow up on their investment in future rounds, going from pre-seed to seed round. Having investors that have enough capital to follow up in a larger capital round in the future to join the company early is important to show credibility. While the entrepreneurs said that they understand that the investors essentially invest in their potential, they wanted to move away from using the "hockey stick" analogy all together since it presents unrealistic expectations. The biggest challenge to onboarding external investors is coming up with mutual expectations and building trust in that process. The entrepreneurs also said that they often feel judged by investors in their initial meetings, and they said that they feel like the investors compares them with unicorn companies which everyone knows is the exception rather than something that everyone can achieve.

"We prefer an investor that can open their network, even attract potential customers. They should want to not just give money, but their time and even some competence or expertise that can boost the growth of the company." - Eivor

"To build a company is generic so having an investor onboard that has gone through that journey themselves is more important that having someone with expertise in the specific industry that we are in. They should feel like they understand what value we produce but apart from that we don't expect them to solve our problems." - Elmer

"I feel like some investors are too short minded in terms of their timeline and when they would like to exit the company. They must be okay with having some disappointment on the way." - Elliot

The investors said when asked about themselves that the most important thing is the team. Essentially you invest in the people behind that idea and their potential. One of the investors even said that if you believe in the person enough, everything else will get figured out. The product or service that they offer must of course have benefits and be relevant for the market, but the most important thing is still how the entrepreneur shows up. There must also be a clear vision and a realistic path ahead. Customer validation and scalability are other key parts that investors look at when deciding if the company has potential to grow long-term.

"Someone with enough drive and courage is going to make a living out of selling ballons." - Igor

"It is all about the people within the organization and their vision, if you want to determine if you think a company has the potential to grow." - Ines

"It is also important to look at what strategic partnerships they have secured early on, it increases their credibility." - Ines

The innovation support system said that the foundation for an investment is capital, but that there is so much more to how investors determine growth potential of a company. It is important for investors that invest in startups to understand that they should want to support the company in any way that they can. If the company does not succeed, the investor will lose their money so that should give them reason to get invested. Sharing knowledge, expertise, and past experiences with the entrepreneur is also why investors chose to invest in a company's potential early instead of putting their money on the stock market. Active involvement is important and so is having the ability to follow up the investment in the future. This allows the investor to secure their shares in the company as it grows and requires additional funding. However, there needs to be better understanding from investors of what it means for the entrepreneur to give up control in exchange for money. As the company needs more funding and the investors buy shares in the company, the entrepreneur gives up control and therefore also the ability to make decisions about the company's vision and direction. The innovation support system also voiced that there is a risk that investors and entrepreneurs clash if they have different ways of measuring growth. Investors often lean towards wanting to see growth in numbers, increased sales, and revenue, while this isn't always the case for an entrepreneur. Depending on what the company does, they might measure growth in societal impact or other measurements of sustainability. Not having the same expectations is the biggest challenge for investors and entrepreneurs to create growth together. It is not so said that companies that think of growth differently cannot find investors, honesty and trust are cornerstones for successful cooperation. Overall, investors play a crucial role as all companies that want to grow need to be financed in one way or another.

"The role of the investor is crucial for creating growth since they take on the largest risk." "If you look at an investor that can open their network and share knowledge, it is important that they find a right match with a company and it can be a great success." - Sigge

"It is important to understand the journey and that it often takes longer than expected and that one might have hoped for to see results." - Sigurd

"The investors have a very important role in enabling growth." - Selma

"Trust is essential and it is important that the entrepreneur and investor talk to each other about all potential scenarios, laying the ground for a relationship where both can be brave." - Signe

5.2.7 The Role of the Innovation Support System

The entrepreneurs explained that the innovation support system plays a crucial role in the initial phases of a company's journey. Going from idea to commercialization is the first step at creating growth. Without the support from the support organizations, many ideas would stay ideas and without a company, there isn't anything that can grow. The entrepreneurs emphasized

how much difference it makes to have external eyes in the shape of a business coach from an incubator in terms of creating change and improvements within the organization. It is easy to become oblivious and not see what might be right in front and achievable. Within this collaboration, it is important to have transparency. The entrepreneur can't get the help and support they want or need if the support actor can't understand the whole situation. The innovation support system is good at creating a community where entrepreneurs can meet each other, sharing knowledge and experiences. Facilitating an arena is beneficial for growth, however, entrepreneurs feel like the support system is not doing enough. Interestingly, they believe that the support actors should implement a stricter screening to be able to join the incubator or accelerator. This would in their opinion make sure that the coaches and the mentors are spending their time coaching the projects that have the highest potential. They all felt like there is too much support and focus on the startup phase and close to no support in the even more crucial phase of scaling and growing the company. Today there are too many actors playing in the same league and the entrepreneurs almost feel bombarded with invitations to events and such, that it becomes difficult to know where they should go and where it makes the most sense for them to get support from. All the entrepreneurs asked for more long-term ambition in the support and help that is offered to them. They said that they would like to see the innovation support system actors finding their focus and offering that specific support over a longer period.

"Too much focus is on the startup phase, it is completely missing from the next phase of the journey, where growth is shaped."[…] "All the actors bombard you with event invitations and activities that they feel like you should participate in, it makes it hard to know what to prioritize."[…] "The more growth you are able to achieve the less support there is within the innovation support system for you to take part in." - Eivor

"It is important to be transparent with your business coach if you want to get the support that you might actually be in need of." - Elliot

"Maybe there is a reason behind there not being that much support further along the journey, at that point, if you have already reached certain level of growth, you should be able to survive and if you don't, it wasn't meant to be." - Elmer

Facilitating matching and providing entrepreneurs with educational programs is part of the main areas that the innovation support system provides the most support if you are asking the investor group. The support system is good at supporting entrepreneurs in understanding the potential of their business ideas. The investors voiced that they feel like many of the support actors provide tools to make the companies grow, however sometime the growth that they support and co create suits the incubator or accelerator more than the company. Incubators, accelerators and other support organizations need to show results to secure their funding, and this is believed to influence what type of support they offer, in hopes that the companies will be successful based on their measurements. In addition to this some investors explained that they feel like the support organizations have built up a reputation of being enablers to the point where entrepreneurs feel like they have achieved something by just getting accepted into one of the standardized programs. This creates false hope that a program that isn't adjusted based on the company's challenges is going to fix all their problems and create growth. Another negative aspect of the innovation support system mentioned by the investors was that they don't have enough visibility. Today it is almost required that you start off at one of the incubators tied to the university as a student to even know about all the other actors that are

offering support. The community of support actors needs to be more open to the public and overall, more inclusive.

"Getting accepted to an incubator or accelerator has become something that entrepreneurs put on their LinkedIn page, however most of the support actors offer a standardized program so getting accepted in the first place does not guarantee that the company gets the right type of support to create growth." - Igor

"The innovation support system needs to become more open and inclusive, there is so much competence to be shared." - Igor

"They are not visible enough. If you don't know that this type of support is offered, they are hard to find in the first place. It is once you are within the ecosystem of actors that you might find more support and help." - Igor

"They care more about creating success in companies that they can later show as alumni, no matter if the growth is very temporary or long-term." - Igor

"They are good at gathering different stakeholder groups around the same agenda, and with that find new forums for creating synergies." - Ines

"They should focus more on questioning entrepreneurs early in the process to not install false hope or risk not prioritizing a case with more potential." - Ida

When asking the innovations support system actors themselves what they do best, they answer that their responsibility is to help the entrepreneur build the foundation in the company. Building a stable company base is achieved by guidance and structure. The organizations work and provide support by facilitating contacts and setting up workshops in areas where many startups often face challenges. They also emphasize that their reputation can give credibility to the companies that are taking part in their program or have been assigned a business coach. These support actors often have existing collaborations that entrepreneurs can benefit from and get a jump start through in building partnerships. They themselves say that one of their main purposes is to have external eyes on the business plan and provide constructive feedback. They also mentioned that they connect entrepreneurs with potential partners and investors. Just as the investors mentioned, they feel like there is a lot of internal competition between the support organizations. This has the potential to have a negative impact on the companies that they aim to help since it might make them greedy and not think of what the best for the startup in terms is of creating long-term growth. Having these many actors, all offer support in the initial phase of startup a business, it can make it difficult for the entrepreneur to navigate the ecosystem. Some of the representatives mentioned that they wished they could support more in finding the right talent and competence to the companies when they are in a phase of growing the organization. They feel like they have the skills to offer this type of support but that it might not fall into the scope of their organization and what their owners or financiers accept them to do.

"With how the system is built up or organized today, it is completely impossible for the entrepreneurs to navigate and find the right support for them." […] "We aim to be someone the entrepreneur can discuss with, and we also want to challenge them and their thinking." - Signe

"Our purpose is to guide the entrepreneur on the whole journey, making them understand what it takes and what is ahead of them. We aim to educate rather than telling them what to do." - Sigurd

"We push the entrepreneurs, we don't believe in serving them too much, instead they must put in the work. That reflects how the market is going to treat them in the future." - Selma

5.2.8 Changes to the Ecosystem to Enable and Support Growth

When asked what to change in the innovation ecosystem to better enable long-term growth, the entrepreneurs said that there should be more pressure on the support organizations to offer support that provides results. The pressure to improve should primarily be on them as they are mostly government funded through tax revenues. It is difficult to put any further pressure on the investors since some of them are investing their own money and it should be up to them where they choose to invest. However, for the risk capitalist and the public venture capital firms there just be more rigid screening of the companies and better attempts at finding common expectations and building trust. The entrepreneurs also feel like there is too much focus and support in finding the right investors, not enough time is spent educating entrepreneurs in alternative ways of running a business. It can be risky to assume that all companies benefit from risk capital. Some of the entrepreneurs wished that they had tried growing organically until it was necessary to bring in external investors that become owners in the business. Their overall view on the ecosystem is that it is currently focused on finding short-term solutions and creating what one entrepreneur called "artificial respiration" through venture capital instead of building prosperous and profitable companies.

"Since many of the support organizations are funded through tax money, there should be more pressure on them delivering support that actually leads to growth in companies."[…] "I don't agree with chasing venture capital, it only becomes a type of artificial respiration that leads to rapid short-term growth, but a company cannot grow like that long-term." - Eivor

"There is too much focus on presenting new startups for investors, and not enough time is spent talking about how to grow organically." - Elmer

"Entrepreneurs should be encouraged to create a company that can afford to make long-term decisions." - Elliot

The investors emphasize that the innovation support organizations must increase their visibility. If more entrepreneurs can see what support is available, then more companies have the chance to get guidance on how to create long-term growth. There needs to be easier ways of being able to offer help without having to be connected to an organization. One of the investors mentioned difficulties in offering advice without having to register it as an income or consultancy. This stakeholder group also said that they believe there are too many policies within the innovation ecosystem. Shifts in politics can completely change the focus of the support organizations which can impact who gets help and support. This can include focusing on female entrepreneurs, diversity in founder teams, certain geographical areas as some examples. This is something that has to change if we want more companies to achieve long-term growth. We can't afford to tell entrepreneurs that they are not prioritized. The investors also ask for more education or support regarding the process that follows investing in a startup or for the startup to get an investment. Having support in finding common expectations and building trust will ensure that the company is able to grow and not get stuck due to disagreements.

"There are too many obstacles and formalities to offer help and support as someone who is not tied to an organization. It should not be required for an investor to invest to offer guidance." - Igor

"Increase visibility, not enough people know that this innovation ecosystem even exists." - Ines

The main point mentioned by the innovation support system was that the competition between them as organizations must be reduced. When asked what could be improved within the ecosystem to better enable long-term growth, most interviewees from this stakeholder criticized themselves and felt like they could achieve more. They all explain that they are financed in the same way and therefore have similar expectations for them. Being measured on the same type of achievement makes it difficult to collaborate and not compete. Since their funding is mainly based on taxes, the political system plays a role in what agenda and focus the public innovation support organizations should follow. When the government changes, the focus of the support actors makes it difficult to keep continuity and support companies over time. There also needs to be a shift in the mindset that one solution fits all. Too many of the support actors have standardized programs that the entrepreneurs are accepted to, like applying for a course at the university. There needs to be more resources allocated to designing guidance and support based on the specific needs of a startup. Other areas of improvement that were mentioned are encouraging more entrepreneurs to share their experience and expertise with other entrepreneurs. Also educate investors in how to approach and interact with entrepreneurs in a more neutral manner to create an equal investment climate. Another way of enabling more long-term growth is to use more people as mentors and coaches that still have one foot in the market, to ensure that the support given to companies is up-to-date and relevant.

"Educate investors of how to view business ideas in a more neutral way to create a more equal investment climate." - Signe

"Everyone would benefit from more collaboration between the support actors, something that is challenging today since we are financed and measured based on the same metrics, setting us up to cannibalize on each other instead of working together for what is best for the startup or entrepreneur."[...] "Create a more open network and ecosystem where entrepreneurs feel like they want to help each other, there is so much knowledge and experience to be shared." - Selma

"Be okay with sharing a startup between the support organizations, if it is best for the entrepreneur and the company. Making sure that they get what they need to grow." - Sture

5.3 Regional Differences

The following sections detail the empirical findings across the three primary Swedish regions identified in the study. The data is categorized by stakeholder groups such as entrepreneurs, investors, and innovation support actors, to allow for a triangulated comparison of how growth is perceived and facilitated geographically.

5.3.1 East

The East region exhibits structural characteristics where growth is framed as a series of considering, value-adding transitions rather than a singular event (Appendix 2). Entrepreneurs in this region conceptualize growth as *"taking steps in the value increase of the company",*

emphasizing that a firm must avoid *"standing and stomping"* at a particular phase (Appendix 2). This reasoning suggests a high level of process awareness, yet it is accompanied by a cautionary observation that the initial capital market in the East is perceived as being *"sometimes a little too easy"* to enter (Appendix 2). This accessibility creates a unique regional tension where firms may focus primely on investor-driven milestones at the expense of organic market validation (Appendix 2; Appendix 4).

Investor logic in the East complements this by prioritizing *"smart money",* where the contribution of expertise and networks is valued as highly as the financial capital itself (Appendix 3). For these investors, long-term success is rooted in the ability to move *"from thought to action"* and continuously optimize the business model (Appendix 3). Support actors in the East motivate their role through a societal lens, viewing growth as the ability to *"contribute to a value for the customer or for society"* (Appendix 4). They argue for a transformation of the ecosystem that shifts the focus away from *"artificial respiration"* through venture capital and toward the construction of *"healthy",* prosperous companies that can sustain growth over time (Appendix 4).

5.3.2 South/West

In the South/West regions, the reasoning behind growth is heavily anchored in product-market fit and the aggressive pursuit of scalability (Appendix 2). Entrepreneurs in these industrial and tech centers define the onset of growth as the moment a *"product or service is validated by the market"*, allowing the value proposition to reach larger volumes (Appendix 2). The motivation here is often external, entrepreneurs feel pressure to *"get through the noise"* and create an attraction that forces the outside world to recognize the firm's value (Appendix 2). The data specifically highlights the organizational challenge of growth in this region, noting that as a company scales, leadership must *"dare to replace management and CEO"* to ensure the leadership matches the firm's current stage of development (Appendix 2). Investors in the South/West demonstrate a more *"aggressive"* development logic where company valuation and market share are the primary drivers (Appendix 3). They advocate for a *"persevering"* management style that allocates resources strategically and maintains an *"ear to the market"* to anticipate customer needs (Appendix 3). Innovation support actors in this region align with this by defining growth as a *"constant striving for progress"* and a means to generate tax revenue for reinvestment into the support system (Appendix 4). They motivate their intervention by focusing on *"proven scalability"* and suggest that the support organization's task is to bring disparate groups together to ensure common goals and expectations are met (Appendix 4).

5.3.3 North

The North region is characterized by a *"perseverance-based"* growth logic where *"financial stamina"* and organizational culture are seen as the primary drivers of long-term success (Appendix 2). Entrepreneurs in the North define growth through the tangible expansion of turnover, employees, and partnerships (Appendix 2). There is a strong reasoning that a *"strong foundation"* is required to handle growth over time, which includes establishing clear internal processes to ensure that *"resources per deal decrease as volumes increase"* (Appendix 2). The motivation for growth in the North is often rooted in the concept of *"financial stamina",* allowing the firm to afford the *"right decisions"* rather than making hasty ones under pressure (Appendix 2).

Investors in the North reflect this cautious yet stable approach, viewing growth as a *"solid foundation and revenue"* with a continuous upward slope (Appendix 3). They place a high value on *"corporate culture that lasts over time"* and the ability to grow as much as possible with their own funds (Appendix 3). This is supported by the innovation support actors in the North who view growth as *"strategically growing both in terms of result and organizationally at the same time"* (Appendix 4). A recurring regional motivation is the need to overcome geographical imbalances in capital distribution (Appendix 4). Actors in the North argue for an ecosystem that *"de-dramatizes"* the investment process and focuses on *"resilience",* ensuring that the support provided is as sharp for mature companies as it is for nascent ones (Appendix 4).

6. DISCUSSION

Building on the theoretical framework outlined in chapter 2, the following discussion aims to interpret the empirical findings and connect them to key concepts within growth theory, Entrepreneurial Ecosystems and the Triple Helix model. The discussion focuses on explaining the underlying drivers, enablers, and restrictions on continuous growth. The findings from the data collection have been turned into a conceptual framework to create a visual representation of the interplay between the three stakeholder groups included in this study.

6.1 Thematic Interpretation of Growth Dynamics

This section of the discussion explores the patterns identified in the study's empirical findings by relating them to the established theoretical framework. The discussion is structured around five central themes that collectively illustrate how continuous growth is shaped, enabled, and constrained within the Swedish innovation ecosystem. The discussion explores how the concept of growth has evolved from a linear model into a more context-dependent process. This is followed by an analysis of the importance of relational mechanisms and networks as foundational structures for resource mobilization. The inherent tensions and restrictions that arise when the logics of different actors collide are highlighted, alongside the capabilities and systemic conditions required to navigate these challenges. The section concludes with a discussion regarding the ecosystem's potential for improvement to better support companies in later of growth.

6.1.1 Evolution of Conceptualization of Continuous Growth

The empirical findings reveal that the concept of continuous growth can be described in multiple ways across different actors within the Swedish innovation ecosystem. Traditional explanations have emphasized financial performance (Achtenhagen et al,. 2010) and the ability to scale the company's value proposition. The findings from this study indicated that there is a broader understanding of how growth can be measured and achieved by the people playing a part in the process. Their understanding of growth includes sustainability, long-term development, and societal impact. This evolution suggests that long-term growth is not a fixed or universally defined concept, but rather more context-dependent and evolving than emphasized previously.

From an entrepreneurial perspective, growth is often linked to building a sustainable organization that can adapt to uncertainties in the external environment. Investors instead focus more on scalability and return on investment. The last group included in this study, the actors from the innovation support system, tend to have a more holistic approach to what growth is. They emphasize long-term viability, available resources, and support from within the ecosystem. These different conceptualizations of growth further highlight that growth is not just an outcome, but a process (Larry. E Greiner, 1998; Churchill & Lewis (1978) shaped by all actors in the ecosystem.

These findings both align with and extend the theoretical perspectives presented in the literature on the concept of growth, which often emphasize measurable indicators like company size, valuation, and revenue. Growth models like the five-phase model by Larry. E Greiner (1979) and the five growth stages by Churchill & Lewis (1978) both describe a relatively linear process. The findings from this study suggest a more dynamic and multidimensional process to achieve continuous growth over time.

6.1.2 Relationships and Networks for Enabling Growth

The findings further demonstrate how continuous growth is achieved through multiple relational mechanisms based on the interactions between entrepreneurs, investors, and actors within the innovation support system. Creating networks, sharing knowledge, and accessing resources emerge as key elements in achieving growth, suggesting that process is not only driven by internal capabilities, but also through relationships within the ecosystem.

These networks and relationships between actors act as channels where critical resources, such as venture capital, expertise, and market access are shared and mobilized. Entrepreneurs rely on network access to investors and support through coaches or mentors. Investors instead contribute to the networks through offering strategic guidance and connections, in addition to financial capital. Similarly, support actors facilitate connections between all groups by providing platforms and institutional backing. The importance of networks in achieving long-term growth reinforces the idea that growth is a part of a broader system of interdependencies rather than isolated to a single firm's process.

The findings from this study align with existing research on entrepreneurial ecosystems and networks. Stam & van de Ven (2021) describes the environment within the entrepreneurial ecosystem as an interconnected web of all actors coming together to create growth and venture development. The findings from this study specifically extend this perspective by illustrating how different types of relationships overlap within the ecosystem, between multiple actors at once. Understanding that these relationships happen simultaneously is important when viewing growth as a concept continuously shaped by interactions, including trust building, finding common expectations, and mutual exchange between actors.

6.1.3 Constraints and Tensions to Shaping Continuous Growth

Despite multiple factors enabling growth being present within the ecosystem and in the relationships between the actors, the findings also present structural and operational challenges to achieving continuous growth. Resource limitations and organizational complexity when scaling are two of the main difficulties mentioned by the respondents.

Scaling and growing the business is a complex process, not only requiring increased resources but also having and maintaining the ability to adapt the internal processes, the capabilities, and overall organizational structure. When a company grows, there is a need to transition from an informal startup team structure to something more structured. This often has the potential to fail if not handled the right way. Being aware of how coordination, collaboration, and decision-making are reflected in the organization is crucial for success in growing the company. Other areas that can constrain the growth are resource allocation and establishing a clear roadmap ahead. These findings are in line with the five phases of growth by Larry. E Greiner (1998) and the "revolutions" that companies experience in the process of growth.

Other constraints include attracting capital, talent, or other types of expertise. Not finding or securing these resources in time can be what stops the organization from achieving growth. One respondent from the investor group mentioned "having a camel's mentality", referring to being aware of what resources are at hand and being in tune with how to allocate them properly and making sure that they last until more can be acquired. Accepting that the intensity of the growth might be lower for a temporary period, rather than aiming to keep up the pace of the growth and failing is what sets companies apart that are able to create continuous growth. While external actors often provide access to resources, these often come with new conditions and

dependencies. This emphasizes that growth is not only enabled by access to resources but also shaped by how these resources are managed and integrated within the organization.

Another part restricting growth is tensions between actors, especially when it comes to finding common expectations and priorities. Finding a balance between short-term and long-term sustainability influences strategic decision making in the company and in what way the company can achieve continuous growth.

A major tension exists between entrepreneurs and investors, different time horizons and visions often lead to conflicting approaches to growth. The finding reveal that investors favor rapid growth, leading to financial returns, while entrepreneurs instead focus on stability, control and long-term value creation. These differences create a need for structured negotiation and clearer communication early in the investment process. In addition to initial or temporary tensions, the findings highlight tensions related to control and delegation as the organization expands. All stakeholder groups emphasized the importance of evolving the leadership of the company as it grows. Shifting from a hands-on, operational leadership to more strategic and planning focus management is required for the organization to keep its momentum. However, this transition can be challenging, as it may involve inviting external parties or acquiring a new CEO. Failure to navigate these changes and tensions risks limiting the organization's ability to achieve growth effectively.

Rather than viewing these constraints and tensions as purely negative, the empirical findings suggest that they are a necessary part of the process, forcing the management of the company to reflect on the path forward. Constraints push the organizations in specific directions, further emphasizing that growth is not a linear process. Tensions instead create pressure for adaptation and the need to make strategic decisions customized to the needs of the organization. Continuous growth is not achieved by eliminating tensions, but by managing and navigating them over time.

6.1.4 Capabilities and System Conditions for Growth

The findings indicate that continuous growth depends on interactions between actors, as well as on the capabilities of individual actors within the ecosystem. Entrepreneurs' ability to adapt and investor's willingness to make long-term strategic investment decisions, in addition to the institutional structures, collectively create and shape the opportunities and limitations for long-term growth.

All stakeholder groups expressed that entrepreneurs are believed to drive growth through their ability to learn, adapt, and make strategic decisions, especially in times of uncertainty. These capabilities are described by Schumpeter (1934) and his definition of entrepreneurs. Investors influence the changes of growth through their evaluation and involvement, leading to both strategic direction and the pace of development. The actors within the innovation support system provide the institutional context in which the interactions between all groups take place. In the Swedish environment, there is a strong emphasis on collaboration between public support actors, the universities and the industry, which is reflected in the principles of the Triple Helix model by Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff (1995).

While the findings of this study are aligned with the theoretical perspectives of the Triple Helix and the entrepreneurial ecosystem Stam (2015), they also highlight that the effectiveness of these systems depends on the alignment between the different actors and their capabilities.

6.1.5 Ecosystem Improvements

The findings call for improved alignment between all actors within the ecosystem. Differences in what growth is understood to be driven by or how it achieved create tensions that can lead to hindering or constraining organizational development. The ecosystem would benefit from clearer communication regarding expectations, vision development, and how to effectively collaborate.

The ecosystem is crucial for facilitating access to networks and support structures. The findings however indicate that this is not equally accessible across actors. Several respondents expressed that once you are an active part of the ecosystem, it is when you can benefit from what it has to offer. Most of the support actors are lacking visibility to the outside environment, and this can create a situation where unnecessary competition becomes present between actors, since they are not able to attract new entrepreneurs or investors into the ecosystem. Deepening the collaboration and strengthening the relational infrastructure would enable better knowledge exchange and partnerships. This type of improvement within the ecosystem would enhance the effectiveness and create more opportunities for resource sharing, leading to increased growth in companies.

The findings also highlight a need for support beyond the startup phase. The current support is focused on the very beginning of the business journey, from turning an idea into commercialization and the initial phase of scaling the business. The respondents express that there is a lot of support for companies that are in the first two phases/stages in corresponding to five phases of growth by Larry. E Greiner (1998) and the five growth stages by Churchill & Lewis (1978). These phases/stages are called *creativity* and *direction*, *existence* and *survival*, which describes the current state that the companies that are receiving help are in. The next two phases/stages in each model are referred to *delegation* and *coordination*, *success* and *take-off* respectively. It is in the later stages that most companies face challenges like organizational development, resource scaling, and strategic alignment. However, the support actors are not present with their support in this next step of the journey. Both the investors and support actors felt strongly about expanding their support to later stages of the growth journey. Expanding the scope of support to address these phases could improve the achievement of long-term growth.

However, the entrepreneurs wanted more in-depth screening of business ideas at the very beginning, leading to the support reaching companies that have confirmed potential. If the support from investors and the innovation system was to be prolonged, they emphasized that the support needed to be specific and relevant to the case. Matching mentors that are still connected to the market could be beneficial, however the entrepreneurs also voiced that they believe that if you need support past the survival stage, then maybe the case isn't strong enough.

Another potential improvement that can be extracted from findings is the structural and institutional constraints within the ecosystem that limits the effectiveness of the support. These constraints include funding structures and misalignments between support actor goals and company needs. Addressing these challenges would require increased coordination between public, private, and academic actors. Leaning into the Triple Helix could create a more cohesive and adaptive support environment.

Together, these findings suggest that improving the ecosystem is not about adding new actors or resources but instead about enhancing coordination, collaboration, and alignment between the actors. Enabling better adaptability from all perspectives could lead to benefits for all

stakeholder groups. Achieving continuous growth depends on how effectively actors interact with each other and how well they can align their expectations. It involves how flexible the system is in responding to the evolving needs of companies aiming to achieve long-term growth.

6.2 Regional Differences and Similarities

The empirical investigation into Swedish innovation ecosystem reveals that while a national consensus exists regarding the fundamental nature of growth, the strategic logic used to pursue it is deeply influenced by regional characteristics. When synthesizing these findings with the theoretical framework, it becomes evident that growth is indeed a *"complex phenomenon"* and *"not uni-dimensional",* as argued by Achtenhagen et al. (2010). Across all three regions, North, East, and South/West, there is a shared understanding that growth is a processual shift of *"going from one phase to another, making sure that you don't get stuck in one spot"*. This aligns with the "verb" based definition of growth established in the theory, suggesting that stakeholders view scaling not as a static destination but as an ongoing evolution of organizational maturity.

An outstanding similarity across the regions is the emphasis on the "Resource-based view" (Shah et al., 2013). Whether in Umeå or Malmö, entrepreneurs and support actors identify that growth is predicated on the ability to mobilize both tangible capital and intangible intellectual resources. This is particularly visible in the shared valuation of networks; investors and support actors in all regions describe networking as *"absolutely crucial"* because *"who you have around you is of great importance for how well the company performs"*. This reinforces the "web" metaphor of entrepreneurial ecosystems (Stam & van de Ven, 2021), where independent actors are trilateral partners rather than isolated entities. Despite these similarities, the "roadmap" to achieving this growth diverges significantly based on regional industrial cultures and capital availability.

In the East region, specifically around the Uppsala hub, the findings suggest a high degree of process awareness that mirrors Greiner's (1998) early phases of creativity and direction. The regional logic here frames growth as a series of *"considering, value-adding transitions"* where the primary goal is to avoid *"standing and stomping"* at any single evolutionary stage. However, the East region faces a unique challenge in its relationship with the external environment, the capital market is perceived as being *"sometimes a little too easy"* to enter. This accessibility creates a strategic tension where the "growth mandate" provided by investors might push a company into a "revolutionary" phase (Greiner, 1998) before the internal structure is ready and leading to a focus on investor metrics over actual market validation.

Conversely, the South/West regions exhibit a logic centered on "market exploitation" as defined by Audretsch et al. (2023). In these hubs, growth is defined by the moment a *"product or service is validated by the market"*, allowing for an aggressive pursuit of scalability. There is a distinct regional motivation to *"get through the noise"* and create an attraction that signals quality to the outside world. This aligns with pursuit of "organizational legitimacy" (Suchman, 1995), where growth is used as a communicative tool to establish a "voice" in a competitive international arena. A notable difference in the South/West is the pragmatic view on leadership. Here stakeholders argue that to enable growth, one must *"dare to replace management and CEO"* if the founder is no longer the right person to scale the organization. This reflects Greiner's (1998) "crisis of leadership", where the skills required to start a firm are recognized as being distinct from those required to manage a maturing organization.

The North region, centered in Umeå, presents a "perseverance-based growth logic that contrasts with the more aggressive scaling mandates of the South. Here, the focus is on building a *"solid foundation"* and achieving *"financial stamina"*. Growth in the North is reasoned because of internal stability and organizational culture, where the goal is to make the *"right decisions"* rather than hasty one under external pressure. This region emphasizes Penrose's (1959) theory that growth is limited by internal managerial resources; northern entrepreneurs prioritize creating internal processes where *"resources per deal become smaller with larger volumes"*. There is also a strong regional consensus on the need to overcome geographical capital imbalances, leading to focus on growing *"as much as possible with own funds"* to maintain resilience.

Regional similarities are also apparent in the challenges identified. All regions point to the "scaling threshold" (Tillväxtverket, 2024), noting that moving from "survival" to "take-off" (Churchill & Lewis, 1987) is the most critical part of the journey. Investors across the board warn against *"unrealistic timelines"* and a *"too steep curve",* while entrepreneurs express fear of the *"investment trap"*, adapting too much to an investor's agenda and losing their own vision. The innovation support actors across Sweden echo this by criticizing the *"standardized programs"* that may fail to address specific regional or company-level needs. Instead of acting as the "facilitating infrastructure" required by the Triple Helix model.

The discussion shows that while the East focuses on phased transitions, the South/West on market validation, and the North on structural perseverance, they are all navigating the same fundamental tensions between "evolution and revolution". The regional differences are not in the desire for growth, but in the "strategic ambition" (Penrose, 1959) and the specific "cultural support" (World Economic Forum, 2013) that shapes how that ambition is realized. The Swedish ecosystem is thus a fragmented yet collaborative "web" where long-term and continuous growth is achieved when the entrepreneur's internal vision is in harmony with the regional ecosystem's specific drivers and constraints.

6.3 Conceptual Framework of Continuous Growth

Building on the theoretical framework and empirical data, a conceptual framework was developed to explain continuous growth as an outcome of dynamic interactions between key actors within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. Whereas previous literature has generally examined growth through individual actors actions in isolation, the findings of this research project strongly suggest that growth is shaped through the interplay between the three stakeholder groups: entrepreneurs, investor and actors from the innovation support system.

At the center of the model, visualized in the Figure 8, is the interaction between the three groups. The overlapping nature of the circles indicated that there is an ongoing relation between all three groups. The empirical findings analyzed through the concepts, themes, and aggregated dimensions of the Gioia method reveal that the interactions are not neutral but instead a base for mechanisms that both enable and restrict growth.

Networks and relationships emerge as a central mechanism to facilitate access to potential partnerships and opportunities. Relational ties between actors enable knowledge exchange and experience sharing, which influences strategic decision making and the ability to navigate through phases of uncertainty. Access to resources, specifically venture capital and other financial capabilities, stands out to be crucial in shaping growth. These resources are mainly created in the interaction between entrepreneurs and investors, however, the support system

often connects these two groups together, acting as a match maker. Having access to the resources alone is not sufficient, instead a lot depends on how the resources are utilized, and the alignment between stakeholder groups plays a huge part in finding mutual expectations.

Another key finding of the research is the presence of tensions that are present in and are related to growth expectations. Investors may emphasize rapid scaling and return on their investment, while entrepreneurs and support actors prioritize sustainable, controlled growth. Differences have the potential to create friction between the stakeholder groups and must be managed for growth to be continuous and not just lasting a short period of time. The findings also highlight that growth is associated with challenges, including organizational complexity, financial constraints, and strategic uncertainty. These challenges are like the other findings not isolated but emerge as a part of the interaction between the actors. Unlike short-term rapid scaling, continuous growth requires managing tensions, aligning expectations, and adapting to changing conditions.

The framework acknowledges that the processes are a part of a broader ecosystem. The findings indicate that the entrepreneurial ecosystem is not static but evolves in response to all interactions within the ecosystem. The actors actively shape and develop the system through their behavior and where their own feedback guides the improvement of the system itself.

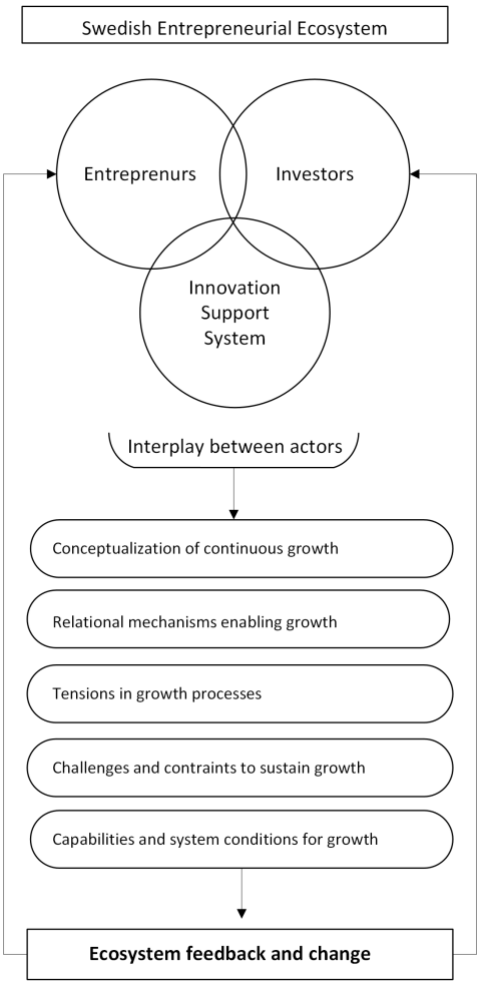


Figure 8. Conceptual Framework of growth in the Swedish Entrepreneurial Ecosystem

7. CONCLUSION

The conclusion chapter aims to answer the research question by revisiting the purpose of the study and concluding what the discussion accomplished to present. The chapter also presents the limitations of the study and suggestions for further research on the subject.

7.1 Revisit Research Question and Purpose, and Key Findings

This thesis explores how the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors, and actors within the innovation support system enables and shapes continuous growth in new ventures. The findings indicate that growth is a concept that cannot be understood as the outcome of isolated actions by separate actors. Instead, patterns emerge that are in line with the Triple Helix model and emphasize that ongoing interactions between the stakeholder groups lead to resource sharing and evolving relationships, all shown to be essential in the process of achieving growth.

The research question guiding this study is "*How does the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and actors from the innovation support system enable continuous growth in new ventures, in a Swedish context?".* With the use of triangulation, through a qualitative study, based on the theories of the Triple Helix model, growth models and entrepreneurial processes, the interactions of the three stakeholder groups were studied to answer the research question.

7.1.1 Summary of Key Findings

A central takeaway of this study is that continuous growth should be understood as a relational process rather than an outcome of the actions undertaken by an individual actor. Previous literature often emphasize strategy, resources, and the leadership of the firm to be the bases for enabling growth. This study demonstrates that growth emerges though the interactions between multiple stakeholders.

In line with the Triple Helix model, the entrepreneurs, investors and innovation support system actors are interdependent, and their relationships create the foundation for achieving long-term growth. Access to capital, networks, and knowledge are key parts that are embedded into these relationships. This emphasizes the importance of viewing growth through an interconnected lens.

The findings also indicate that alignment between stakeholders is a key mechanism to enabling continuous growth. Misalignment presents constraints and tensions, effecting growth potential negatively. Alignment can be achieved through finding common expectations regarding growth pace, strategic direction and vision.

Another aspect of the findings is that continuous growth is often restricted by tensions between actors and their prioritizations. Examples of these tensions mentioned by the respondents include short term, rapid scaling versus maintaining control long-term. The ambition to create social impact is often conflicted with the expectation of high return on investment. The findings suggest that achieving growth is not done by eliminating these tensions, instead knowing how to manage them effectively.

The Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem offers a strong foundation for starting and developing a company. Access to funding, supportive infrastructure and a collaborative culture are all enabler of creating growth. However, the findings of this study reveal that the ecosystem is not without challenges. Large number of support actors creates a complex environment that can be

difficult for entrepreneurs and investors to navigate efficiently. Overlaps in the support have the potential to lead to inefficiencies or misaligned support.

Integrating the perspectives of entrepreneurs, investors and innovation support actors, the findings of this study shows that growth is a complex and dynamic process. It is shaped not only by what resources are available, but how they are interpreted, connected and utilized within the ecosystem as a whole.

7.1.2 Answering the Research Question

Achieving continuous growth in new ventures is enabled through coordinated interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and innovation support actors. Financial and social resources, as well as knowledge sharing, are allocated and mobilized through strong relationships. The empirical findings indicate that growth depends not on the presence of these different actors alone, but in their alignment in expectations, roles and time horizons. Effective collaboration is a big part of reinforcing dynamics that support long-term growth, however, misalignment between the same actors leads to tensions and constraints. Continuous growth should therefore be seen as a relational, non-linear process, shaped by how these different actors interact, share resources, and manage competing demands within the entrepreneurial ecosystem.

7.2 Contributions to Theory

This study contributes to the literature on entrepreneurial growth and ecosystems by moving beyond the traditional, linear models of firm development. While foundational models such as Greiner's Five Phases of Growth (1998) and Churchill & Lewis's (1987) Stages of Growth focus primarily on internal organizational changes, this research extends these perspectives by illustrating that continuous growth is a relational outcome of the interplay between multiple actors.

The findings challenge the notion that growth is a purely internal, consequential process. By integrating the Triple Helix model (Etzkowitz & Leydesdorff, 1995), this study demonstrates that growth is enabled or constrained by the alignment of external expectations. The conceptual framework (Figure 8 on page 59) contributes to the theory by identifying the "relation tensions", as structural components of the growth journey, rather than just external variables.

A significant theoretical contribution is the identification of regional strategic variety. Most current research (e.g., Shah et al., 2013) treats growth drivers as generic. This study provides a nuanced layer by showing that geographical and industrial cultures (North, East, South/West) dictate different "logics of scaling" ranging from structural perseverance to aggressive market validation. Aligning with Achtenhagen et al. (2010), this study reinforces that growth must be understood as a multidimensional process. This study further contributes to this theoretical branch by empirically showing that continuous growth is increasingly defined through legitimacy and societal impact rather than just static numerical increases in turnover or business valuation.

7.3 Contributions to Practice

The practical implications of this study are directed toward the three key stakeholder groups to better enable a long-term and high-performing Swedish innovation ecosystem. Directed to entrepreneurs and managers, the study suggests that entrepreneurs must prioritize "financial stamina" and internal organizational health over the pursuit of "artificial respiration" through rapid venture capital. This means focusing in building a complementary team and a strong

foundation early on. Furthermore, founders must be aware of the "crisis of leadership" and be prepared to evolve their role or introduce professional management as the firm moves from the existence phase to the take-off stage.

Investors are encouraged to shift from a "hockey stick" measurement logic toward a "smart money" approach. This involves not only providing capital but acting as a strategic sounding board that provides "market ears" and network access. The findings suggest that investors who understand and align with the entrepreneur's long-term vision are more likely to foster companies that achieve continuous growth rather than short-lived expansion.

For innovation support actors and policymakers, a critical recommendation is to reduce the "cannibalization" between support organizations. Actors should move toward a more collaborative resource-sharing model that prioritizes the entrepreneur's specific needs over the organization's own metrics. There is a clear need for support services that extend beyond the startup phase. Expanding programs in between to address the "delegation" and "coordination" crises of more mature firms is essential to bridge the national "scaling gap".

To bridge the current "scaling gap", this study proposes the establishment of a centralized intermediary system, a "boundary-spanning" organization, that operates at the interface of University, Industry, and Government. Drawing on the Triple Helix model, such a system would facilitate the "role substitution" necessary for continuous growth, acting as a strategic coordinator to ensure that support flows seamlessly across institutional silos as a venture moves through its lifecycle. These structural improvements carry significant weight on a broader level. By ensuring that public and private resources are utilized at the precise moments they can best foster growth, the ecosystem maximizes its contribution to job creation and tax revenue which are the pillars of the Swedish welfare state.

In addition, a coordinated intermediary system allows for a unified focus on "planetary boundaries" and societal impact. By moving away from "artificial respiration" through short-term venture capital and toward a model of coordinated, continuous growth, the ecosystem ensures that economic renewals are synonymous with social and environmental perseverance. Ultimately, the transitions to a collaborative infrastructure does not only benefit the individual firm. It secures the competitive edge of the national innovation economy while ensuring that continuous growth is achieved with long-term societal values.

7.4 Societal and Ethical Implications

Several ethical and societal implications can be related to this study and how it relates to how growth is enabled within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. Since this study suggests that growth is shaped in the interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and innovation support actors, the decisions made by these stakeholders influence not only business development, but wider societal outcomes.

The study highlights the societal importance of accessible and inclusive innovation support systems. The Swedish innovation ecosystem provides strong structural support for entrepreneurs, however the findings also reveal that with many actors and a complex ecosystem structure, it can be difficult to navigate. This has the potential to lead to unequal access to resources, networks and other opportunities, which can affect growth potential negatively. From a societal perspective, this emphasizes on creating a coordinated and accessible support

ecosystem that enable more entrepreneurs and startups to participate in entrepreneurial activities.

Another important implication concerns the tension between financial growth objectives and long-term value creation. The findings indicate that entrepreneurs often face pressure to prioritize rapid growth and financial performance, sometimes at the expense of social impact, organizational development, or strategic stability. This raises an ethical concern regarding how growth is defined and evaluated, and if support structures encourage continuous development or short-term economic outcomes.

The findings also suggest that investors and support actors greatly influence which ventures receive resources and opportunities that could be crucial for achieving growth. This creates ethical responsibilities related to fairness and inclusion. Decisions regarding funding and supporting a specific entrepreneur or startup will lead to effects in the industry, as well as in society, if growth is achieved.

Finally, this study contributes to societal discussions regarding entrepreneurship as a driver of innovation, employment and economic development. By demonstrating that continuous growth depends on collaboration, knowledge sharing and stakeholder alignment within the ecosystem, the findings emphasize the societal value of creating strong relationships. Additionally, coordinated support structures between public, private and entrepreneurial actors is crucial in creating and shaping growth.

7.5 Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research

This study adopts a cross-sectional approach involving three different stakeholder groups and how they perceive growth at as single point in time. However, as the findings of this study has indicated, growth is a dynamic process that evolves over time and through different stages of a company's life cycle. Future research could apply a longitudinal design to examine how this interplay between entrepreneurs, investors and support actors change and develop over time. An increased time perspective to the study would enable deeper insights into how relationships, alignment, and tensions shift throughout various growth phases. It would also allow for a better understanding of how companies transition from early-stage development to achieving continuous growth.

Since the study adopts a qualitative and interpretivist, the findings are based on subjective interpretations from both respondents and researchers. The perception of continuous growth and ecosystem interactions are therefore context-dependent and shaped by the experiences and backgrounds of the participants. The qualitative approach enables a deeper understanding of relational dynamics, however the findings should not be interpreted as generalizable to all entrepreneurial ecosystems.

A second recommendation for future research is to expand the stakeholder groups and therefore increase the number of different perspectives. It has become inherent from the findings of this study that more stakeholders than the three groups included in this research has an impact on the growth of a company. All respondents mentioned the importance of staying close to the market and the customers and it is therefore imaginable that they would influence to what degree a business can grow. Other stakeholder groups that influence the growth rate and success of a company includes employees, as well as external partners. Majority of the respondents of this study mentioned organizational structure and corporate culture as key

elements to achieving growth. External partners can like investors contribute to various areas of the company, through financial agreements and market expertise.

Another recommendation is to conduct a comparative study across other countries and regions. This study is limited to a Swedish context, mainly due to time constraints. The Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystem is characterized by strong institutional support and a highly developed innovation system. Comparing the findings from this study with other countries that might have a different level of ecosystem maturity or structure would determine if the findings of this study are context specific or what mechanisms of growth that are more general. A comparative study would contribute to a deeper understanding of how institutional support systems shape continuous growth.

Although respondents from multiple regions in Sweden were included in the study, the purpose was not to conduct a fully comparative analysis. The identified regional differences should therefore be interpreted as contextual insights rather than representing all Swedish entrepreneurial ecosystems. Regional environments can differ depending on demographic conditions, access to capital, networks and support infrastructure.

Since this study has covered different regions in Sweden, a potential extension of this would be to either narrow the scope of entrepreneurs to a specific industry across the same regions included in this study or researching what each region is specialized in and include companies from those industries in each region respectively. Researching companies within the same industry would enable understanding of if there are industry specific tensions and constraints to growth. That type of findings would be beneficial for support system actors like incubators that are tied to work towards industry specific startups. The other approach of researching what each region is specialized in comes from media and investors talking about how different regions have become hubs for specific industries since expertise might be geographically located there. An example of this is Uppsala being a strong hub for life science since large international companies in that industry has located factories and offices there. Another aspect is Läkemedelsverket, the Swedish medical products agency is in the city (Läkemedelsverket, 2026).

A key contribution of this study is identifying the alignments and misalignments between actors and how it influences the ability to achieve continuous growth. However, since they are dynamic concepts, they remain complex and unexplored to an extent. Future research could focus on how alignment is created and maintained over time, since it has become evident that it is a key part of creating growth. Another research focus could be on how different actors negotiate conflicting expectations and other areas of misalignment, tied to the understanding that growth is achieved when collaborating actors are in alignment. Tensions have been shown to be another area of interest in terms of understanding growth. Managing tensions between speed and sustainability is one of many examples that was mentioned by the respondents of this study. Researching how these tensions are managed and overcome in practice could be another recommendation for future research. Studying misalignments and tensions would build on the previous research by Larry. E Greiner (1998) and the five phases of growth, and the revolutions and evolutions of the growth process.

References:

Achtenhagen, L., Naldi, L., & Melin, L. (2010). Business Growth - Do Practitioners and Scholars Really Talk about the Same Thing? *Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice*, *34*(2), 289-316.

Almi. (2026). *This is how venture capital works with Almi Invest*. https://www.almi.se/en/venture-capital/this-is-how-venture-capital-works-with-almi-invest/

Audretsch, D.B., Belitski, M., Caiazza, R., Chowdhury, F. & Menter, M. (2023). Entrepreneurial growth, value creation and new technologies. *Journal of Technology Transfer, 48*(5), 1535-1551 https://doi.org/10.1007/s10961-023-10034-w

Audretsch, D.B., Belitski, M., Fiedler & Meurer, M. M. (2025). Values and entrepreneurship in the sustainable society: toward a multilevel understanding of entrepreneurial value practices. *Small Business Economics, 65(4)*, 1701-1725. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11187-025-01069-4

Azeem, M., Khanna, A. (2024). A systematic literature review of startup survival and future research agenda. *Journal of Research in Marketing and Entrepreneurship*, 26 (1), 111-139. https://doi.org/10.1108/JRME-03-2022-0040

Backteman, E., & Åberg, U. (2026). *Regionalt utvecklingsarbete 2025* (Rapport 0573). Tillväxtverket. https://tillvaxtverket.se/download/18.6bbf6ffa19d9a616af961e56/1776771822813/Regionalt%20utvecklingsarbete%202025.pdf

Bager-Sjögren, L., & Rosenberg, M. (2004). *Kartläggning av aktörer i det svenska innovationssystemet.* Institutet för tillväxtpolitiska studier. https://www.tillvaxtanalys.se/download/18.62dd45451715a00666f1bc5d/1586366161371/Kartläggning%20av%20aktörer%20i%20det%20svenska%20innovationssystemet-04.pdf

Bourouaha, A., & Maliki, S. B. (2026). Exploring the drivers and hurdles of firm innovativeness in Sweden family firms. *ResearchGate*.

Brunnström, L. (2020). *Commercialization done differently: How Swedish university incubators facilitate the formation of knowledge-intensive entrepreneurial firms.* University of Gothenburg.

Business Sweden. (2020, September 1). *The land of unicorns.* https://www.business-sweden.com/insights/articles/the-land-of-unicorns/

Collis, J., & Hussey, R. (2021). *Business research: A practical guide for undergraduate & postgraduate students* (5th ed.). Macmillan Education.

Corporate Finance Institute. (2019). *Investor.* https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/wealth-management/investor/

Cote, C. (2023). *Startup incubator vs. accelerator: Which is right for You?* Havard Business School Online. https://online.hbs.edu/blog/post/startup-incubator-vs-accelerator

Davidsson, P., Achtenhagen, L., & Naldi, L. (2010). Small firm growth. *Foundations and Trends in Entrepreneurship*, *6*(2), 69-166. https://doi.org/10.1108/S1876-066X(2010)0000006008

Dealroom. (2025). *State of the Swedish Tech Ecosystem*. Dealroom.co. https://content.dealroom.co/uploaded/2025/05/Sweden-2024-full-report-1.pdf?x21901

Dealroom. (2026). *Investor Types.* Dealroom.co. https://knowledge.dealroom.co/knowledge/investor-types

Doyle, K. (2024, August 29). *Explainer: What is a unicorn?* Stanford Business. https://www.gsb.stanford.edu/insights/explainer-what-unicorn

Etzkowitz, H. (2003). Innovation in innovation: The triple helix of university-industry-government relations. *Social Science Information, 42*(3), 293-337. https://doi.org/10.1177/05390184030423002

Etzkowitz, H., and Leydesdorff, L. (1995). The triple helix -- university-industry-government relations: A laboratory for knowledge based economic development. *EASST Review, 14*(1), 14-19. https://ssrn.com/abstract=2480085

European Commission. (2021). *European scale-up gap - Too few good companies or too few good investors?* Directorate-General for Research and Innovation, Publications Office of the European Union. https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2777/3239776

European Commission. (2025). *European innovation scoreboard 2025*. Directorate-General for Research and Innovation, Publications Office of the European Union. https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2777/886042

European Investment Bank. (2024). *The scale-up gap: Financial market constraints holding back innovative firms.* EIB Publishing. https://www.eib.org/en/publications/20240130-the-scale-up-gap

Flechas-Takahashi, S. T. (2026). The triple helix and the quality of the startup ecosystem: a global view. *Journal of Business & Industrial Marketing*.

Freel, M. S., and Gordon, I. R. (2022). On the consequences of firm growth. *International Small Business Journal*, *40*(6), 674-695. https://doi.org/10.1177/02662426221087612

Frid, C. J., Wyman, D. M., & Shaver, K. G. (2025). Cultivating emerging gazelles: How entrepreneurial networks influence early firm success. *Journal of Small Business Strategy*, *35*(3), 29-40. https://doi.org/10.53703/001c.138478

Fusch, P., Fusch, G., & Ness, L. (2018). Denzin's paradigm shift: Revisiting triangulation in qualitative research. *Journal of Social Change*, *10*(1). https://doi.org/10.5590/JOSC.2018.10.1.02

Gartner, W. B. (1988). Who is an entrepreneur? Is the wrong question. *American Journal of Small Business*, *12*(4), 11-32. https://doi.org/10.1177/104225878801200401

Genedy, M., Hellerstedt, K., Naldi, L., & Wiklund, J. (2024). Growing pains in scale-ups: How scaling affects new venture employee burnout and job satisfaction. *Journal of Business Venturing*, *39*(2), 106367. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusvent.2023.106367

Gioia, D. A., & Chittipeddi, K. (1991). Sensemaking and sensegiving in strategic change initiation. *Strategic Management Journal*, *12*(6), 433-448.

Gioia, D. A., Corley, K. G., & Hamilton, A. L. (2013). Seeking qualitative rigor in inductive research: Notes on the Gioia methodology. *Organizational Research Methods*, *16*(1), 15-31.

Greiner, L.E. (1997). Evolution and revolution as organizations grow: A company's past has clues for management that are critical to future success. *Family Business Review*, *10*(4), 397-409. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-6248.1997.00397.x

Greiner, L. E. (1998). Evolution and revolution as organizations grow. *Harvard Business Review*, *76*(3), 55-68. https://www.ucg.ac.me/skladiste/blog_8559/objava_99894/fajlovi/GREINER%20Evolution_and_Revolution_as_Organizations_Grow.pdf

Hjalmarsson, D. (2022). Building local innovation support systems: Theory and practice. In K. Wennberg & C. Sandström (Eds.), *Questioning the entrepreneurial state: Status-quo, pitfalls, and the need for credible innovation policy* (pp. 95–109). Springer Nature. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-94273-1_6

Industrifonden. (2026). *Our Story - Bringing Nordic breakthrough innovations to the world*. https://industrifonden.com/

Jacobsen, D. I. (2017). *Hur genomför man undersökningar? Introduktion till samhällsvetenskaplig metod* (3rd ed.). Studentlitteratur.

Kirzner, I. M. (1973). *Competition and entrepreneurship.* University of Chicago Press.

Lewis, V., & Churchill, N. (1987). The five stages of small business growth. *Harvard Business Review*, *61*(3), 30-50.

Leydesdorff, L. (2012). The triple helix of university-industry-government relations. In E. Carayannis & D. Campbell (Eds.), *Encyclopedia of creativity, innovation, and entrepreneurship*. Springer. http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.1996760

Läkemedelsverket. (2026). Contact. https://www.lakemedelsverket.se/en/about-the-swedish-mpa/contact-us#hmainbody1

McKinsey & Company. (2025). The scale-up conundrum: Evolving startups from founder-led growth. McKinsey Global Institute. https://www.mckinsey.com/uk/our-insights/the-mckinsey-uk-blog/the-scale-up-conundrum

Opute, A. P., Kalu, K. I., Adeola, O., & Iwu, C. G. (2021). Steering sustainable economic growth: Entrepreneurial ecosystem approach. *Journal of Entrepreneurship and Innovation in Emerging Economies*, *7*(2), 216-245. https://doi.org/10.1177/23939575211024384

Penrose, E. T. (1959). *The theory of the growth of the firm.* Blackwell Publishing.

Picken, J. C. (2021). Managing the barriers to startup scalability. *California Management Review*, *60*(4), 12-34.

Rastvortseva, S. N., Panasiuk, S. A., & Chudaykin, D. A. (2025). The role of the startup ecosystem in shaping the innovative competitiveness of a national economy (case studies of Sweden and Estonia). *Journal of Regional and International Competitiveness*, *6*(3), 16-26.

Regeringskansliet. (2024). *Det offentliga stödet till startups och scaleups ska effektiviseras*. https://www.regeringen.se/pressmeddelanden/2024/05/det-offentliga-stodet-till-startups-och-scaleups-ska-effektiviseras/

Saunders, M. N. K., Lewis, P., & Thornhill, A. (2023). *Research methods for business students* (9th ed.). Pearson.

SCB. (2008). *Karta över NUTS-indelningen i Sverige.* SCB RM/REN. https://tillvaxtverket.se/download/18.2a2ae249185be5f310f1ca56/1674581152846/NUTS_1_2_3_20080101-2.pdf

Schroders. (2026). *Understanding private equity.* Schroders.com https://www.schroders.com/en-au/au/adviser/resources/understanding-private-equity/

Schumpeter, J. A. (1934). *The theory of economic development*. Harvard University Press.

Shane, S., & Venkataraman, S. (2000). The promise of entrepreneurship as a field of research. *Academy of Management Review*, *25*(1), 217-226. https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2000.2791611

Stam, E. (2015). *Entrepreneurial ecosystems and regional policy: A sympathetic critique* (Discussion Paper Series Vol. 15, No. 07). UU USE Tjalling C. Koopmans Research Institute.

Stam, E., & van de Ven, A. (2021). Entrepreneurial ecosystem elements. *Small Business Economics*, *56*(2), 809-832. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11187-019-00270-6

Startup Genome. (2025). *The Startup Genome Report: Premature Scaling.* https://startupgenome.com/reports

Stinchcombe, A. L. (1965). Social structure and organizations. In: J. G. March (Ed.) *Handbook of organizations* (pp. 142-193). Rand McNally.

Stockholm Insights. (2025). *Stockholm - Europe's unicorn factory.* Stockholm Business Region. https://www.stockholmbusinessregion.com/insights/tech/

Suchman, M. C. (1995). Managing legitimacy: Strategic and institutional approaches. *The Academy of Management Review*, *20*(3), 571-610. https://doi.org/10.2307/258788

Swedish Incubators & Science Parks. (2026). *En nationell infrastruktur för innovation, tillväxt och omställning*. https://www.sisp.se/science-parks/

Szathmári, E., Varga, Z., Molnár, A., Németh, G., Szabó, Z. P., & Kiss, O. E. (2024). Why do startups fail? A core competency deficit model. *Frontiers in Psychology*, *15*, 1299135.

Tillväxtverket. (2024). *Entreprenörskap och nystartade företag i Sverige* [Entrepreneurship and newly started companies in Sweden]. https://tillvaxtverket.se/tillvaxtverket/om-tillvaxtverket/publikationer/publikationer-2024/2024-03-01-entreprenorskap-och-nystartade-foretag-i-sverige

Tillväxtverket. (2026). *Financing.* https://tillvaxtverket.se/tillvaxtverket/inenglish/financing.2911.html

Verksamt. (2025). *Business Angels.* https://verksamt.se/en/financing-business-advice/business-angels

Vinnova. (2024). *Swedish startups attract investments.* https://www.vinnova.se/en/news/2024/03/swedish-startups-attract-investments

Vinnova. (2026). *Incubation, startups and scaleups.* https://www.vinnova.se/en/topics-and-areas-of-expertise/incubation-startups-and-scaleups/

Väisänen, T. (2020). *State of the Swedish Innovation Support System 2020.* STUNS Life Science. https://lifescience.stuns.se/wp-content/uploads/2021/02/Report-Tuomas-Va%CC%88isa%CC%88nen-State-of-the-Swedish-Innovation-Support-System-2020-Jan-2020-STUNS-Life-science.pdf

Williams, C. (2007). Research methods. *Journal of Business & Economics Research (JBER)*, *5*(3), 65-72. https://doi.org/10.19030/jber.v5i3.2532.

World Economic Forum. (2013). *Entrepreneurial ecosystems around the globe and company growth dynamics.* World Economic Forum. https://www3.weforum.org/docs/WEF_EntrepreneurialEcosystems_Report_2013.pdf

World Intellectual Property Organization. (2025). *Sweden ranking in the Global Innovation Index 2025.* https://www.wipo.int/gii-ranking/en/sweden

Yilmaz, K. (2013). Comparison of quantitative and qualitative research traditions: Epistemological, theoretical, and methodological differences. *European Journal of Education*, *48*(2), 311-325.

Zimmerman, M. A., & Zeitz, G. J. (2002). Beyond survival: Achieving new venture growth by building legitimacy. *The Academy of Management Review*, *27*(3), 414-431. https://doi.org/10.2307/4134387

Appendix

Appendix 1: Interview Guide Swedish

Intervju Guide	Svenska
Allmänna frågor	▪ Kan du beskriva din roll och vad du arbetar med? ▪ Hur skulle du definiera tillväxt i företag? ▪ Vad skiljer mellan kontinuerlig tillväxt och kortsiktig tillväxt? ▪ Utifrån din erfarenhet, vad kännetecknar företag som lyckas skapa tillväxt över tid? *Tillväxtprocessen* ▪ Kan du beskriva ett företag som du har sett uppnå långsiktig tillväxt? Vad möjliggjorde den utvecklingen? ▪ Vilka är de största utmaningarna företag stöter på när det gäller att upprätthålla tillväxt över tid? ▪ Hur viktiga är nätverk och relationer för att upprätthålla tillväxt?
Entreprenör	*Internt perspektiv* ▪ Vad anser du är ditt huvudsakliga ansvar i att forma kontinuerlig tillväxt? ▪ Vilka förmågor är mest avgörande för att upprätthålla tillväxt över tid? ▪ Hur förändras din roll i takt med att företaget växer? *Investerare* ▪ Vad förväntar du dig av investerare för att kunna upprätthålla långsiktig tillväxt? ▪ Utöver kapital, vilken typ av stöd från en investerare är mest värdefullt? ▪ Vad missförstår investerare ibland när det gäller tillväxt? *Innovationsstödsystemet* ▪ Vilken roll spelar stödorganisationer i att forma kontinuerlig tillväxt? ▪ Var tillför dem mest värde? ▪ Vad skulle de kunna förbättra för att bättra stödja långsiktig tillväxt?
Investerare	*Investerar logik* ▪ Hur bedömer du om ett företag har potential för långsiktig tillväxt? ▪ Vilka signaler kan tidigt indikera långsiktig skalbarhet? ▪ Vad kan tidigt tyda på att det kommer finnas utmaningar framåt? *Entreprenörer* ▪ Vad gör entreprenörer bra för att möjliggöra kontinuerlig tillväxt? ▪ Vilka är vanliga misstag som entreprenörer gör när det gäller att forma långsiktig tillväxt? ▪ Hur bör entreprenörer utvecklas i takt med att deras företag skalar upp? *Innovationsstödsystemet* ▪ Hur viktiga är inkubatorer, acceleratorer och offentliga aktörer för att forma tillväxt? ▪ Vad gör dem bra? ▪ Var brister dem? ▪ Vad bör dem prioritera för att bättra möjliggöra långsiktigt tillväxt?
Innovationsstödsystem	*Organisationens roll* ▪ Hur ser du på er organisations roll i att forma kontinuerlig tillväxt i företag? ▪ I vilken fas är ert stöd som mest avgörande? *Entreprenörer* ▪ Vilka förmågor behöver entreprenörer utveckla för att uppnå långsiktig tillväxt? ▪ Var upplever du att entreprenörer oftast har svårigheter? ▪ Vad bör entreprenörer fokusera på utöver den tidiga utvecklingsfasen? *Investerare*

	▪ Viken roll spelar investerare i att format långsiktig tillväxt i företag? ▪ Var bidrar investerare mest effektivt? ▪ Finns det spänningar mellan investeringslogik och långsiktigt tillväxt?
Avslutande allmänna frågor	▪ Om du fick förändra en sak i ekosystemet för att bättre möjliggöra kontinuerlig tillväxt, vad skulle det vara? ▪ Vad är något i samarbete med någon av de andra två grupperna som kan göras eller implementeras för att bättre möjliggöra kontinuerlig tillväxt? ▪ Är det något vi inte diskuterat som du anser är avgörande för att förstå långsiktig tillväxt i företag?

Appendix 2: Data Analysis of Entrepreneurs

	Entrepreneur East	**Entrepreneur South/West**	**Entrepreneur North**	**Entrepreneur Summary**
What is growth	When you go from one start to another phase. You don't stand and stomp but take steps in the value increase of the company	Product or service that is validated by the market. And through its value proposition, you can scale up to larger levels.	Increased turnover. The company grows in the number of products, employees and partnerships	From one phase to another. The value increase of the company or turnover increases. The hosting offer is validated by the market, and you can scale up.
How to measure growth	You get more capital, increase in value in the company	New markets or customer segments.	Increased turnover, number of employees and partnerships	Bring in more capital. New markets or customer segments. Increased turnover or the number of employees.
Short-term	It is often quite easy to start a company. Sometimes a little too easy to get in a first investment round	Not committing does much in fixed costs too quickly. It is difficult to become profitable and grow an organization. Rapid growth can be done by only bringing in a couple of large customers.	Timing is incredibly important and you have some flow. The entrepreneur has an overly optimistic view of the future and fails in creating a long-term perspective.	Sometimes it's a little too easy to get a first round of investment. Sometimes a few customers can be enough to create short-term growth. Timing is crucial and maybe you have some flow.
Long-term	You start generating your own income. You can build up the business. Find partners. You have an attractive product. There must be a need that the market to understand. Create attraction and make those around you understand the value.	A strong foundation is required for the company to be able to handle growth over time. Have a structure and organization that can handle it. Clear internal processes in place. Ensure that the number of resources per deal becomes smaller with larger	Financial stamina so that you can afford to make the right decisions. Have a clear and well-thought-out plan going forward. Work the brand and signal what you stand for. What do you want	Financial stamina and a good foundation for being able to afford to make long-term decisions. Create attractions and make the outside world understand the value. Succeed in getting through the noise. Create scalability.

	Manages to get through the noise.	volumes. Scalability. Bring expertise into the company that knows how to streamline as the organization grows. Build a corporate culture, work with values and direction. A larger organization requires a lot more administrative work and makes sure that employees are happy. Customer relations. PERSEVERANCE! You must believe in what you do. Be able to handle pressure in a constructive way.	people to say about the company when you're not there? Have a clear idea of how you want to be perceived and work towards achieving it. Must trust both internally and externally. Work past the "nice" words. Make sure there is substance behind it. There must be something under the surface.	Build a corporate culture and work with values and direction. Stand for what you are working towards and make others understand what it is. There must be substances under the surface. Build trust both internally and externally.
Challenges	If you don't raise capital in time. End up in a trap focusing on delivering to investors and in the process of losing direction.	To build a company that cares about both internal and external at the same time. It is easy to choose one focus and forget the other.	Not trusting that it will work out and make hasty decisions. Not treating employees in the right way, it is important to make them want to stay for something they have built on.	Not fall into a trap of adapting too much to someone else's goals or expectations. Not making hasty decisions.
Network	It's very important. Everything is based on having good external relationships.	Very important, especially with financiers because without money you can't run a company. Also, customer relationships to be able to create a business.	It is extremely important, especially to know what kind of partner you want to work with and create a long-lasting relationship. It is also incredibly important to build a team.	It is extremely important to build the right relationships with external partners such as investors and customers. It is important to have an agenda when networking.
Entrepreneur	Bridging the gap between the organization and the board. Responsibility for driving the company forward.	Do things in the right priority. Develop the value proposition based on customer feedback. Keep an	Too much focus on raising money. Not as much time is spent on strategy. At the same time, it is	Too much focus on raising capital takes the focus away from future work and strategic decisions.

	You have to dare to replace management and CEO if it benefits the company as it grows. While the person who leads the company can also develop, the company's best interests must always be at the center to choose who should steer the direction forward.	ear to the market. Don't commit too much to fixed costs. Be flexible. Focus on trying to have key people and cutting-edge expertise within the company. As the company develops, so does the leadership role. There is a need for a more comprehensive role and someone who steers the direction forward. It can be difficult to give up control, but the most important thing is that you are forward-looking in all decisions.	needed for the company to survive. Without capital, there is no business. The most important thing is to have a solution to focus on. And be okay with leaving tough things behind. Go from wearing many hats in the start-up phase to focusing on what you are good at by hiring more people. Dare to create change and make sure you have a CEO who is right for the company and what they want to achieve.	Have an ear to the market and dare to change within the company and the value proposition. Focus on solutions and put past mistakes behind you. Focus on having key people within the company. Dare to change the management of the company as it grows and develops. It is easy to get lost and forget what is best for the company due to pressure from investors.
Investor logic	Someone who has the opportunity to follow the company over time, through follow-up investments. Opens their network and creates new customer contacts. Contributes with some type of expertise that in turn increases the company's growth. That they want the best for the company and therefore make sure to market it. Strategic sounding board. Challenge to communicate about common expectations. As an investor, you must look at investing in a startup in a certain way, more like a lottery than investing	Smart money is important, i.e. Where you get something more than just capital from the investor. It can be skills that are lacking in the company or that can be developed even more. Someone who contributes by having experience from before. Can follow up on their investment in several rounds. Often an unrealistic picture of potential growth, many people want to see a hockey stick even though they know that they will almost never be	Investors can contribute in several ways, if they have contributed money, they want the company to succeed, and they can then act as a subcontractor to increase growth. It is easy to end up in a position of dependence on investors, and the risk is then that you adapt too much and deviate from your plan. Bringing in the wrong investors can create a sway in the company. Many people have a rather short-term view of what they want the company	Investors should contribute more than capital to increase their chances of growth. If you have ownership shares, you should be concerned about the company's success. It is valuable that they share networks, contacts, previous experiences, and cutting-edge expertise. It is important that the investor can follow the company for a period and follow up on their investment in future rounds. Usually, an unrealistic view of

	in slightly more stable companies on the stock exchange.	achieved. Easy to compare with successful companies even though the trips and business ideas are completely different.	to achieve without really wanting to familiarize themselves and understand before judging them. You have to be okay with setbacks.	what is achievable within a certain time frame. Often compare them with other companies without trying to get the whole picture.
Support system	Support in the early phase is usually very good. I think there is a lack of support in the growth phase. Many different actors who almost bombard with events and activities that they make sound are crucial for success. Should be available with support at a later stage, such as finding the right partner. A lot of focus on bringing in external capital and almost no support if you want to grow organically. Maybe they should make it even more difficult to start a business and really test the business idea before going too far with something that will never work. Find new ways to help entrepreneurs in the next phase, through networking, a business coach or with support in how to scale up their commercialization.	Coaching and introducing investor networks is very valuable. Creating a community with others in a similar situation. Exchanging knowledge and experiences among themselves. The further you get on your journey, the less support there is to take part in. At the same time, it may be the case that if you cannot stand on your own two feet at the time when a lot of support disappears, perhaps you should not exist anyway.	Find people who can be quick-thinking and supportive. Stay in touch to have external eyes on an entire process and not just when you have problems. Transparency is important. And allow someone to have insight into the company if you want to get the right kind of help. Perhaps they should screen the companies even harder in the beginning to really be able to direct their support where it is needed most. Maybe they should help by forcing a plan b. To think about what happens if you don't keep to the schedule or can't deliver on what you promised the investors.	A lot of focus, help, and support in the early phase. Fewer people have chosen to support companies further in their journey. Helps create a valuable community where all groups have the opportunity to meet each other. Important for creating growth. Important with transparency to be able to get relevant help and support. Perhaps they should screen the companies even tougher in the beginning to make sure that they are spending time and resources on a case that has potential. Perhaps even later we should force a plan b to get a contractor to understand what is required and ensure if it does not go as planned.
Transforming the ecosystem to better enable continuous growth	Create greater demands on the support system because it is tax-financed. Investors often invest their own money, and it is	There is too much focus on raising money and not as much on building prosperous companies that can grow over time.	I haven't experienced a real community so maybe it's that the different actors don't show enough to each other or	Put more pressure on the innovation support organizations because they are tax funded. Too much focus on chasing and raising

	then more difficult to make greater demands for that group. It should be their task to bring the other groups together and educate both sides to better enable common goals and expectations.	Inform and educate about other ways to build the companies than venture capital. The support organization should act as more support for a company builder than pushing to bring in venture capital. Do not seek artificial respiration but make sure to build a healthy body.	that support isn't available in all industries. The focus should be on creating a financial foundation so that people can afford to make long-term decisions.	capital instead of also informing and educating about how to create organic growth. You should want to build prosperous and profitable companies instead of relying on artificial respiration through venture capital.

Appendix 3: Data Analysis of Investors

	Investor East	**Investor South/West**	**Investor North**	**Investor Summary**
What is growth	Something that grows, continuous curve upwards	Reach profitability	Solid foundation and revenue	Sustainable growth, continuous upward slope
How to measure growth	Turnover and profit	Turnover, size of organization. Markets and revenue streams, gaining new market shares, key people who stay	Attracting and raising external funding	Turnover, profits, market share, revenue streams, partnerships, attracting external parties and investments
Short-term	Individual years that stand out, rapid profit increase is quite easy, a little luck, hard work for a short while. Many quick decisions with many choices, not always fully thought out	Very aggressive development, company valuation is what decides.	Fast rushes, at any cost. Run after the money. Forget about vision. Survival at any cost.	Fast, aggressive, a little luck and a short time of hard work.
Long-term	Good at going from thought to action, change culture in the company, good at screwing and optimizing all the time. Dared to work. Will is the foundation. You want to grow.	Persevere, build basic elements, perseverance, financial muscle, survive despite cycles, management that raise strategic issues, allocates resources, understands the world around them,	Finances and corporate culture that lasts over time, grows as much as possible with own funds, business model that attracts, the ability to change your business model, kill your darlings, balance between	Moving from thought to action Change culture Adapting business model Plan ahead Understanding the world around us and customers Building basic elements Creating a bigger

		shares vision with employees. Ear to the market all the time, understand what the customer wants. Grows in a controlled manner. Grows in the number of strategic partnerships	revenues and adapt to reality. The right partner. Secure and retain competence.	market Key people stay within the organization.
Challenges	Do just the right amount, it is difficult to optimize if you stand completely still. Short-term work decisions, get through discomfort. A goal-oriented leadership is required. Make difficult decisions. Get the organization on board and get them motivated. People don't take enough help, pride in doing a lot themselves.	Political differences, sudden changes, how do you stay relevant in a changing world? Recruitment is a challenge, recruit key people. Live up to expectations and demands from external parties.	It is difficult to find a business model that lasts over time. What do I need and who do I want in the company?	Get the organization on board, make difficult decisions, recruitment, match business model with market
Network	Absolutely crucial, dare to zoom out. Be inspired, listen, and learn from others. You can't come up with everything yourself.	Risks and opportunities are shared. Mutual trust.	Very important, the support from the innovation support system is invaluable.	Absolutely crucial, learn from each other, share risk and trust, and not do everything yourself.
The entrepreneur	Someone who talks or listens and learns. Have the strength to get through difficult times. Dare to try The entrepreneur must be willing to get help. Usually good at something but rarely in the big picture. Afraid to ask questions, can indicate weakness. You must have a clear direction to work towards the compass that guides the strategic work.	Create credibility. They have enough knowledge to implement what they say. What does their journey look like, how do they take on the challenge. Entrepreneurs can be a little too naïve. Think about whether external investors are really the right way to go. With new people comes new demands. Underestimating the way forward,	Dare to test early against the market. Understand the customer and find a genuine need. Not be too naïve and think that everything will work out. Awareness and belief that nothing is impossible. Too optimistic, they think it will take less time than it does in reality. Must be a stress-resistant person.	Get help and be humble about the fact that you can't manage everything yourself. Many people underestimate the time spent and are too optimistic about themselves and in their communication with external parties. There should be a willingness to adapt to the customer and the market. Think through the investment and what

	Work goal oriented. Dare to change the workforce. Dare to replace yourself.	how long it will take to land real business relationships. Make sure you have reserves and use them wisely, like a camel. Endurance.		requirements it comes with.
Investor logic	The value is in the people in the company. The product must have benefits and relevance in society. Serial entrepreneurs are preferable because they have already made mistakes and learned from them.	It is based on the person. The vision and what they want to do with it. You must validate the idea early. Set clear milestones and the road map there. Initiated strategic partnerships early. You don't solve a big enough problem, the transition becomes too difficult for the customer. Scalability.	Clear business idea. Confidence in the contractor. Is a clear plan presented? Is there an alternative plan? A too steep curve is a red flag. Give my own time and actively participate in the company	The team is most important. There must be a clear vision and a realistic and mapped out path to get there. Credibility. Customer validation and scalability. Is there a need for a business idea?
Support system	Fundamental and with great potential to help and support. Facilitate matching and guarantee that entrepreneurs meet relevant skills and build networks. A little overconfidence that you will be certified through an incubator and that it will solve all problems if you get a title on LinkedIn. Many actors do a lot in the early phase. A lot of prestige should be a little more open and popular, so that everyone feels welcome. They are not visible enough, it is often the same people who spin around because	Very important. Enable you to go from idea to commercialization Good at gathering everyone around a common agenda. Creating exchanges and new opportunities for synergies. Many times, the incubators are focused on the companies growing so that it suits them and their process and not always what is the right path for the company in question.	They are a good education for the entrepreneur to learn a lot, early in the journey. Support in testing the business idea and business model. They are involved in the entire journey, from start to finish, in different ways. Actors within the same ecosystem cannibalize each other. They are often financed in the same way and have the same requirements to live up to, this makes them compete for the same companies to reach set goals in numbers, etc.	Important role for learning and maturation of entrepreneurs and business ideas. Matching with networks and expertise. Lack of visibility and flexibility. Negative competition between actors questions their intentions. If they are financed in the same way and have the same demands on them, there is a risk that they will all start doing the same thing. Will their help be adapted to the company or to create something that they

	you already must be inside the system to find further. Not everyone is passionate about doing well for the companies or for them to build something for real. They are also chasing results and quantifying their results in a negative way. You have to show some cool names as alumni. Often a little too generic processes, not adapted to the companies and their actual needs. When a coach does not deliver or live up to expectations, they dare to replace.		Dare to review the contractor and test the business idea early.	can later highlight as a success case?
Transforming the ecosystem to better enable continuous growth	It must be easier to start a business. If more people start, there is also a greater chance that some will grow into really large companies that in turn contribute a lot of good to society. There are also many obstacles to helping others if you want to. Training in both directions so that both the entrepreneur and the investor can better understand each other.	Increase visibility, many people do not know what resources are available. Many players have requirements regarding which companies fit into their processes as their results must be measurable and comparable with others. Too many policies within the innovation system and top-down. Changes in focus also because of politics, different governments want you to invest in different things.	There is a need for more collaboration between the supporting organizations. Networks gather everything in the same place so that the entrepreneur does not have to look for the right support. De-dramatize and instead focus on the different groups meeting in an effective way.	There is a need for deeper and more elaborate cooperation between the actors within the ecosystem. Invest in skills development so that all groups better understand the purpose of the others and how they can benefit from each other. Establish more open and inclusive communication.

Appendix 4: Data Analysis of Innovation Support System Actors

	Innovation support East	Innovation support South/West	Innovation support North	Summary Innovation support
What is growth	Increased turnover or impact in some way. The ability to contribute to a value for the customer or for society.	Increased turnover and an increase in the number of employees. To create more job opportunities and thereby generate more tax money that is reinvested in the support system.	Increased turnover, employing more people, which leads to more jobs. Strategically grows, both in terms of results and organizationally at the same time. Profitability. A constant striving for progress. Increased company valuation. Be sustainable within the limits of the planet.	Increased turnover, more employees. Creating value for customers and society. Economic expansion, strategic decisions and sustainable development.
How to measure growth	Increased turnover. Number of employees.	Increased turnover and the number of employees.	Increased turnover. More jobs. Growing organization. The company increases in valuation.	Increased sales. Number of employees, organizational development and company valuation.
Short-term	Many focus on creating value for investors and forget a little about how they fit into the market and really the business itself. They focus more on selling their idea to investors than to customers.	Jump on trends without thinking about whether it is right for the company in the long term. Affected a lot by fluctuations in the outside world because the company is not stable yet.	The classic hockey stick, that you grow exponentially. Everyone needs to have initial growth to also be able to achieve long-term growth. Often a result of "quick money".	Strong focus on investors, trends and rapid expansion. Less focus on market adaptation.
Long-term	The key to a long-term approach is to offer something of value to the customer. Always have the business in focus and pivot based on it. Be able to adapt to shifts in the outside world, politics, economy, laws and regulations. Build stability and know that one's product matches the market.	Have the ability to adapt and create a strategy for the future. Allow external eyes to shine through and support to achieve increased growth. Look at their organization from the outside. Perseverance. Create resilience. Mixed teams are a strength in creating long-term growth.	Proven scalability in the long run. The growth itself is not the goal, but instead a consequence of good work. Building a profitable company that should have the goal of remaining. How mature is the entrepreneur and the market.	Long-term growth is based on customer value and market adaptation. A strong and complementary team. Perseverance and adaptability and focus on creating a sustainable and profitable company.

	A stable and complementary team is extremely important for the long-term. Do not rely too much on external actors but try to find people who can stay in the company. Patience is essential.	Working closely with their customers. Strong drive to want to solve a problem. Divide roles and clearly create responsibilities. Try to understand their customers. That the team can work efficiently is the most important thing.	Create a good relationship with their customers. Create a good culture and work environment for their employees. Works to maintain competitiveness. Perseverance, especially in the first phase. Keep working even when no one else believes in you. Be able to adapt and dare to pivot. Maintain continuous contact with the support organization.	
Challenges	You don't spend enough time and resources on really understanding your customers. You connect the market far too late in the development process. You bring in money to develop everything yourself instead of collaborating. You are afraid that someone will steal your idea. They forget about customer care and constantly focus on new business. They do not use soft money but believe that venture capital is the only way forward.	One challenge is not having a specific enough focus. Retaining a CEO who is not really the best at driving growth in the company. Failing in attracting and bringing in the right people.	Shifts in the international situation. Instability in global trade and political changes. Overconfidence in how many time things will take. Not devoting enough resources to reviewing external parties before entering a collaboration. Creating something that there is a need for and not something you think you need. Meet regulatory requirements and other laws. Managing to raise capital in time and before you must adapt too much because you do not have financial stability.	Lack of customer understanding. Not attracting the right skills. Incorrect priorities and uncertainty about raising capital and other external factors. Engages the market too late in the development process. Not daring to change the management of the company or adapt the structure to what is best for the company, especially when it grows. Fear of cooperation and excessive willingness to do everything yourself.

Network	Very important. That is one of the strengths of Sweden. There are great opportunities to build deep relationships. There are many people who offer and open their network without it being seen as competing. At the same time, we need to become even better at networking with a clear agenda and daring to approach specific people.	Very important. A large network and good relationships can ensure that you get answers to all the questions you have and challenges you face in driving growth in a company. At the same time, it can be difficult to sort between advice that you get from your network. It is important that you constantly work actively with your network.	Super important. Basically, it's people who do business with each other. Absolutely crucial. If you have not built a good network, you will never grow. It is more important to have deeper relationships than many in number. It increases the chances of getting a good fundraising round if there is something you need. A built network can ensure that you get a good exchange of experience and skills. Helps to navigate correctly.	Networks are crucial for growth. Strong and relevant relationships enable knowledge exchange, capital raising and strategic guidance. Requires active work and a clear agenda.
The entrepreneur	Patience is extremely important in an entrepreneur. It has to do with daring to take risks and wanting to expose yourself to new situations. Self-confidence. If you don't believe in your idea, it's hard to get others to do it. And it must be seen and heard outwardly. Be open to getting help and making use of your network. Attract people who have skills that the company needs. To keep up the momentum and constantly strive to develop and become better.	Talk to the customer. They are the best salespeople for their own product, so it is important that they are out and talking to the market. Familiarizing yourself with and understanding the company's finances, even if the area is not one's main responsibility. It is important to be able to move on quickly after setbacks so as not to get caught up in the negative. Should an offer be based on the customer's actual needs.	Must have expertise in the area you operate. Be social and build networks. To attract the right investors and employees. You must have perseverance and a very strong drive. You can't be afraid to take risks. Nor do you see problems, but instead solutions. Be relationship oriented. Also be able to be humble about the fact that you can't do everything yourself. Want to get help. You must be clear about what you want to achieve, right from the start. Very important with the passion	Perseverance, drive and patience. Self-confidence and the ability to convey one's vision. Dare to take risks and deal with setbacks. Understand the customer's needs and the market. Be open to help and actively use your network. Build teams and delegate, let go of control. Continuously develop leadership based on the company's growth phase. Understand finances on a deeper level and create realistic timelines.

	Many people get stuck in the idea that you must do everything yourself. Difficult to delegate. Building teams and continuously evaluating leadership to fit where the company is on its journey. Too much focus on bringing in external capital and too little on making sure that their value proposition fits the customer and the market. The entrepreneur should spend more time reviewing an investor just like they do before investing in a company.	Should be curious and hungry to work. Work based on their strengths.	and drive. Responsiveness and willingness to improve and learn along the way. Know when it is time to change management in the company. Focus on building a team. Few people keep track of how long things take and thus create an unrealistic timetable. Many find it difficult to let go of control and trust others.	Be solution-oriented, curious and willing to learn.
Investor logic	Capital is the foundation of an investment, but it is even more important what you are willing to follow up the investment with. Do you have cutting-edge expertise you can share or is your network of value to the company you are investing in. If you put money into something, you are often eager for it to go well and then more willing to support in the way that is possible. Better understand how much you are expected to engage in a startup	They have a very important role in growth. Just want to contribute capital but also share knowledge and networks. Make sure to support them in any way they can to also ensure that they can make a good exit. Create legitimacy against other investors, show that you believe in the entrepreneur. Act as a strategic sounding board. More understanding from investors what it means for the entrepreneur to give up control in exchange for money.	They play a very important role as all companies that want to grow need to be financed. Especially those that enter early and take a much higher risk than the bank may be willing to do. It is important that there is a sustainability in the investment and that investors have the opportunity to follow up on their investment in future rounds. It is important that the investor believes in the entrepreneur and does not make unreasonable demands or try to push through their	Capital is important, but expertise and networks can also be of great importance. Investors act as strategic sounding boards. Active involvement and the opportunity to follow up on investments are important. Matching between entrepreneur and investor is crucial. Trust, transparency and common goals are central. Investors contribute to legitimacy and signal quality. Investors need to better understand the entrepreneur's situation and process.

	compared to investing your money in the stock market. There are times when venture capital is not the best option for creating growth. Sometimes development needs to take place a little slower and sometimes it is not worth selling shares in the company because it means that you also let go of control. Trust and confidence are crucial for the entrepreneur and the investor to agree and be able to work towards a common goal.	Many investors demand that growth is focused on increasing sales or the value of the company. If the entrepreneur has other priorities such as impact or sustainability, which can sometimes affect how much sales can grow, it can create friction between the two groups. It is very important to find the right match in an investor and not just chase money.	own agenda. Have respect for the people who have managed to build something, otherwise you can invest in something else. Think long-term about where you invest your money. Very few startups that keep to the schedule and then you can be stuck with your money longer than intended. Have an exit plan right from the start. Understand the value of being able to contribute more than just capital. Be open to contributing in different ways in or around the company. Focus on creating common expectations between entrepreneur and investor at an early stage. It can be tough if you don't have the same priorities or views on where to focus. It can be difficult to put yourself in the contractor's situation if you haven't gone through something similar yourself. Honesty and trust are cornerstones for successful cooperation. It takes courage from both sides. Investors need to have a better	

			understanding of the entire process that an entrepreneur goes through when raising capital.	
Support system	Lays many cornerstones in company building. Supports and is an advisor in critical choices. Important role in educating about alternative paths and ways to develop one's company and its value proposition. Inspiration and pep when you encounter setbacks. Help the entrepreneur to translate their knowledge into something for which there is a need and a market. Plays an important role in facilitating contacts and creating networks around a business idea or an entrepreneur. As a state actor, we can also lend our brand as a stamp that creates credibility and recognition before the company can achieve it itself. Paving the way for the entrepreneur through the existing collaborations that we as a support organization already have. At the same time, there is a lot of competition between the support organizations, which can instead	Connect entrepreneurs with investors or potential partners. Guides the entrepreneur through the process of bringing in venture capital and other ways to create growth. Create an understanding of what requirements may be set later in the development of the company. Rather whip the companies a little than curl them so that they understand that it will be tough when they are commercialized. There is naturally a lot of support before and after bringing in external capital because, it is often something new for the entrepreneur and afterwards it can require a lot of guidance on how to arrive at common expectations towards and from investors.	Fulfils an important function in supporting in a very early phase. There is a lot of support in the stage of starting up a business. Helps with advice until they can stand on their own two feet. Can pass on within the innovation support system if another actor can help them even better. At the same time, there is a lot of competition between the different actors because their mission is similar. It can be a challenge as an entrepreneur to keep track of all the players and what they specialize in. Work in parallel with the company throughout their journey. Educate and inform about what it is like to run a business and what is required. Create an activity plan together with the entrepreneur. Act external eyes and provide constructive feedback.	Important role in the early phase through advice, guidance and structure. Helps entrepreneurs develop business ideas and find markets. Facilitates networks, contacts and collaborations. Contributes legitimacy through branding and connection to state actors. Support in capital raising and understanding of investment processes. Acts as external eyes and gives feedback. Helps build teams and find skills Challenges in the form of competition between actors. Can be difficult for entrepreneurs to navigate the system.

	inhibit the entrepreneur from having access to everything that is on offer. Work even more with skills supply and help a startup find the right talent.		Fulfils an important function in helping to build teams and ensuring that companies get the right skills into the company. Many entrepreneurs who need to hold a hand when they are going to bring in external capital for the first time.	
Transform the ecosystem to better enable continuous growth	Must be better at sharing the resources that exist within the innovation support system. Many are financed in the same way and compete for the same bag of money in the hope of helping companies in the best way. The institutional organizations are too closed and tied to the fact that their support must be directed in one direction. Instead, there should be an opportunity to broaden the support to those who need it if you are best at something. Better use of the resources that are available. Too much is governed by rules and policies, which in turn are affected too much by politics. It is difficult to build up a long-term perspective in the support that can be offered if the focus on what type of support it should be	All groups would benefit from more widespread cooperation. The biggest obstacle is that many are financed by public money, which comes with an agenda and different requirements to measure one's activities on. Measurement points, in turn, affect which companies receive help because how they do determine how much money the support organization receives from its financiers. The support must go from a standard model that you believe, and hope will suit many people to invest more and make sure to adapt as needed. Set similar requirements for the support that is given as what you expect the company you are helping to do to its market.	Achieve deeper collaboration between all three groups. To increase understanding of the role of the others and the willingness to work together to create growth. There is too much channelling between the support organizations. There would need to be a coordinating organization that ensures that everyone has their focus and helps to channel the entrepreneur further. Today, it is often that you keep an entrepreneur to achieve static that you are measured on, which in turn determines how you are financed. Instead of sending the person on to another actor who can support them even better. Educate investors on how to treat an entrepreneur and a	Need for increased collaboration between entrepreneurs, investors and support systems. Reduced competition and increased resource sharing between support actors. Current funding structures and measurement requirements have a negative impact on the behaviour of support organisations. Need for a long-term perspective despite political control. More needs-based support instead of standardized models. Better geographical spread of venture capital. Stronger support for companies in later growth phases. Training and increased understanding between actors.

	changes all the time. Find new ways to really use the infrastructure that is being built and that creates many opportunities. Together with investors, develop creative investment vehicles that suit specific sectors. Educate each other in what we are best at. Create more space for resource sharing and networking. Develop a type of innovation procurement. A procurement system that benefits startups that often contribute something that the market has not seen before, but which may solve the problem even better.	There must be better ways to reach capital. Today, it is unevenly distributed geographically, and it should not affect a business idea negatively. Create sharper support for slightly more mature companies that have come further on their growth journey. Engage coaches and mentors who still have a foot in the market. A way to ensure that the support given to companies is up-to-date and relevant.	business idea in a neutral way to create a more equal investment climate. Encourage more entrepreneurs to share their journey with other entrepreneurs. There is so much knowledge to be gained. Better and more long-term collaboration with investors to support companies together in the best way and over a longer period.	More practical relevant support through mentors with a market connection. Development of new forms of investment and innovation procurement.



UMEÅ SCHOOL OF BUSINESS,
ECONOMICS AND STATISTICS
UMEÅ UNIVERSITY

Business Administration SE-901 87 Umeå
www.usbe.umu.se